

Resource: Study Notes (Tyndale)

Aquifer Open Study Notes

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Study Notes (Tyndale)

GEN

Genesis 1:1

In the beginning God created the heavens and the earth: This statement summarizes the entire creation account ([1:3–2:3](#)). Already a key question—Who created the world?—is answered (see also [Prov 8:22–31](#); [John 1:1–3](#)). Although the modern naturalistic mindset rejects this question and that of creation's purpose, Genesis affirms God's role and purpose in creation. • The common name for God (Hebrew 'elohim) emphasizes his grand supremacy. The word 'elohim is plural, but the verbs used with it are usually singular, reflecting the consistent scriptural proclamation of a single, all-powerful God. • created (Hebrew bara'): In the Old Testament, God is always the agent of creation expressed by this verb. It describes the making of something fresh and new—notably the cosmos ([1:1](#), [21](#); [2:3](#)), humankind ([1:27](#)), the Israelite nation ([Isa 43:1](#)), and the future new creation ([Isa 65:17](#)). • The heavens and the earth are the entire ordered cosmos.

Genesis 1:1–2:3

These verses introduce the Pentateuch (Genesis—Deuteronomy) and teach Israel that the world was created, ordered, and populated by the one true God and not by the gods of surrounding nations. • God blessed three specific things: animal life ([1:22–25](#)), human life ([1:27](#)), and the Sabbath day ([2:3](#)). This trilogy of blessings highlights the Creator's plan: Humankind was made in God's image to enjoy sovereign dominion over the creatures of the earth and to participate in God's Sabbath rest.

Genesis 1:2

This verse gives the background for the summary in [1:1](#) and the detailed description in [1:3–2:3](#). God's creative utterances bring order to the chaotic state

of the universe. • formless . . . empty (Hebrew tohu . . . bohu): This terse idiom means something like “wild and waste.” It sets a stark contrast to the final ordered state of the heavens and the earth ([1:1](#)). • deep waters (Hebrew tehom): Some scholars say this alludes to the Mesopotamian goddess Tiamat (representing chaos), but Genesis views tehom as inhospitable chaos, not as a deity or goddess that God engaged in cosmic battle. • the Spirit of God: God directly superintended the creation process.

Genesis 1:3

Then God said: Nothing in ch [1](#) is created apart from God's powerful word (cp. [Ps 33:6](#), [9](#)). • “Let there be . . .” and there was: God's command enacted his will to create the world. God is not a part of creation or limited by it; he is the supreme ruler over everything (cp. [Neh 9:6](#)).

Genesis 1:3–13

In the first three days, God formed the chaos into a habitable world.

Genesis 1:4

Light is antithetical to chaotic darkness ([1:2](#)); the light is declared good but the darkness is not (cp. [John 1:5](#)). God is the source of this light (cp. [Gen 1:14–19](#)). God separated the light, as he did water (cp. [1:6–8](#)), by his creative word. Light is associated with life and blessing ([Job 38:19–20](#); [Pss 19:1–6](#); [97:11](#); [104:19–20](#); [Isa 60:19–20](#)) and sets a boundary on the darkness that would destroy cosmic order. Darkness often typifies terror, death, and evil (see [Gen 15:12](#); [Job 18:6, 18](#); [Ps 88:12](#); [Eph 5:11–12](#); [1 Jn 1:5](#)).

Genesis 1:5

God called (or *named*): To name something is to exercise authority over it (see also [2:19-20](#)). • day: The Hebrew *yom* can refer to daylight ([1:5a](#)), to a 24-hour period ([1:5b](#)), or to an unspecified time period ([2:4b](#), “When,” literally *in the day*; cp. [Exod 20:8-11](#)). • evening . . . morning: The Hebrew day began at sundown, just as the first day began with darkness and brought the first morning light.

Genesis 1:6-8

The creation account describes the appearance of things from a human perspective. The sky is viewed as a shiny dome that is a buffer between two collections of water (cp. [Job 37:18](#); [Ezek 1:22](#)). In the ancient Near East, the cosmos was understood as a three-tier system, with rain originating from the outermost tier (see [Gen 7:11-12](#) and study note).

Genesis 1:9-10

Let the waters . . . flow together: Other ancient cultures viewed the sea as a hostile force. Genesis shows God as further restraining chaos (see study note on 1:2) by prescribing specific boundaries for the sea. The flood—an act of God’s judgment ([6:7](#))—undid these boundaries and returned the earth to chaos ([7:1-24](#)).

Genesis 1:14

Let them . . . mark the seasons, days, and years: The movement of the heavenly bodies defined Israel’s liturgical calendar, whose roots in creation gave a sacred timing to Israel’s festivals and celebrations (see [Exod 23:15](#); [Lev 23:4](#)).

Genesis 1:14-31

On days 4-6, God filled the domains that had been formed during days 1-3 ([1:3-13](#)).

Genesis 1:16

In the surrounding pagan cultures, the two great lights were worshiped as deities, but in Genesis

they serve God and humanity (see [Ps 136:7-9](#); [Jer 31:35](#)). The sun and moon are not named; they are simply called the larger one and the smaller one. Not including their names may have reminded Israel that they were not gods. • govern: Cp. [1:26, 28](#); [Ps 136:9](#). • the stars: The starry heavens testify to God’s creative power as they proclaim his glory ([Pss 19:1](#); [148:3](#)). They do not predict the future, as Israel’s neighbors believed (see [Jer 10:2](#)).

Genesis 1:21

Contrary to the pagan idea that the great sea creatures were co-eternal with God, Genesis states that God created them and is sovereign over them. The Hebrew word *tanninim* (“creatures”) elsewhere refers to crocodiles ([Ezek 29:3](#)), powerful monsters ([Jer 51:34](#)), or the sea creature Leviathan ([Isa 27:1](#); cp. [Job 41:1-34](#)).

Genesis 1:22

God blessed them: God’s blessing commissions and enables the fulfillment of what God has spoken (see “Blessing” Theme Note). • Let the fish . . . let the birds: These directives define the blessing. The fish and birds are fertile by God’s command, not by pagan ritual, as some of Israel’s neighbors thought.

Genesis 1:26

Let us make is more personal than the remote “Let there be” (e.g., [1:3, 6](#)). • The plural *us* has inspired several explanations: (1) the Trinity; (2) the plural to denote majesty; (3) a plural to show deliberation with the self; and (4) God speaking with his heavenly court of angels. The concept of the Trinity—one true God who exists eternally in three distinct persons—was revealed at a later stage in redemptive history, making it unlikely that the human author intended that here. Hebrew scholars generally dismiss the plural of majesty view because the grammar does not clearly support it (the plural of majesty has not been demonstrated to be communicated purely through a plural verb). The plural of self-deliberation also lacks evidence; the only clear examples refer to Israel as a corporate unity (e.g., [2 Sam 24:14](#)). God’s speaking to the heavenly court, however, is well-attested in the Old Testament (see [Gen 3:22](#); [11:7](#); [1 Kgs 22:19-22](#); [Job 1:6-12](#); [2:1-6](#); [38:7](#); [Ps 89:5-6](#); [Isa](#)

[6:1–8](#); [Dan 10:12–13](#)). • The descriptors in our image and like us are virtually synonymous in Hebrew. Humans enjoy a unique relationship with God. • They will reign: Humans represent the Creator as his ambassadors, vice-regents, and administrators on earth.

Genesis 1:27

The first poetry of Genesis reflectively celebrates God's climactic feat in creating humankind. • human beings: This term (Hebrew *ha-'adam*, "the man") is often used to denote humanity collectively (see [6:1](#), [5–7](#); [9:5–6](#)). Though traditionally translated "man," gender is not at issue here; both male and female are included.

Genesis 1:28

God blessed them: See study note on 1:22; see also [17:16](#); [48:16](#); [Deut 7:13](#). • said: God's message to humankind is direct and intimate; we are stewards of his delegated authority. • govern. . . . Reign: As God's vice-regents, humans are entrusted with the care and management of the world God created (see also [Gen 9:2](#); [Ps 8:5–8](#)).

Genesis 1:29–30

These verses highlight the extent (throughout the earth) and variety (every seed-bearing plant . . . all the fruit trees) of God's provision for humans, animals, and birds.

Genesis 1:31

The Creator declares his work good seven times in ch [1](#); following the creation of human beings, God declares it all very good.

Genesis 2:1–3

Humankind is the high point of God's creative acts ([1:26–31](#)), while day 7 is the climax of the creation week. When God rested, he endorsed all of creation—there was nothing more to do! This seven-day framework structured Israel's week, with the seventh day as the precedent for their weekly Sabbath. The Sabbath was intended to

celebrate God's finished work; the seventh day would be set apart as holy and dedicated to the Creator, who also rested (see [Exod 20:8–11](#); [31:12–17](#); cp. [Matt 12:1–8](#); [Rom 14:5–6](#); [Col 2:16–17](#); [Heb 4:1–11](#)).

Genesis 2:3

The first six days of creation involved separation (light from darkness, day from night, water from dry land). The last act of creation separated what is ordinary from what is holy, thus laying the foundation for Israel's worship. It also anticipated a coming age of rest ([Heb 4:1–11](#); [12:2](#); [13:14](#)). • The absence of the usual "morning and evening" reflects the Creator's willingness to enter into unending fellowship with humankind.

Genesis 2:4

This is the account (literally *These are the generations*; Hebrew *toledoth*): This or a similar phrase is repeated throughout Genesis, creating an internal outline for the book. In other occurrences, it introduces the genealogy or story of a key personality ([5:1](#); [6:9](#); [10:1](#); [11:10](#), [27](#); [25:12](#), [19](#); [36:1](#); [37:2](#)). • Some have argued that the first half of [2:4](#) belongs with [1:1–2:3](#), but it is more likely the introduction to the account that follows. • Lord God (Hebrew *Yahweh Elohim*) is the second name used for God in the early chapters of Genesis. *Elohim* ([1:1–2:3](#)) describes the all-powerful creator God. *Yahweh Elohim* speaks of the eternal God who formed a lasting covenant with Israel ([Exod 3:6](#), [13–15](#)). Accordingly, [Gen 2:4–25](#) focuses on God as provider more than as creator. The three themes of sexuality, dominion, and food in ch [1](#) are now addressed in reverse order (food, [2:8–17](#); dominion, [2:18–20](#); sexuality, [2:21–25](#)).

Genesis 2:4–25

This account (see study note on 2:4) of the heavens and the earth is not a second creation account; rather, it is a theological and historical expansion on [1:1–2:3](#). The focus is now on what the cosmos produced rather than on its creation. Special attention is given to the first man and woman. As the story progresses, it is colored by contrasts of good and evil, knowledge and ignorance, life and death, harmony and discord.

Genesis 2:5

Work does not result from sin; it was part of the original structure of creation and is directly tied to human identity and purpose ([1:28](#); [2:15](#)).

Genesis 2:6

springs: The word refers to subterranean springs that rose to the surface of the ground.

Genesis 2:7

In [1:1–2:3](#), creation happens at a distance, by divine command (“Let there be . . . and that is what happened”). In this account, the creative act is much more intimate (see also [2:8–9](#), [21–22](#)). • from the dust of the ground: In Hebrew, ‘adamah (“ground”) forms a wordplay with ‘adam (“man”). The earth remains the definitive reference point for humans, who in death return to dust ([3:17–19](#); [4:11](#); [Job 4:19](#); [10:8–9](#); [Isa 29:16](#)). • breathed . . . into the man’s nostrils: God’s breath is not imparted to other animals; only humans are formed in God’s image ([Gen 1:27](#)) and enjoy dialogue with their Creator ([2:16–17](#); [3:8–13](#)). They alone have spiritual awareness and moral conscience (see [Job 32:8](#)).

Genesis 2:8

Eden was the general location in which the garden was placed, not the garden itself. The term could mean “plain,” “delight,” or “fertility.” The description that follows favors the idea of fertility. • in the east: The exact location of Eden is left to speculation, but it was east of Canaan, Israel’s later home. • God placed the man in the garden for divine fellowship and physical blessing (see also [2:15](#) and study note there).

Genesis 2:8–14

Analogous to the sacred time marked out on the seventh day of creation ([2:2–3](#)), the sacred space of the garden in Eden was separate from the surrounding world. It functioned as a garden-

temple or sanctuary because the Lord manifested his presence there in a special way.

Genesis 2:9

Beauty and bounty characterized humanity’s original environment (cp. [13:10](#)). • The tree of life represented God’s presence and provision. The one who ate of it would have everlasting life ([3:22](#)), which made it a rich image for later Israelite and Christian reflection ([Prov 3:18](#); [11:30](#); [13:12](#); [Rev 2:7](#); [22:2](#), [14](#), [19](#)). The candlestick in Israel’s Tabernacle may have been a stylized representation of it ([Exod 25:31–35](#)). • Eating the fruit of the tree of the knowledge of good and evil enabled humanity’s capacity for wisdom ([Gen 3:6](#)) and moral discernment ([3:5](#), [22](#); cp. [Deut 1:39](#), “innocent”). Eating from it represented a human grasp for autonomy and wisdom that were God’s alone (cp. [Prov 30:1–4](#)). Humans sidestepped God’s revelation as the means of moral discernment, flaunting their independence rather than submitting to God’s will (cp. [Prov 1:7](#)). Choosing human wisdom over God’s instruction brings death and destruction (see [Ps 19:7–9](#); [Ezek 28:6](#), [15–17](#)).

Genesis 2:10

The river that was watering the garden was a material blessing (bringing agricultural fertility) and a symbol of God’s presence (cp. [Ps 46:4](#); [Ezek 47:1–12](#); [Zech 14:8](#); [Rev 22:1–2](#)). • dividing into four branches (literally *heads*): The common understanding is that one river had its source in Eden, flowed down through the garden, and then split into the four rivers named.

Genesis 2:10–14

This detailed description portrays the eastern region around Eden as a mountain with rivers flowing out to the world. Eden’s beauty and fertility enriched the whole earth.

Genesis 2:11

The Pishon and the Gihon ([2:13](#)) cannot be identified with certainty. If the land of Havilah was in southeast Arabia or on the African coast, as some biblical data suggest (see [10:7](#); [25:18](#); [1 Sam 15:7](#)),

then the Pishon was possibly the Nile River. Josephus thought that Havilah and the Pishon were in India (*Antiquities* 1.1.3). Two other proposals suggest: (1) rivers in the mountains of eastern Turkey where the Tigris and Euphrates ([Gen 2:14](#)) also flow, and (2) the marshy delta near the Persian Gulf. Current geographical conditions make any theory impossible to prove conclusively.

Genesis 2:12

The magnificence and fertility of the garden are pictured as spreading to the surrounding regions through the rivers flowing out from it. The four rivers possibly imply that the garden's bounty flowed out to the four corners of the earth. • Gold and onyx were later used for decorating the Tabernacle, the Temple ([Exod 25:3–9](#); [1 Chr 29:2](#)), and the priests' clothing ([Exod 28:9–14](#), [20](#)). • Resin was used in sacred incense ([Exod 30:34](#)).

Genesis 2:13

Gihon: Though unknown, proposals have included the Nile (as in the Greek version of [Jer 2:18](#); Josephus, *Antiquities* 1.1.3), the Jordan, or, according to Jewish tradition, a river that formerly ran through the Kidron Valley ([1 Kgs 1:33](#); [2 Chr 33:14](#)). • Although Cush is the name of ancient Ethiopia, Mesopotamian regions associated with Babylon seem to be the immediate setting (see [10:8](#)); Cush is possibly the land of the Kassites, a dynasty ruling in Babylonia.

Genesis 2:14

Tigris . . . Euphrates: These well-known rivers flow from the mountains of eastern Turkey.

Genesis 2:15

to tend and watch over: The garden required maintenance and oversight. Tending the Garden was humanity's dignifying work. These roles in God's garden-sanctuary were later applied to God's Tabernacle (see [Lev 8:35](#); [Num 3:5–10](#); [4:46–49](#)).

Genesis 2:17

except (literally *but you must not eat*): This prohibition is given in the same legal format as Israel's Ten Commandments (see [Exod 20:1–17](#); [Deut 5:6–21](#)). The Lord built law and obedience into the fabric of his covenant relationship with humanity. • the knowledge of good and evil: See study note on 2:9. • you are sure to die: The consequences of disobedience would be immediate spiritual death (loss of relationship with God) and eventual physical death (see [3:22–23](#); [Eccl 12:6–7](#)).

Genesis 2:18

It is not good: This is God's first negative assessment of an otherwise excellent creation ([1:31](#)). The Lord God is portrayed as a father who obtains a bride for his son (cp. ch [24](#)). • The answer to the man's need is a helper who is just right for him; she is his perfect complement, made in the same image of God ([1:26–27](#)), given the same commission ([1:28](#); [2:15](#)), and obligated by the same prohibition ([2:17](#)). The man cannot fulfill his created purpose alone.

Genesis 2:18–23

As human creation was the climax of ch [1](#), so human intimacy is the high point of ch [2](#). God's concern for mutual human support and companionship finds no parallel in ancient Near Eastern literature.

Genesis 2:19–20

to see what he would call them: Following God's example ([1:5](#), [8](#), [10](#)), the man chose a name for each of the creatures. In so doing, he was exercising his reign over creation ([1:26](#), [28](#)).

Genesis 2:23

Adam recognized the woman as a "helper just right for him" ([2:20](#)). His celebration of her in poetry and song observed his unity with her, not their distinctions (cp. [29:14](#)). • Adam declares that "She will be called 'woman' (Hebrew 'ishah) because she was taken from 'man' (Hebrew 'ish)." He understood the nature of their connection (see [Eph](#)

[5:28-29](#)). Adam had earlier assessed the animals without finding the characteristics he needed in a partner. How different this evaluation is!

Genesis 2:24

Marriage between a man and a woman is not just a human social construct but is rooted in the created order. • a man leaves . . . and is joined: Marriage entails a shift of loyalty from parents to spouse. • the two are united into one: Marriage and its commitments make it the most fundamental covenant relationship observed among humans. Marriage is a powerful image of Israel's covenant with God ([Hos 2:14-23](#)) and of Christ's relationship to the church ([Eph 5:22-32](#)). Marriage is designed as an inseparable, exclusive relationship between a man and a woman. The family unit it creates is the basic building block of human society.

Genesis 2:25

both naked: Prior to the Fall (ch 3), nakedness reflected innocence and trust. After the Fall, it denoted vulnerability and shame (see [9:22-23](#); [Lev 18:1-23](#); [Isa 47:3](#)). Shame is more than embarrassment; it connotes exploitation and humiliation (see [Deut 28:48](#); [Isa 58:7](#); [Jas 2:15-16](#)).

Genesis 3:1

Genesis describes the deceiver as a serpent, one of the animals God created (see also [3:14](#) and study note). He is later identified as Satan, the great enemy of God's people ([Rev 12:9](#); [20:2](#)). His manipulative language and his disguise as a serpent, the shrewdest of all creatures, show him as a master deceiver. Satan has various methods for opposing God's people (see [1 Chr 21:1](#); [Zech 3:1-2](#)); deception remains among his key strategies (cp. [2 Cor 11:3, 14](#)). The Hebrew term for shrewd ('arum) can be positive ("prudent," [Prov 14:8](#)) or negative (as here; see [Job 5:12](#)). It forms a wordplay with "naked" ('arummim) in [Gen 2:25](#). Adam and Eve were naked and vulnerable; the serpent was shrewd and cunning. • Probably the serpent asked the woman because the prohibition was given to Adam prior to Eve's creation (see [2:16-17](#)). Adam was probably aware of the serpent's cunning, having assessed and named all the animals before Eve was created ([2:19-20, 23](#)).

• Did God really say? The deceiver began by twisting God's language to cast doubt on God's goodness. God's original prohibition applied to only one tree ([2:16-17](#)), not to all (any) of them.

Genesis 3:1-24

The rebellion of the man and the woman shattered their unity and harmony with earth, animals, each other, and God.

Genesis 3:2-3

The woman attempted to set the record straight; in the process, she belittled the privileges God had given her and her husband in several ways: (1) She reduced God's "freely eat" ([2:16](#)) to may eat; (2) she downplayed God's emphasis on the availability of fruit from every tree but one ([2:17](#)); (3) she added not touching to God's prohibition against eating ([2:17](#)); and (4) she softened the certainty of death ([2:17](#)).

Genesis 3:4-5

You won't die! This is the exact negation of God's clear and emphatic words: "you are sure to die" ([2:17](#)). The serpent capitalizes on the woman's uncertainty by baldly denying the penalty and quickly diverting her attention to the supposed prize—to be like God, knowing both good and evil. The deceiver falsely implies that this would be an unqualified good for them. The term rendered God is Elohim; it can also mean "divine beings" (i.e., God and the angels; e.g., [Pss 29:1](#); [89:7](#)).

Genesis 3:6

- *She saw ... that it was desirable:* The woman made two serious mistakes:
 1. She assumed she could decide what was good or bad. But God is the only one who has the right to decide what is good or bad.

2. She coveted God's wisdom, meaning she strongly desired something that did not belong to her (see [Deuteronomy 5:21](#)).
- *her husband who was with her:* Scripture highlights the woman's role in humanity's first sin (compare [1 Timothy 2:14](#)). But, the man was also present and responsible. He becomes the focus in the following verses and in biblical teaching. His sin brought serious consequences for all people. The good news is that through Jesus Christ, the "second Adam," God offers salvation to everyone ([Romans 5:12-21](#)).

Genesis 3:7

Shame is opposite to the naked innocence Adam and Eve enjoyed prior to their rebellion ([2:25](#)). Their relationship with one another and with God was fractured. • sewed fig leaves together: These covered their physical bodies, but not their shame. They could not mend their broken relationships (see also [3:21](#) and study note).

Genesis 3:8

When the cool evening breezes were blowing: The Hebrew has traditionally been interpreted as referring to the cool part of the day, most likely the evening. Others think that the language refers to a powerful manifestation of God's presence (a *theophany*; see [Exod 19:16-25](#); [1 Sam 7:10](#)) as a storm. If this view is correct, the man and the woman were hiding from the sound of the Lord appearing in judgment (see [2 Sam 5:24](#); [Ps 29](#)). • God put trees in the garden as an environment for humanity to enjoy fellowship with God. Now the man and woman used them to evade the divine presence.

Genesis 3:9-10

Where are you? The true intent of this rhetorical question is revealed in the man's answer ([3:10](#)). The real question was, why are you hiding? (cp.

[4:9-10](#)). • I was afraid because I was naked: Modesty was not the issue. The shame brought on by rebellion drove Adam and his wife to hide. Possibly they also feared punishment (see study note on [3:8](#)).

Genesis 3:12

It was the woman you gave me: Rather than confessing, the man became evasive. He blamed the woman for giving him the fruit and God for giving him the woman.

Genesis 3:13

What have you done? is another rhetorical question that is really an exclamation of horror (cp. [4:10](#)). • The serpent deceived me: As the man implicated the woman ([3:12](#)), the woman accused the serpent. The serpent did play a role and would be punished ([3:14](#)), but that did not release the woman or the man from their guilt.

Genesis 3:14

to the serpent: Though later revelation identifies the deceiver as Satan, it is the created animal who was cursed, like the ground ([3:17](#)). • Groveling in the dust reflects a posture of humiliation and defeat ([Ps 72:9](#); [Mic 7:17](#)).

Genesis 3:14-19

The parties were judged in the order of their transgression—serpent, woman, man. Each received a punishment unique to his or her situation, and each had a key relationship altered. God is principled in judgment, not fickle; each punishment is proportionate to the offense.

Genesis 3:15

hostility: The prophet Isaiah envisions the day when the Messiah's kingdom will restore all of creation to a harmonious state like the Garden of Eden before humans sinned (see [Isa 11:8](#)). • her offspring (literally *her seed*): This collective noun can refer to a single descendant or many. The ancient Near Eastern concept of corporate

solidarity (e.g., “you and your descendants,” [Gen 28:14](#)) is also behind this description of the ongoing hostility that would exist between humans and snakes. The pattern is set using singular terms (He . . . you). Christian interpreters have traditionally understood this verse as a prophecy of Christ, the seed of Abraham and the culmination of the woman’s seed ([Gal 3:16; 4:4](#)). • strike: The striking of his heel is a reference to the suffering of God’s servant (see [Isa 53](#)), while striking the serpent’s head—a more definitive blow—is ultimately fulfilled in Christ’s death, resurrection, and final victory over Satan ([1 Cor 15:55–57](#); [Rev 12:7–9; 20:7–10](#)).

Genesis 3:16

Judgment falls on the woman’s unique role of childbearing and on her relationship with her husband. • And you will desire to control your husband, but he will rule over you: The marriage relationship now included an element of antagonism rather than just security and fulfillment. New life in Christ allows for the restoration of a man and a woman’s marriage relationship ([Eph 5:18–32](#); cp. [Matt 20:25–28](#)).

Genesis 3:17–19

God highlighted his original command not to eat the fruit by speaking of eating several times in [3:17–19](#). The judgment affected humanity’s ability to get food, and it was proportionate to their offense of eating what had been prohibited. • the ground is cursed: The relationship of the man to the ground (see study note on 2:7) was now antagonistic as judgment fell on his primary role ([2:5, 15](#)). He must labor and toil to work the ground, but with diminished productivity. Human sin has broad effects on creation (see [4:12; 6:7; Lev 26; Deut 11:13–17, 28; Rom 8:22](#)).

Genesis 3:20

Eve (Hebrew khawah) sounds like a Hebrew term (khayah) that means “to give life.” Following God’s pronouncement of Adam’s impending death ([3:19](#)), Adam expressed hope by giving Eve a name associated with life. Adam’s naming of Eve in such close proximity to [3:16](#) may suggest that the narrator views it as Adam’s first act of ruling over

the woman after the Fall (see study note on 2:19–20).

Genesis 3:20–24

Soon after they were judged for their sin, Adam and Eve were banished from the garden.

Genesis 3:21

God mercifully provided more substantial clothing for Adam and Eve (cp. [3:7](#)) before expelling them into the harsh environment outside the garden.

Genesis 3:22

like us: The plural probably reflects God’s conversation with his angelic court (see study note on 1:26). • the tree of life . . . live forever! Mercifully, God prevented humankind from eating of the tree of life and having to live forever in a fallen state. Through Jesus Christ, however, eternal life is once again made available (see [Rev 2:7; 22:2, 14, 19](#)).

Genesis 3:23

So the Lord God banished them from the Garden of Eden: Before the Fall, the garden was a sanctuary in which humans could move freely in God’s holy presence. Now their sin required expulsion from that environment. This same principle was behind the laws that restricted an Israelite’s access to God’s presence in the Tabernacle or Temple (e.g., [Lev 16:1–2; Num 5:3](#)).

Genesis 3:24

Cherubim are a class of angelic beings that guard access to God’s presence ([Exod 26:31; Ezek 28:14](#)). • east . . . of Eden: In Genesis, movement eastward often implies leaving the presence or blessing of God, whether in judgment (see also [Gen 4:16](#)), self-aggrandizement ([11:2; 13:11](#)), or estrangement ([25:6](#)).

Genesis 4:1

had sexual relations (literally *knew*): In certain contexts, the Hebrew term meaning “to know” is an idiom for sexual knowledge of another person ([4:17](#); [19:33](#), [35](#)). It is never used of animals, which mate by instinct. • With the Lord’s help: Eve fulfilled her God-given role of procreation despite the negative effects of the Fall (see [3:16](#), [20](#)). • I have produced: *Cain* (Hebrew *qayin*) sounds like a Hebrew term (*qanah*) that can mean “produce” or “acquire.”

Genesis 4:2

Cain's brother Abel: The name “Abel” may come from the Hebrew word *habel*, meaning “breath,” “vapor,” or “meaningless.” This might hint at Abel’s tragically short life (compare [Ecclesiastes 1:2](#)). Alternatively, it may come from the Akkadian word *ablu*, meaning “son.”

Genesis 4:3

There was nothing wrong with offering grain to the Lord ([Leviticus 2:14](#); [Deuteronomy 26:2-4](#)). But Cain only gave a small portion of his crops. God requires the first and best ([Exodus 23:16](#), [19](#); [34:22](#), [26](#)). Cain’s attitude made his offering less valuable than Abel’s ([Hebrews 11:4](#)). So, God did not accept Cain’s offering.

Genesis 4:4-5

the best portions of the firstborn lambs: Or *the firstborn of his flock and their fat portions*. Abel was giving God the best animals and the richest parts. Abel’s offering, in contrast to Cain’s, was the best he had to offer. True worship is a costly privilege.

Genesis 4:7

Sin is crouching at the door . . . you must subdue it: Sin is pictured as a vicious animal lying in wait to pounce on Cain (cp. study note on [3:16](#)). Either sin will dominate Cain, or Cain will resist the temptation to sin. There is no neutral ground in that conflict.

Genesis 4:8

The effects of the Fall on human relationships are tragically expressed in the first murder. • The word brother is used seven times in [4:2-11](#), highlighting Cain’s fratricide in the face of familial responsibility.

Genesis 4:9

Where is your brother? The questions God asked Cain ([4:6](#), [9](#), [10](#)) recall those that God asked Cain’s parents ([3:9-13](#)). In both cases, humans put up evasive answers (cp. [3:12-13](#)). Cain’s answer is shockingly defiant—another clue that the problem with his token offering was the attitude that lay behind it.

Genesis 4:10

What have you done? is more an expression of horror and rebuke than a fact-finding question (cp. [3:13](#)). • Abel’s blood is personified as a legal witness that cries out against Cain. • from the ground: See study note on [4:11-12](#).

Genesis 4:11-12

As with his father (cp. [3:9-12](#), [17-19](#)), Cain’s interrogation ([4:9-10](#)) was followed by God’s verdict. Adam’s sin had already caused the ground to be cursed. Now Cain was cursed and banished from the land he farmed because he had contaminated it with innocent blood. • homeless wanderer: Cain was condemned to ceaseless roving in a land that would provide neither sustenance nor security. The effects of sin were escalating.

Genesis 4:13-14

For Cain, eviction from the land—the domain of his vocation as a farmer (see [4:2](#); cp. [3:23](#))—amounted to exile from God’s presence. The Israelites were warned that unfaithfulness to the Sinai covenant would similarly result in eviction from the Promised Land and from God’s presence in the Temple (see, e.g., [Lev 26:27-32](#)).

Genesis 4:15

Sevenfold punishment was the full weight of justice. Cain complained that his punishment was too great, but the full sentence that would fall on anyone who committed Cain's crime against him shows how gracious the Lord was to Cain. Cain deserved death (see [9:5-6](#)). • The mark graciously provided protection following Cain's judgment (cp. [3:21](#)).

Genesis 4:16

The name Nod speaks more of Cain's fate (see [4:12, 14](#)) than of a specific geographical area (the location is unknown). Cain's sin denied him rest and a sense of belonging. • Cain's exile east of Eden is another point of connection with Adam's story (cp. [3:24](#)). Cain did not learn from his father's mistake, so he also suffered estrangement from the ground and exile to the east (see study note on [3:24](#)).

Genesis 4:17

Cain's wife was probably one of his sisters ([5:4](#)). Cain's marriage to his sister would not have caused genetic problems so early in the development of the human gene pool. • Cain was condemned to be a wanderer. Perhaps he founded a city in rebellion against that verdict, seeking to defend himself by enclosing it in walls. Naming it after his son reflects a tendency among those who rebel against God to idolize humanity and its achievements.

Genesis 4:17-5:32

These back-to-back genealogies do more than list names for the record. They contrast the ways that human culture spread, some in rebellion against God (Cain, [4:17-24](#)) and some in obedience to God (Seth, [4:25-5:32](#)). In Genesis, the history of the rejected branch is generally explained before carrying forward the line that led to Israel. Two points of contrast are especially worth noting: (1) Lamech, the seventh from Adam through the lineage of Cain, is the main focus of the first genealogy. Like his ancestor, Lamech took human life and had to live in constant fear of death as a consequence ([4:23-24](#)). By contrast, Enoch, the seventh from Adam through the lineage of Seth

(see [4:25-5:32](#)), lived in a way that pleased God and avoided death altogether ([5:24](#)). (2) Advances in human culture and technology came through Cain's line (the first city, livestock, shelter, metallurgy, music), but the effects of sin still dominated. No technological advances are mentioned in Seth's line; instead, people began "to worship the Lord" ([4:26](#)) and to find "favor with the Lord" (see [6:8](#)).

Genesis 4:18

the father of: Or *the ancestor of*, and so throughout the verse. Hebrew genealogies do not necessarily list every single generation.

Genesis 4:19

Marrying two women was contrary to God's ideal pattern for marriage ([2:24](#)) and might be another manifestation of the arrogance and rebellion of Cain's descendants.

Genesis 4:20-22

Technological advancement masks increasing self-assertion and distance from God (see study note on [4:17-5:32](#)).

Genesis 4:23-24

Lamech's chilling taunt shows the further escalation of sin's effects on humanity. Cain's line had reached a crescendo of violence with Lamech's contempt for life. In his arrogance, he put his deed into poetic verse. • punished seventy-seven times! God warned that anyone who tried to kill Cain would experience the full weight of justice ([4:15](#)). Lamech's declaration that anyone who harmed him would receive an even more severe penalty is a claim to be accountable to no one, including God.

Genesis 4:25

another son in place of Abel: Cain ([4:8-16](#)) and Lamech ([4:19-24](#)) illustrate sin's consequences; the birth of Seth brought renewed hope. See also study note on [5:1-2](#).

Genesis 4:25–5:32

The story returns to Adam and follows the line of Seth, whose lineage led to Abraham and the Israelite nation.

Genesis 4:26

Enosh means “humankind.” In the Old Testament, the term is often used in poetic texts that emphasize human mortality, frailty, and weakness (e.g., [Ps 144:3](#), “mere mortals”). Enosh was born at the time when people began to worship the Lord by name (literally *call on the name of the Lord*). In Genesis, that meant calling on the name of the Lord through sacrifice and prayer (similar Hebrew terminology is found in [Gen 12:8](#); [13:4](#); [21:33](#); [26:25](#)).

Genesis 5:1

written account: Although the previous account ([2:4–4:26](#)) focused on Adam, Eve, and their first children, it was technically “the account of the ... heavens and the earth.” [Genesis 5:1–32](#) is a more typical genealogy. • like himself: See [1:26](#) and study note.

Genesis 5:1–2

This is the prologue to the second account in Genesis ([5:1–6:8](#); see study note on 2:4); it connects God’s purpose in creation with Seth’s line rather than Cain’s ([4:17–24](#)).

Genesis 5:1–32

The genealogies of Genesis go beyond simply recording history. By selective information and by structure, they communicate spiritual truth. The genealogies highlight God’s blessing, authenticate the family heritage of important individuals, and hold the Genesis narrative together by showing familial continuity. Adam’s genealogy through Seth traces ten generations to Noah (see [1 Chr 1:1–4](#); [Luke 3:36–38](#)), with the flood intervening before another ten generations from Noah to Abram. The number ten indicates completeness (ten plagues,

[Exod 7:8–11:10](#); Ten Commandments, [Exod 20:2–17](#)). Noah closed history before the flood, and Abram inaugurated a new era.

Genesis 5:2

male and female . . . “human” (Hebrew ’adam): See [1:27](#) and study note. • blessed them: See [1:28](#) and study note.

Genesis 5:3

in his own likeness, after his own image: The image and likeness of God continue to exist in all human beings even after sin entered the world (see note on [1:26](#)). When Adam had children, they carried both the image of God and the effects of Adam’s sin ([Romans 5:12–14](#)).

Genesis 5:5

he died: Death indeed came to Adam (see [2:17](#); [3:18–19](#)) and his descendants (see [Rom 5:12–14](#)). Cain’s violence is omitted (see [Gen 4:8, 15, 23–24](#)) and key figures in Seth’s line live in hope ([5:29](#)).

Genesis 5:6

the father of: Or *the ancestor of*; Hebrew genealogies do not necessarily list every single generation.

Genesis 5:22

Enoch lived in close fellowship with God (literally *Enoch walked with God*; also in [5:24](#)): Enoch’s position as seventh from Adam in the genealogy strikes a contrast with Lamech, the seventh from Adam in the line of Cain (see study note on 4:17–5:32).

Genesis 5:24

Unlike all other sons of Adam, Enoch did not succumb to death; rather, he disappeared, because God took him (cp. [2 Kgs 2:9–12](#); see also [Heb 11:5](#)).

Genesis 5:27

969 years: This statement and the numbers given in [5:25](#), [28](#) and [7:6](#) mean that Methuselah died in the year of the flood.

Genesis 5:28–29

As with Enoch ([5:21–24](#)), the normal genealogical formula is interrupted to highlight important theological information about Noah. Noah sounds like Hebrew *nakh*, “relief” or “comfort,” and *nuakh*, “rest.” As the first person born after Adam’s death (see study note on 5:5), Noah prompted his father Lamech to hope that the curse brought on by Adam’s sin ([3:17](#)) might be lifted. See [8:21](#); [2 Cor 1:3–7](#); [2 Thes 2:16–17](#).

Genesis 6:1–2

The sons of God have generally been understood as fallen angels (cp. the same Hebrew phrase in [Job 1:6](#); [2:1](#); [38:7](#); [Pss 29:1](#); [89:7](#)). This interpretation is prominent in ancient Jewish and Christian literature (e.g., *1 Enoch* 6:1–7:6; Justin Martyr, *Apology* 2.5) and is apparently supported by the New Testament (see [1 Pet 3:18–20](#); [2 Pet 2:4](#); [Jude 1:6–7](#)). Some interpreters do not believe that God would permit angels to procreate with humans and doubt that the above New Testament texts should be read in this way. Another possibility is that *sons of God* refers to the righteous descendants of Seth, while the beautiful women were female descendants of Cain’s wicked line. This interpretation is in harmony with [Gen 4:17–5:32](#) but is weakened by the language of [6:1–2](#), which seems to refer to the daughters of humanity in general, not the daughters of Cain specifically. Others believe that *sons of God* refers to tyrannical human kings (possibly demon-possessed) who took Lamech’s polygamy ([4:19](#)) to a new height of wickedness by seizing the daughters of the righteous. Language reminiscent of [3:6](#) (saw . . . took) shows the rebellious nature of this act.

Genesis 6:1–8

Human wickedness reached a climax, prompting God to send the flood to destroy all living things. A glimmer of hope appears in God’s favor toward Noah ([6:8](#)).

Genesis 6:3

will not put up with: Many think that this is an announcement of God’s decision to withdraw the restraining influence of his Spirit from human society and allow human wickedness to run its full course. Others think it means that God would withdraw his life-giving breath from humans at an earlier age (*ruakh*, the Hebrew term for “spirit,” can also mean “breath”; see [6:17](#); [7:22](#); see also [Ps 104:29–30](#)). • normal lifespan will be no more than 120 years (literally *his days will be 120 years*): It is possible that this was a new restriction on the number of years individuals would generally be allowed to live (so the NLT). However, for generations after the flood, humans lived well beyond 120 years (see, e.g., [Gen 11:10–26](#)). An alternative interpretation sees this as a 120-year grace period before the arrival of the flood (see [Jon 3:4](#); [Matt 24:37–38](#); [1 Pet 3:20](#); [2 Pet 2:5](#)).

Genesis 6:4

giant Nephilites (Hebrew *nephilim*): The term may mean “fallen ones.” The context implies that they were the offspring of the “sons of God” and would be destroyed in the flood. [Numbers 13:31–33](#) uses the same term to describe other giants who were hostile toward God’s people and would also be destroyed (see also [Deut 2:11](#), which connects the Anakite *nephilim* with another group called the *repa’im*).

Genesis 6:5

everything they thought or imagined (literally *every intention of the thoughts of their hearts*): In the Old Testament, the heart is the core of volition, thought, and morality (see [Prov 4:23](#)). Wicked actions stem from a corrupt inner life. • consistently and totally evil: Strong language captures the pervasiveness, depth, and persistence of human wickedness. Human nature continued to be corrupt even after the flood (see [Gen 8:21](#)).

Genesis 6:6

the Lord was sorry: The extent of human wickedness made the Lord regret having created

them (see also [6:7](#); cp. [1 Sam 15:11, 35](#)). • It broke his heart: The evil in humanity's heart ([Gen 6:5](#)) pained God greatly. Sending the flood was a heart-wrenching act on God's part.

Genesis 6:7

wipe . . . from the . . . earth: As Adam and Eve were banished from the garden-sanctuary ([3:23](#)), all of humankind would be expunged from God's good creation. • every living thing: Human sin had so corrupted the earth that judgment fell on the animals and birds over which they had dominion (see [1:28](#) and study note). The special role of humans in the created order ([1:28–30](#)) means that nature is affected by human moral choices (see [8:1](#); [Job 38:41](#); [Hos 4:3](#); [Rom 8:19–22](#)).

Genesis 6:8

Noah and his godly life stand in stark contrast to the sinfulness of the rest of the people.

Genesis 6:9

the account: See study note on 2:4 • a righteous man, the only blameless person: The text does not claim that Noah was without sin (see [Rom 5:12–14](#)). Noah's righteousness and blamelessness came about because he walked in close fellowship with God. See also [Gen 7:1](#); [17:1](#); [Heb 11:7](#).

Genesis 6:11–13

- See [Genesis 6:5–7](#).
- *violence*: The Hebrew word here is *khamas*. Murder had greatly corrupted Cain's descendants ([4:8, 23–24](#)).

Genesis 6:14

The large boat (traditionally rendered *ark*) was a long rectangular barge designed for survival, not for navigation. The Hebrew word *tebah* is used again only of the basket in which the baby Moses was floated on the Nile ([Exod 2:3, 5](#)). • cypress

wood: It is not clear what kind of wood this was. It was possibly from a conifer, such as cypress.

Genesis 6:15

The ark was so large that when it floated, it likely pushed aside about 43,300 tons of water. This is similar to how much water a modern large cargo ship moves aside when it floats.

Genesis 6:16

An 18-inch opening below the roof encircled the boat, providing light and air. • Noah was to build a door and God would close it ([7:16](#)). God was the captain of this peculiar boat with no sail or rudder. God also brought the animals to Noah ([6:20](#)).

Genesis 6:17

cover the earth with a flood: Some propose that the flood might only have covered the ancient Near East as it was known to Noah or Moses. However, the flood's stated purpose—to destroy every living thing that breathes (see also [6:7, 11–13](#); [7:1, 4, 18–23](#); [8:21](#))—and its effect of undoing creation (see study notes on 1:9–10; 7:11–12) suggest that the flood covered the entire planet (see also [1 Pet 3:20](#); [2 Pet 2:5](#); [3:6](#)).

Genesis 6:18

This first explicit mention of a covenant in the Bible refers to the unilateral pact that God made with humankind and the world after the flood (see [9:9, 11, 14–17](#)).

Genesis 6:19–20

God's instructions to Noah repeat the language of creation (every kind, cp. [1:24](#)). • a male and a female: These animals would procreate and repopulate the earth after the flood.

Genesis 7:2

of each animal I have approved: In addition to the animals that were to repopulate the earth, these “clean” animals were for food and for Noah’s sacrifice after the flood ([8:20–21](#)). This passage does not use the precise technical language that is found in the regulations concerning “clean” and “unclean” given to Israel at Sinai (see [Lev 11](#); [Deut 14:3–12](#)), but the underlying concept is the same (perhaps God revealed it directly to Noah).

Genesis 7:4

The number forty is often associated with affliction, trial, or punishment (see [Exod 16:35](#); [Judg 13:1](#); [1 Kgs 19:8](#); [Ezek 4:6](#); [Jon 3:4](#); [Matt 4:2](#); [Acts 1:3](#)).

Genesis 7:6

covered the earth: See study note on 6:17.

Genesis 7:8

See study note on 7:2.

Genesis 7:11–12

on the seventeenth day of the second month: Such information gives the flood account a certain solemnity; it reminds readers that this was a true historical event. • underground waters: See [2:6](#). • rain fell: The flood undid the boundaries established on the second and third days of creation ([1:6–13](#)). Elsewhere, the Bible describes God’s judgment as an undoing of creation (see [Jer 4:23–26](#); [Amos 7:4](#)). • forty days and forty nights: See study note on 7:4.

Genesis 7:16

the LORD shut him in: This showed that God was in control. He protected the people inside the ark and punished those who remained outside (see also [6:16](#) and study note).

Genesis 7:17

floodwaters grew deeper (literally *waters multiplied*): The same word used for the proliferation of humans and animals during creation (see [1:22](#), [28](#)) is now used ironically of the water that would annihilate them. • covering the ground: The Hebrew word translated “ground” or “earth” is mentioned eight times in eight verses ([7:17–24](#)). The earth is the domain that humankind had polluted and that was now the object of a cleansing deluge.

Genesis 7:22

Everything that . . . lived: See study note on 6:17.

Genesis 8:1

God remembered: This structural and theological center of the flood story does not mean that God had at any point forgotten Noah. This is covenant language reflecting God’s faithfulness to his promise to ensure the safety of his covenant partner (cp. [6:18](#); [9:15–16](#); [Exod 2:24](#); [Lev 26:42, 45](#)). • wind: The same word is translated “Spirit” in [Gen 1:2](#). This and other parallels (see [Gen 9:1–2](#)) suggest that the restoration of the earth after the flood was effectively a new creation.

Genesis 8:2

underground waters . . . torrential rains: See study note on 7:11–12.

Genesis 8:4

The mountains of Ararat might be in the region of Ararat (Urartu) southeast of the Black Sea near Lake Van, which touches parts of eastern Turkey, Armenia, and Iran. There is a Mount Ararat (*Agri Dag*) in Turkey, but this verse only identifies the region, not a specific mountain.

Genesis 8:5

the waters continued to go down: Another parallel with the creation week (see [1:9](#)) suggests that the

earth's restoration was effectively a new creation (see study note on 8:1).

Genesis 8:7

The *raven* is the biggest bird in the crow family and in Noah's time the raven was considered ceremonially unclean ([Leviticus 11:15](#); [Deuteronomy 14:14](#)). As a scavenger that eats dead animals, it could survive without returning to the boat.

Genesis 8:11

Unlike the raven ([8:7](#)), the dove feeds on vegetation. Since olive trees are not tall, Noah could tell that the water was almost gone.

Genesis 8:13

On the first day of the new year, ten and a half months after the flood began: This was two months after the peaks of the mountains first became visible ([8:5](#)).

Genesis 8:14

the earth was dry! This special word for dry land is uniquely used in connection with the sea to portray God's sovereignty over both domains (see [1:9-10](#); [Exod 14:22, 29](#); [Ps 95:5](#); [Jon 1:9](#)).

Genesis 8:17

be fruitful and multiply: See [9:1](#).

Genesis 8:20

This first mention of an altar in the Bible shows Noah's gratitude for having passed through the judgment. • sacrificed as burnt offerings: The same wording is used of the whole burnt offering in Leviticus ([Lev 1:3-9](#)); however, it can refer to any offering that is burned. Noah gave this offering to thank and worship God, who had delivered him and his family from the flood.

Genesis 8:21

pleased with the aroma of the sacrifice (literally *smelled the sweet aroma*): The narrator uses anthropomorphic language (i.e., he describes God's activity in human terms) to show God's acceptance of Noah's offering (see also [Exod 29:18](#); [Lev 1:9](#); [Num 15:3](#)). The common ancient Near Eastern notion that the gods ate the sacrifices offered to them is notably absent. • to himself (literally *in his heart*): The phrase echoes "broke his heart" ([6:6](#)), just as think or imagine echoes "everything they thought or imagined" ([6:5](#)). God's commitment to a new order replaced his grief over the old. • I will never again curse . . . destroy: The old curse was not lifted ([5:29](#)), but God promised not to add to it, thus establishing new limits for life in a disordered world (cp. [Isa 54:9](#)). The flood was to stop violence, not to reform the human heart ([Gen 6:5](#)). Humankind's bent toward evil would be contained to some degree through accountability to a new law ([9:5-6](#)).

Genesis 8:22

God's promise to sustain the rhythm of the seasons reaffirmed the created order ([1:14](#); see also [Jer 33:20](#); [Zech 14:7](#)).

Genesis 9:1

Be fruitful and multiply: The blessing and mandate first given to Adam ([1:28](#)) are now reissued to Noah, the "Adam" of the newly cleansed world in need of repopulation.

Genesis 9:1-7

God's first post-flood speech opens and closes with blessing ([9:1](#), [7](#)). In it, human and animal relationships are again defined, with some modification of the original created order. The sanctity of life is given special focus.

Genesis 9:2-3

There are two modifications to the original created order. (1) Previously, humans reigned over the animals ([1:28](#)), but now animals would live in terror of humans (similar military language is

found in [Exod 23:27–31](#); [Deut 11:25](#); [31:8](#)). (2) The animals' terror was related to a change in human diet. Humans were now permitted to eat the meat of animals to supplement their subsistence on grains, fruits, and vegetables ([Gen 1:29](#)).

Genesis 9:4

A key restriction is imposed. Since blood was identified with life, it had to be drained from a slain animal before its meat could be eaten (see [Lev 3:17](#); [7:26–27](#); [17:10–14](#); [Deut 12:16, 23](#)). The law of Moses prohibited eating animals that died naturally, since their blood had not been drained ([Deut 14:21](#)). God provided animal blood to atone for human sin ([Lev 17:11](#); [Heb 9:22](#)).

Genesis 9:5–6

Violence, including murder, was a major factor in bringing about God's judgment of the flood ([4:8](#); [6:11, 13](#)). At this new beginning for humans, God affirmed the sanctity of human life and established a system of retributive justice for the taking of human life (see also [Ps 9:12](#); "Retribution" Theme Note). The function of law is to restrain human wickedness and preserve moral order. This law was further developed in the law of Moses ([Exod 21:12–14](#); [Lev 24:17–22](#); [Num 35:16–34](#); [Deut 17:6–7](#); [19:15](#)).

Genesis 9:6

For God made human beings in his own image: The death penalty has a theological basis. God's image gives humans a unique status and authority within creation ([1:26–28](#)). Since murder destroys a person made in God's image, the ultimate penalty must be imposed on a murderer. See also [Exod 21:23–25](#). We are not to pursue personal revenge ([Rom 12:17–19](#)) but are to uphold the justice of the "governing authorities" that God has established ([Rom 13:1–7](#)).

Genesis 9:7

Now be fruitful and multiply, and repopulate (literally *swarm and fill*): In contrast to those who would destroy human life ([9:5–6](#)), God's desire is that human life should abound and flourish.

Genesis 9:8–17

God's second post-flood speech conveys his promise and plan for preserving creation.

Genesis 9:9–10

God had promised this covenant before the flood ([6:18](#)). Its scope extends beyond humanity to include the earth and all animals.

Genesis 9:11

This promise does not prohibit worldwide judgment, but it restricts the means by which God will do it (see [2 Pet 3:4–13](#)).

Genesis 9:12

In the Bible, covenants are frequently confirmed by some sort of sign (e.g., [17:11](#); [Exod 31:13, 17](#); [Luke 22:20](#)).

Genesis 9:13–16

God brought cataclysmic judgment through the rainstorm; now, the rainbow, a meteorological phenomenon associated with the rainstorm, would be an image of peace for all the earth (see [9:17](#)). • The same Hebrew term denotes both "rainbow" and "bow." Since God is sometimes pictured as a warrior who shoots arrows of judgment (see [Deut 32:42](#); [Pss 7:12](#); [18:13–14](#); [Hab 3:9–11](#)), some think that the imagery in [Gen 9:13–17](#) is of the Divine Warrior hanging up his bow of judgment.

Genesis 9:18

Ham is the father of Canaan: See also [9:20–27](#); [10:6–20](#). The text emphasizes Canaan's ancestral connection to Ham to show that the Canaanite identity was inseparably linked to Ham's shameful behavior ([9:20–27](#)). The citizens of both Egypt (from which Israel escaped slavery) and Canaan (to which Israel was headed) were Ham's descendants ([10:6](#); see [Lev 18:3, 24–26](#); [Pss 105:23, 27](#); [106:22](#)). Later stories in Genesis emphasize the immoral

climate of both Egypt ([Gen 12:10–20](#)) and Canaan ([34:1–31](#); [38:1–30](#)). See [9:20–27](#) and [10:6–20](#).

Genesis 9:20–27

The story of Noah begins with him walking in righteousness and obeying the Lord ([6:9](#)), but it ends with him lying drunk and naked in his tent and then delivering a curse on Canaan. Even after the great flood, the human race exhibited some of the same sinful characteristics that warranted the judgment in the first place. Special attention is given to the cursed origin of the Canaanites, the corrupt and idolatrous people Israel would later displace from the Promised Land (see also [15:16](#) and study note; [Lev 18:3](#); [20:23](#)).

Genesis 9:21

wine . . . became drunk: Wine is a gift from God ([Deut 14:26](#); [Ps 104:15](#); [Isa 55:1](#); see [Luke 22:14–20](#); [John 2:1–11](#)). Scripture is clear, however, that excessive consumption of alcohol is a perilous sin ([Prov 23:20–21](#), [29–35](#); [1 Cor 6:10](#)).

Genesis 9:22

the father of Canaan: See study note on 9:18. • Ham's behavior was shameful. He gazed upon his naked father and, rather than covering him and keeping the matter secret, robbed him of his dignity by announcing it to his brothers (see [Exod 21:15](#), [17](#); [Lam 4:21](#); [Hab 2:15](#)). An ancient Near Eastern tale says that a son is expected to come to his father's aid when he is drunk (*Tale of Aqhat*; cp. [Isa 51:17–18](#)). Ham's neglect of familial duty explains why Noah praised Shem and Japheth but cursed Ham ([Gen 9:24–27](#)).

Genesis 9:25

Then he cursed Canaan: Noah foresaw Ham's actions as morally representative of Ham's descendants through Canaan.

Genesis 9:26

Noah refers to God as the Lord, who formed the covenant with Israel. Shem was the privileged forefather of the Israelites (see [10:21–32](#)).

Genesis 9:27

May Japheth share the prosperity of Shem: Japheth's descendants would live among Shem's descendants and share Shem's prosperity (cp. [Rom 11:17–18](#)).

Genesis 10:1

Many children were born . . . after the great flood: This fulfilled the renewed creation mandate ([9:1](#), [9](#); cp. [1:28](#)).

Genesis 10:1–11.9

The fifth account ([10:1](#)) in Genesis (see study note on 2:4) unites the Table of Nations ([10:2–32](#)) and the Babel story ([11:1–9](#)) around the theme of scattering the nations ([10:5](#), [18](#); [11:4](#), [8–9](#)). The Table of Nations precedes the Babel story even though the Babel incident caused the geopolitical situation reflected in the Table of Nations. By reversing the order, Genesis links the repopulation of the earth with the blessing conferred upon Noah and his sons (see [9:1](#) and study note) and shows that Abram's call ([12:1–3](#)) was God's solution to the problem of human estrangement from God as reflected in the Babel story ([11:1–9](#)).

Genesis 10:2

The seven sons of Japheth settled in the region of Anatolia (the western plateau lands of Turkey) and spoke Indo-European languages. • Gomer was the ancestor of the later Cimmerians who lived north of the Black Sea. • Magog was probably the ancestor of those who settled in the region of Lydia (see [Ezek 38:2](#)). • The descendants of Madai were the later Medes of northwest Iran (see [2 Kgs 17:6](#); [Jer 51:11](#); [Dan 5:28](#)). • The descendants of Javan were the later Ionian Greeks. • The descendants of Tubal and Meshech were sometimes allies in battle ([Ezek 38:2](#)). Both were possibly from the coastal regions of Anatolia (see [Ezek 27:13](#)). • The descendants of

Tiras possibly became the Thracians that lived near the Aegean Sea.

Genesis 10:2–32

This section describes the ancestral origin of the nations of the ancient Near East. Ham was at the center ([10:6–20](#)), while the descendants of Japheth and Shem spread out to the surrounding regions of Greece, Crete, Asia Minor, Mesopotamia, Madai, the Arabian peninsula, and northeast Africa. The list selectively highlights nations relevant to Israel. The total of seventy (seven times ten) names indicates completeness (see [46:27](#); [Deut 32:8](#)) and symbolizes the totality of the world, which would later be blessed by the descendants of Abraham ([Gen 18:18](#)). • Although Shem is mentioned first in [10:1](#), he is addressed last in the Table because of his connection to Abram ([10:21–31](#); [11:10–32](#); [12:1](#)). Although God established the boundaries of all nations (see [Deut 32:8](#); [Amos 9:7](#); [Acts 17:26](#)), Israel was his special creation—a microcosm of seventy people ([Gen 46:27](#)) called to be a blessing to a world of seventy nations (see [12:3](#)).

Genesis 10:3

The descendants of Gomer came from near the Upper Euphrates region north of the Black Sea (cp. [Ezek 38:1–9](#)). • The descendants of Ashkenaz were the later Scythians who inhabited the region between the Black and Caspian Seas. • Riphath is near Carchemish. • The descendants of Togarmah are associated with Til-garimmu, the capital of Kammanu in modern Armenia (see [Ezek 38:6](#)).

Genesis 10:4

Elishah is probably Cyprus. • Tarshish is possibly southwest Spain (see study note on [Jon 1:3](#)). • The Kittim were inhabitants of southern Cyprus. • The Rodanim were inhabitants of the island of Rhodes, later a territory of Greece.

Genesis 10:5

seafaring peoples . . . various lands: They settled around the Mediterranean and on various islands. • language: This occurred after the Tower of Babel episode ([11:1–9](#); see study note on [10:1–11:9](#)).

Genesis 10:6

The peoples descended from Ham's four sons (Egyptians, Babylonians, Assyrians, Canaanites) were Israel's most hostile neighbors. • Cush was possibly in Ethiopia or ancient Nubia (northern Sudan). • Mizraim was the ancient name for Egypt ([50:11](#)). • Put was in Libya. • Canaan encompassed southern Syria, Phoenicia, and Palestine west of the Jordan River. In Moses' time, Egypt and Canaan were provinces of the same empire. Ham's descendants were excluded from the blessing of Shem's line ([9:20–28](#)).

Genesis 10:7

The sons of Cush and Raamah together total seven. • Seba was in northern Africa (see [Isa 43:3](#); [45:14](#)). • Havilah was in southwest Arabia. • Sabtah was in southern Arabia, in ancient Hadramaut, near the Persian Gulf. • Raamah was in southwest Arabia near Najran. • Sabteca was in ancient Samudake near the Persian Gulf. • Sheba was a kingdom in southwest Arabia with commercial colonies (see [1 Kgs 10:1–29](#)). • Dedan was in northern Arabia.

Genesis 10:8–12

Special attention is given to the early history of Babylonia and Assyria, the Mesopotamian empires that would conquer and exile Israel and Judah.

Genesis 10:9

Nimrod attained great fame by conquest and terror; his empire extended from Babylonia in the south to Assyria in the north ([10:10–12](#)). • the greatest hunter in the world: Assyrian monarchs glorified their own power, often depicting themselves as valiant hunter-conquerors.

Genesis 10:10–12

Babylonia is the area surrounding the Tigris and Euphrates in southern Mesopotamia. This kingdom eventually reached into northern Mesopotamia (Assyria). • Of the cities mentioned, Babylon is most important because of its role in building the

Tower of Babel (see [11:4](#) and study note). • Erech was ancient Uruk and is now Warka in southern Iraq (see [Ezra 4:9–10](#)). • Akkad was the ancient Agade north of Babylon, home of the famous ruler Sargon (2370–2295 BC). • The location of Calneh is uncertain, though it is presumably one of Nimrod's cities located north of Aram-naharaim in southern Mesopotamia (cp. [Amos 6:2](#)). • building . . . Nineveh: Like Cain, Nimrod built cities (see [Gen 4:17](#) and comments). Nineveh was an ancient Assyrian city on the east bank of the Tigris River in northern Iraq. • Rehoboth-ir was a daughter-city of Nineveh or was located nearby. • Calah is modern Tell Nimrud, south of Nineveh. • Resen is possibly modern Selamiyeh, northwest of Tell Nimrud.

Genesis 10:13–14

- *the Ludites* were Lydian tribes located west of the Nile delta.
- The identity of *the Anamites* is unclear. They might have been Egyptians near Cyrene, west of Egypt.
- *the Lehabites* were probably a Libyan tribe.
- *the Naphtuhites* lived in northern Egypt.
- *the Pathrusites* lived in southern Egypt.
- *the Casluhites* might have lived in an Egyptian area also known as "Cyrenaica."
- *the Caphtorites* were Cretans (see [Jeremiah 47:4](#); [Amos 9:7](#)).
- *the Philistines* from Crete were warriors and traders who traveled by ship from Crete to settle in southwest Canaan. They lived there during the time when the Israelites left Egypt and in later periods ([Exodus 13:17](#); [Amos 9:7](#)). During the early years of Israel's kings, the Philistines were one of Israel's strongest enemies (see 1–2 Samuel).

Genesis 10:15–18

Sidon settled in Phoenicia, north of Canaan. • Hittites: The Hittites in Genesis were a coalition of cities within Canaan (see [26:34–35](#); [27:46](#); [Ezek 16:3](#)). They were probably not the same as the Hittites of Anatolia (Asia Minor), whose empire was one of the great empires of antiquity during the patriarchal period. • The Jebusites were ancient inhabitants of Jerusalem ([Josh 15:63](#); [Judg 19:10–11](#); [2 Sam 5:6–9](#)). • The Amorites lived throughout the mountains of Palestine in Canaan (see [Gen 15:16](#); [48:22](#); [Num 13:29](#); [Deut 3:8](#); [Josh 10:5](#); [Judg 1:35](#); [10:8](#); [Ezek 16:3](#)). • Little is known of the Girgashites, a Canaanite tribe ([Gen 15:21](#); [Deut 7:1](#); [Josh 3:10](#)). • The Hivites were an uncircumcised Canaanite tribe ([Gen 34:2](#), [13–24](#); [Josh 9:1](#), [7](#); [11:3](#); [Judg 3:3](#); [2 Sam 24:7](#)). • The Arkites resided in Tell 'Arqa in Lebanon. • The Sinites formed a city-state and inhabited Phoenicia. • The Arvadites inhabited Ruad in northern Phoenicia, near the El Kebir River. They were known for shipping (cp. [Ezek 27:8](#)). • The Zemarites inhabited Sumur (modern Sumra), north of Arka on the Phoenician coast. • The Hamathites founded what is now Hama on the Orontes River, the northern boundary of Canaan (see [Num 34:8](#); [Josh 13:5](#); [2 Sam 8:9–10](#); [1 Kgs 8:65](#); [2 Kgs 14:25–28](#)).

Genesis 10:19

The territory of Canaan is specifically marked off because it would be taken from its inhabitants and given to Israel (see [15:18](#); [Num 34:2–12](#); [Ezek 47:15–20](#); [48:1–28](#)). • An ancient north-south seacoast highway (the Via Maris) extended from Sidon . . . to Gerar, connecting Egypt to Mesopotamia. • Modern Gaza is 11 miles northwest of Gerar. • Sodom and Gomorrah were cities on the border of the land southeast of the Dead Sea. • Admah and Zeboiim are mentioned 15 times in connection with Sodom and Gomorrah ([14:2](#), [8](#); [Deut 29:23](#); see [Hos 11:8](#)). All four cities were destroyed by God to cleanse the land (see [Gen 19](#)). • Lasha was possibly in the northern region of the Dead Sea.

Genesis 10:21

Shem, the older brother of Japheth, was the father of the Semitic peoples. The descendants listed represent countries east of Israel (modern Iraq, Iran, and Syria). The narrator lists these locations

within Mesopotamia since Abram, the father of Israel, originated from this area (see [11:27–32](#)). • Eber receives special attention because of his connection with Abram (see study note on 10:24).

Genesis 10:22

The descendants of Elam lived in the region of modern southwestern Iran (see [14:1, 9](#); [Ezra 4:9](#); [Isa 11:11](#)). • The descendants of Asshur were later Assyrians who lived under Nimrod's jurisdiction (see [Gen 10:11](#)). Sumerians descended from Ham were ousted by Mesopotamian Semites. • Arphaxad possibly settled northeast of Nineveh; his descendants are further described in [11:12–26](#). • Lud was near the Tigris River; its people were related to the Lydians (see [10:13](#)). • Aram was a kingdom of tribes that lived in the Mesopotamian plains.

Genesis 10:23

The patriarchs later interacted with the descendants of Aram (see [25:20](#); [31:20](#); [Deut 26:5](#)). • Uz was the chief Aramean tribe, possibly located northeast of the Jordan; it was Job's home (see [Job 1:1](#); see also [Lam 4:21](#)). • Hul is unknown. He possibly founded Armenia. • Gether is unknown; he was possibly the founder of the Syrians. • Mash might be associated with Mount Masus in northern Mesopotamia or with a part of the Lebanon Mountains.

Genesis 10:24

Shelah is unknown, but may be short for Methushelah (cp. [38:5, 11](#)). • Eber was the ancestor of Abram the Hebrew ([11:10–26](#)); his name is at the root of the term "Hebrew" (see [14:13](#); [39:14](#); [40:15](#); [41:12](#); [Exod 2:11](#); [3:18](#)).

Genesis 10:25

Peleg means division, anticipating the separation of people into language groups after Babel ([11:1–9](#)). Peleg's line led to Abram (see [11:16–26](#)). • Joktan was the ancestor of the southern Arabian tribes. The Ishmaelite tribes were in northern Arabia (see [25:13–16](#)).

Genesis 10:26–29

Almodad was an ancestor, region, or tribe in modern Yemen. • Sheleph was a tribe of Yemen. • Hazarmaveth was related to Hadramaut in southern Arabia. • Jerah is unknown, but was possibly associated with Mount Barach. • Hadoram was an Arabian tribe. • Uzal was Sana'a, an old capital of Yemen in pre-Islamic times. • Diklah was a southern Arabian oasis in Mina. • Obal was between Hodeida and Sana'a in southwest Arabia. • Abimael was a Sabaeen. • Sheba was in southern Arabia (see [10:7](#)). • Ophir was a region of southern Arabia between Sheba and Havilah; it was a source of gold ([Isa 13:12](#)). • Havilah: See [10:7](#). • Jobab was possibly Jobebitai in southern Arabia.

Genesis 10:26–32

There were fourteen sons of Shem by Eber through Joktan. The placement of the Babel story between the lines of Joktan and Peleg ties Joktan to the judgment of the Babel story ([11:1–9](#)) and ties Peleg to Abram ([11:27–12:1](#)).

Genesis 10:30

Mesha was a region in northern Arabia, south of Hadramaut. • Sephar is identified with Isfar, south of Hadramaut in Yemen.

Genesis 11:1

Now: The events in [11:1–9](#) caused the nations to scatter, as shown in the family histories of [10:2–30](#). Although these events happened in a different order than they are written, the author arranged them this way to help explain things about God's actions and plans more clearly (see study note on 10:1–11:9).

Genesis 11:1–9

The story of the unfinished tower carries forward themes of language and solidarity from the Table of Nations (ch [10](#)). The builders' desire for autonomy recalls the rebellion in Eden (ch [3](#)) and establishes the need for Abram's redemptive faith in the midst

of international disorder (ch [12](#)). The scattering of the nations anticipates the warning to Israel that idolatry would result in their being scattered and their cities devastated (see [Lev 26:33](#); [Num 10:35](#); [Deut 4:27](#); [28:64](#); [30:3](#)). Chronologically, the story is a flashback that explains the rise of the nations during Peleg's time (see [Gen 10:25](#)).

Genesis 11:2

migrated to the east: See study note on 3:24. • Babylonia was located in southern Mesopotamia, the region of Nimrod's later empire and city-building campaign (see [10:10](#); [Isa 11:11](#); [Dan 1:2](#); [Zech 5:11](#)).

Genesis 11:3

Stone was plentiful in Canaan; in Mesopotamia, stone was scarce and brick technology was developed. • Tar was made from bitumen, a natural, cement-like, waterproof asphalt (see [6:14](#); [Exod 2:3](#)).

Genesis 11:4

Far from the original garden ([2:15](#)), the first cities of Genesis represent arrogance ([4:17](#)), tyranny ([10:8-12](#)), and wickedness ([18:20-21](#)). The city on the Babylonian plain was a magnet for human pride and idolatry. • a tower that reaches into the sky: This was probably a temple-tower (a ziggurat). Common in ancient Babylonian urban culture, ziggurats were regarded as sacred mountains by which deities descended to earth (Jacob's dream in [28:12](#) possibly reflects this idea). • This will make us famous (literally *let us make a name for ourselves*): The tower builders sought fame through idolatrous ambition. God promised to give Abram a famous name because of his humble obedience ([12:2](#)).

Genesis 11:5

came down: The tower was a human attempt to ascend to God's realm (see [Deut 26:15](#); [Pss 2:4](#); [103:19](#); [115:16](#)). The folly of that attempt was exposed by God's "coming down" to see their feeble efforts.

Genesis 11:6

If left unchecked, the tower builders' solidarity and ambition would allow human wickedness to flourish in unimaginable ways.

Genesis 11:7

Come, let's go down: God addresses his angelic court (see [1:26](#); [3:22](#); and study notes). • won't be able to understand each other: Their inability to communicate would curtail their unified sinful ambition. The God-honoring unity of language on the day of Pentecost was a symbolic reversal of the Babel dispersion ([Acts 2:5-13](#); see [Zeph 3:9](#)).

Genesis 11:8

the Lord scattered them: Similarly, Adam and Eve's punishment for grasping at autonomy and Cain's punishment for murder involved banishment and dispersion ([3:23](#); [4:12, 14](#); [9:19](#); [10:5, 25, 32](#)).

Genesis 11:9

Babel: The Babylonians viewed their city as the residence or gateway of the gods. The pun that concludes this account accurately reveals Babylon's spiritual confusion. Babylon achieved prominence under Nimrod ([10:10](#)) and in later biblical history (see [2 Kgs 25:1-30](#)). Its role as an epicenter of arrogance and idolatry make it a fitting image for the anti-God forces associated with the end of time (e.g., [Rev 14:8](#); [16:19](#); [18:2](#)). • The tower builders had centralized to ascend into God's realm ([Gen 11:3-4](#)). God descended and scattered them all over the world to frustrate their idolatrous ambition.

Genesis 11:10

This account of Shem's family resumes the line of Shem from [10:21-32](#), now with special focus on the line leading to Abram. Only Abram and Israel are heirs to Shem's God (see [9:26-27](#); [Deut 32:8-9](#)). The Babel story vividly repudiates the culture that Abram was called to abandon ([Gen 12:1](#); [24:6-7](#)). Together with the account of Terah's descendants

([11:27-32](#)), this second account of Shem's line forms a bridge from the universal history of chs [1-11](#) to the national history of Israel that begins in ch [12](#). Abram is the remnant from Babel's confused world. God called him as an act of grace whereby the fractured world of Babel would be blessed ([12:3](#)). • the father of: Or *the ancestor of*; Hebrew genealogies do not necessarily list every single generation.

Genesis 11:18

Peleg: See study note on 10:25.

Genesis 11:27

Nahor was the grandfather of Laban, whose daughters later became Jacob's wives (chs [29-31](#)).
• Lot: See "Lot" Profile.

Genesis 11:27-32

This brief section provides a complete summary of Terah's life and accounts for his other sons and their marriages; it also introduces Lot, Abram's nephew, who later played a prominent role. The ancestors, including Terah and his family, were idolatrous, worshiping other gods in Mesopotamia ([Josh 24:2](#)).

Genesis 11:27-25.11

This is the account (Hebrew toledoth; see study note on 2:4) of Terah's family: What follows in [11:28-25:11](#) are the particulars about the family descended from Terah, notably about Abraham and God's covenant with him, and about Isaac, the child of promise, who carried forward the line and the blessing to the next generation.

Genesis 11:28

The call of Abram occurred in Ur of the Chaldeans ([15:7](#); [Acts 7:2-4](#)), the main city of Sumer in Mesopotamia near the mouth of the Persian Gulf. The family had moved there perhaps generations before the call. Their ancestral home ("native country," [Gen 12:1](#)) was apparently near Haran, in the region of the descendants of Shem ([11:10-26](#));

thus they settled there when they left Ur ([11:31](#)) and were later described as "Arameans" ([Deut 26:5](#)). • land of his birth: The same Hebrew phrase is repeated in [12:1](#) ("native country"), making Ur, not Haran, the location of Abram's call (see [15:7](#); [Neh 9:7](#); [Acts 7:2](#)).

Genesis 11:29

Sarai means "princess" in Hebrew. No mention is made of Sarai's parentage, perhaps to add suspense to the Abimelech story, which reveals that she was Abram's half sister ([20:9-12](#)). Later, the law prohibited such a marriage ([Lev 18:9](#); [20:17](#); [Deut 27:22](#)). • Nahor's wife was Milcah: Milcah was Haran's daughter and Nahor's niece (see [Gen 11:29](#)). Her son Bethuel was the father of Rebekah, the wife of Abram's son Isaac ([24:10](#), [15](#), [24](#)). The name Milcah is related to the Hebrew word meaning "queen." In Akkadian, it is a title of the goddess Ishtar, the moon-god's daughter. Terah's name is related to the word for "moon" in Hebrew; his whole family appears to have worshiped Sin, the moon-god (see [Josh 24:14](#)).

Genesis 11:30

Sarai, Rebekah ([25:21](#)), and Rachel ([29:31](#)) all suffered infertility. Sarai's situation in particular highlights the paradox between the apparent reality and God's promise to give many descendants ([12:2](#)). The Israelite nation's origin from barren women fixes its identity in the sovereignty of God, who miraculously gives children to barren women (see also [1 Sam 1:2](#); [2:5](#); [Ps 113:9](#); [Isa 54:1](#)).

Genesis 11:31

Terah took: The text is clear that Abram's departure from Ur was prompted by God's calling (see study note on 11:28), but the event is described from Terah's perspective, in keeping with the patriarchy of ancient Near Eastern culture. This cultural deference to the oldest male is evidently why Abram did not continue on to Canaan by himself at this time (see [Acts 7:2-4](#)). • Haran was 550 miles northwest of Ur, near the Syrian-Turkish border. Despite the similar name, there is no connection with Terah's son Haran, who had died in Ur ([11:28](#)). • *Haran* means "caravan."

Ancient commercial routes converged there, making it a key site for trade. • *Haran* was also well known for the moon worship to which Terah's family was apparently devoted (see study note on 11:29).

Genesis 12:1

Abram knew that he should leave, but he did not know where he was going. Obedience required faith.

Genesis 12:1-3

These verses are structured around two commands to Abram: Leave and be a blessing (see study note on 12:2). Each directive is followed by three promises conditioned upon obedience.

Genesis 12:1-9

Through Abram's faith and family, God began restoring the blessing. God called Abram from a pagan world to begin a new nation; his promises to Abram later became a covenant (ch 15). • God's call to Abram later helped convince the Israelites to leave Egypt and go to the land God promised to Abram. It also reminded the Babylonian exiles of their need to return to their own land (e.g., [Isa 51](#)).

Genesis 12:2

- *make your name great*: Abram gained the fame that the builders of the tower of Babel wanted for themselves (see [11:4](#) and study note).
- *so that you will be a blessing*: This statement is a command and a promise in Hebrew. It depends on Abram obeying God's command ([12:1-3](#)): "Go ... so that you will be a blessing. I will bless those who bless you and curse those who curse you."

Genesis 12:3

Based on Abram's obedience to the command to be a blessing ([12:2](#)), God gave him three more promises. • those who treat you with contempt: People who disregarded Abram and his covenant were rejecting God's choice and plan. • All the families on earth will be blessed: By faith, they could participate in the covenant God was making with Abram. The blessing spread to the whole world through Abraham, Israel, the covenants, the prophets, Scripture, and the Messiah ([Gal 3:8, 16](#); cp. [Rom 9:4-5](#)).

Genesis 12:4

Abram was middle-aged, settled, prosperous, aristocratic, and polytheistic (see study note on 11:27-32). When the Lord spoke to him ([12:1-3](#)), he obediently left his old ways in Ur to follow God's plan. Since Abram responded in faith, God's promises ([12:2-3](#)) could be confirmed in a binding covenant ([15:8-21](#)).

Genesis 12:4-9

Abram's obedience to God's call corresponded to God's commands (see study note on 12:1-3). He journeyed to Canaan ([12:4-6](#)) and became a blessing ([12:5-9](#)).

Genesis 12:5

The people (Hebrew *hannepesh*, "the lives") he had taken into his household were probably converts; Abram first became a blessing by influencing people in his household to join him in following the Lord.

Genesis 12:6-7

The oak of Moreh was apparently a Canaanite shrine; fertile groves of trees were sacred to the Canaanites (cp. [Isa 1:29](#)), and *Moreh* means "teacher." Abram proclaimed (Luther: "preached") the Lord's name beside a pagan place of worship and instruction ([Gen 12:8](#)). • Abram continued to be a blessing when he built an altar to worship God at Shechem and east of Bethel ([12:8](#)).

Genesis 12:7

- *the LORD appeared to Abram* at Shechem ([12:6](#)) to confirm that this was the promised land. Israel was meant to live in this land, but they needed faith to share in God's promises (compare [Numbers 14](#); [Joshua 1:6–9](#)).
- *to your offspring*: Abram did not own the land yet. He lived there as a temporary settler.

Genesis 12:8

he worshiped the Lord (literally *he made proclamation of the Lord by name*): Proclaiming the name (identity and character) of the Lord is central to worship and witness (cp. [4:26](#); see [Exod 34:5–7](#)). Abram had to distinguish his sacrificial worship from that of the pagan Canaanites.

Genesis 12:8–9

Abram had to keep moving camp because the Canaanites had the fertile land.

Genesis 12:10

The Nile River provided ample irrigation, so Egypt was often the last region to suffer from famine.

Genesis 12:10–13

Abram's scheme was rooted in fear that jeopardized his family and God's promises. Abram was not walking by faith when he went to Egypt. He stopped building altars and his deceptiveness took center stage. Deception would plague his family throughout Genesis ([26:1–11](#); [27:1–29](#); [29:15–30](#); [30:34–36](#); [31:6–11](#); [37:18–35](#); [39:7–20](#)). • Abram's plan was probably based on a social custom whereby a brother arranged the marriage of his sister (cp. [24:29–61](#)). Abram may have thought that any potential suitor would have to deal with him, giving him time to leave with Sarai. He did not count on Pharaoh's acting without negotiation ([12:14–16](#)).

Genesis 12:10–20

This episode shows that God would not allow Abram to jeopardize his promises. Just after Abram's obedience to the call, a famine tested his weak faith. God delivered him and his family, even though Abram foolishly used deception rather than trusting in God to preserve him in Egypt. • This story deliberately parallels Israel's later bondage in Egypt. Because of a famine ([Gen 12:10](#) // [Gen 47:13](#)), Abram/Israel went to Egypt ([Gen 12:10](#) // [Gen 47:27](#)); there was an attempt to kill the males and save the females ([Gen 12:12](#) // [Exod 1:22](#)); God plagued Egypt ([Gen 12:17](#) // [Exod 7:14–11:10](#)); Abram/Israel plundered Egypt ([Gen 12:16](#) // [Exod 12:35–36](#)); they were expelled (Hebrew *shalakh*, "send"; [Gen 12:19–20](#) // [Exod 12:31–33](#)) and ascended to the Negev ([Gen 13:1](#) // [Num 13:17, 22](#)). Israel was to believe that God would deliver them from bondage in Egypt through the plagues because their ancestor had already been rescued from bondage in Egypt.

Genesis 12:13

tell them you are my sister: This request occurs three times in Genesis (see also [20:2](#); [26:7](#)). The text explains that this was Abram's usual strategy ([20:13](#)), and his son did likewise. This first occasion was outside the land, the second (ch [20](#)) within, showing that God protected his promise in both regions.

Genesis 12:14–15

Sarai was 65 years old, but she lived to be 127; she was like a modern childless woman of about 35. She and Abram came from a noble family (see study note on [11:29](#)), so she was regal in her person and dress. Pharaoh was attracted by her physical appearance and her political assets.

Genesis 12:14–16

Abram was bound by the king's gift to an unwanted agreement about Sarai that he could not prevent. His scheme had resulted in a terrible bind that endangered him, Sarai, and the promise. • Abram appeared to prosper from his deception, but the

new possessions also caused crises. Abram and Lot had to separate (ch [13](#)), and Hagar, an Egyptian maiden, became the mother of the Ishmaelites, perennial enemies of Israel (ch [16](#)).

Genesis 12:15

Pharaoh was a title, not a personal name ([37:36](#); [Exod 1:15](#)).

Genesis 12:17–19

God's intervention rescued Sarai and preserved the marriage to fulfill the covenant promise. Sarai's restoration to Abram came with a rebuke from Pharaoh on God's behalf ([12:18–19](#)).

Genesis 12:20

No answer to Pharaoh's questions ([12:18–19](#)) was needed, because the rebuke was followed by expulsion. Pharaoh's command paralleled God's command to Abram ([12:1](#)), but Pharaoh's demand brought shame and disgrace. God was faithful in preserving his promise.

Genesis 13:1–7

This story is set in conflict amid God's blessings. In the opening verses, Abram returns to a place where he had built an altar. Previous events are emphasized as Abram's return to the land is described ([13:3–4](#)); Abram renewed his worship and again proclaimed the Lord's name (cp. [12:8](#)).

Genesis 13:2

Abram already had powerful resources ([12:5](#)); his Egyptian sojourn augmented his wealth and power ([12:16](#)).

Genesis 13:5–7

Lot was also wealthy, with flocks and herds. Tents figure prominently in Lot's story ([13:12](#)). • The Canaanites and Perizzites (see [34:30](#); [Deut 7:1](#); [Judg 1:4](#); [3:5](#)) held the well-watered land; the

quarrel between Abram's and Lot's herdsmen left Abram more vulnerable to attack.

Genesis 13:8

Abram was concerned that there be no conflict (Hebrew *meribah*) between them, as they were close relatives (literally *brothers*). Moses later reproved Israel over the incident in the wilderness at Meribah ([Exod 17:1–7](#); [Num 20:1–13](#)) and instructed them on exercising faith in such situations. Meribah thereafter became a watchword for testing and striving with the Lord in unbelief (see [Ps 95](#)).

Genesis 13:8–13

Abram, to whom the land was promised, might have told Lot to find his own place. Abram's generosity was an act of faith; he knew that even if he gave the whole land away, God would still give it to him and his descendants. Abram did not have to cling to things, whereas Lot's choices were self-seeking.

Genesis 13:10

What appealed to Lot would be short-lived. In the garden of the Lord, Adam and Eve succumbed to their craving for what they saw; Israel was later enslaved in Egypt. Sodom and Gomorrah are reminders of putting intense desires ahead of obedience to God ([3:5–6](#); see [1 Jn 2:16](#)). • Zoar was a small town in the plain to which Lot and his daughters later fled ([19:18–22](#)); it was previously called Bela ([14:2](#)).

Genesis 13:11

Lot's choice was totally selfish, without concern for Abram or faith in the Lord. • The region called the whole Jordan Valley (literally *the circle of the Jordan*) is believed to have been near the south end of the Dead Sea, based on descriptions in ancient records that locate cities of the Plain. This area is now very desolate.

Genesis 13:11–18

The narrator makes numerous contrasts between Lot and Abram.

Genesis 13:13

The implication is that Lot would not resist Sodom's influence because he, too, was living for himself.

Genesis 13:14–17

Abram could give Lot the choice land because he believed in God's promise. Abram waited for God to give him the land; Lot just took what he wanted.

Genesis 13:18

Hebron was an Anakite city ([Num 13:22](#)) originally called Kiriath-arba ("city of Arba"), located in forested highlands just north of the Negev ([Gen 12:9](#); [Josh 17:15](#)). Abraham, Isaac, and Jacob all settled there ([Gen 18:1](#); [35:27](#); [37:14](#)), and Sarah, Abraham, Isaac, Rebekah, Jacob, and Leah were buried there ([23:19](#); [35:27–29](#); [49:29–32](#); [50:13](#)). • Mamre was an Amorite ([14:13](#); [15:16](#)).

Genesis 14:1

Tidal apparently ruled a number of city-states (Goiim, literally *nations*).

Genesis 14:1–2

Archaeology has not identified these kings, but similar names from antiquity corroborate the report's accuracy. The Mesopotamian kings were confederates under a suzerain, apparently Amraphel, who is mentioned first.

Genesis 14:1–16

In this skirmish typical of ancient politics, powerful kings formed a coalition to subjugate smaller vassal states.

Genesis 14:4

King Kedorlaomer apparently defeated the Siddim Valley kings at an earlier time and put them under tribute for asphalt, olive oil, and copper. In the thirteenth year they refused to send it; in the fourteenth year ([14:5](#)), the invaders returned to subjugate them again.

Genesis 14:4–5

This was Chedorlaomer's war. Under the feudal system of tribal affiliations, those in covenant with him had to fight. It was also Abram's battle to rescue Lot, and those under treaty with him had to accompany him.

Genesis 14:5–8

The invaders came down the King's Highway on the east side of the Jordan Valley to the Gulf of Aqaba, then circled back to the valley of the Dead Sea.

Genesis 14:8–12

The five cities of the plain were close together at the south end of the Dead Sea. The Mesopotamian kings defeated the frail uprising, looted the cities of Sodom and Gomorrah, and carried off Lot with the other captives.

Genesis 14:13

The word Hebrew first occurs here in the Bible. It is not equivalent to the later term *Habiru* from Egyptian texts; the *Habiru* were mercenaries that roamed the land in the era of the judges. • Mamre: See study note on 13:18. • relatives: Or *allies*; literally *brothers*.

Genesis 14:14

Abram . . . mobilized the 318 trained men who had been born into his household: Abram was a formidable force, an outworking of God's promise to make him great ([12:2–3](#)). • Dan was a city about 150 miles north of Abram's home in Hebron, then named Laish or Leshem (see [Josh 19:47](#) and study note; [Judg 18:29](#)). Dan, whose descendants

migrated north in the days of the judges ([Judg 18:1-29](#)), had not yet been born ([Gen 30:6](#)). An editor apparently updated the text so that later readers could identify this city.

Genesis 14:14-16

God could give his people victory over any forces invading the Promised Land. Faithfulness to God was the prerequisite for victory. God promises to bless his people and give them victory over the world. He uses those who respond to his call and can skillfully use weapons of war (cp. [Eph 4:8; 6:10-19](#)).

Genesis 14:15

Damascus was 40 miles north of Dan. Hobah was about 60 miles north of Damascus.

Genesis 14:17

The valley of Shaveh or King's Valley was probably the Kidron Valley (see [2 Sam 18:18](#)).

Genesis 14:18

Melchizedek means "king of righteousness," suggesting that he was a righteous servant of God. He was probably a Jebusite priest and king; later authors regarded him as a type of Christ ([Ps 110:4; Heb 7:1-19](#)). • Salem is the ancient name of Jerusalem (cp. [Ps 76:2](#)).

Genesis 14:19-20

By paying a tithe (a tenth) to Melchizedek, Abram acknowledged Melchizedek as a spiritual superior (see [Heb 7:4](#)) and affirmed that God had given him victory.

Genesis 14:21-24

Abram knew that accepting the offer of the king of Sodom (see study note on 14:1-2) could make him his ally or subject, as Lot had been. This would jeopardize the fulfillment of God's promises. Faith

looks beyond the riches of the world to the greater blessings that God has in store.

Genesis 14:22

In the words of this oath, Abram may have been clarifying that his God, the Lord (Yahweh), was the God Most High that Melchizedek invoked. Perhaps Melchizedek had never heard the name Yahweh.

Genesis 15:1

Do not be afraid: Abram lacked a son to be his heir. The Lord addressed Abram's anxiety about the future with comforting words. • I will protect you (literally *I will be your shield*): The Hebrew word for "shield" (*magen*) is from the same root as Melchizedek's word *defeated* ([14:20](#)). The Lord who had defeated Abram's enemies would continue to protect him. • your reward will be great: The promise of offspring ([12:2-3](#); cp. [Ps 127:3](#)) was still unfulfilled.

Genesis 15:1-21

God made a covenant (a special agreement) with Abram. In this covenant, God confirmed the promises he had made earlier when he summoned Abram to leave his country ([12:1-3](#)). Abram's descendants would experience a long period of slavery before God made these promises come true.

Genesis 15:2-3

Using a wordplay, Abram expressed his concern that Eliezer of Damascus (Hebrew *dammeseq*), a man in Abram's household, would be his heir (Hebrew *ben-mesheq*, "son of possession"), as was customary when there was no son.

Genesis 15:4-6

God affirmed that the promise was for Abram's own offspring and showed him the stars as a promise of the vast number of descendants that he would have ([22:17; 26:4](#)). Paul quotes this promise in [Rom 4:18](#) to underscore the strength of Abram's faith.

Genesis 15:6

And Abram believed: God made his covenant with a believer; the statement does not indicate when Abram came to faith. The Hebrew text does not link Abram's belief with the promise of the stars; it just says parenthetically that Abram believed God. Abram already had faith; his departure from Ur was his first great act that demonstrated it (see [Heb 11:8-10](#)). • God counted him as righteous because of his faith: This central statement about Abram's saving faith is quoted three times in the New Testament ([Rom 4:3](#); [Gal 3:6](#); [Jas 2:23](#)) to support the doctrine of righteousness before God by faith (see also [Rom 4:22-23](#)).

Genesis 15:7-21

With a solemn ceremony, God made a binding covenant with Abram that guaranteed the fulfillment of God's promises to him.

Genesis 15:10

Obedying God's instructions, Abram gathered three herd animals for the ceremony and cut them in half. Cutting the animals symbolized the oath, indicating that the covenant maker staked his own life on his word ([Jer 34:18](#)).

Genesis 15:11

Vultures are unclean birds of prey that symbolize those who unjustly attack Abraham's heirs ([15:13-14](#)).

Genesis 15:13

oppressed: The same word is used in [Exod 1:11-12](#). Egypt, like predatory birds ([Gen 15:11](#)), would try to destroy Israel and hinder the covenant's fulfillment. • Apparently 400 years is a round number (also [Acts 7:6](#); cp. [Exod 12:40](#); [Gal 3:17](#)). Using the chronology in the Hebrew text, the family moved to Egypt around 1876 BC, and the Exodus occurred around 1446 BC (though many scholars date the Exodus later, around 1270 BC; see Exodus Book Introduction, "The Date of the Exodus").

Genesis 15:13-16

Not even 400 years of bondage could interfere with God's plan to fulfill the covenant.

Genesis 15:16

The reasons for Israel's bondage included God's justice. God would tolerate the sins of the Amorites until they fully deserved judgment. • do not yet warrant their destruction (literally *are not yet full*): To give the Promised Land to Israel, the Lord would dispossess the land's inhabitants in a way that satisfied his justice. The fulfillment of promises to Israel also brought retributive judgment on people of the land (though individuals were saved by faith; see [Josh 2:1-15](#); [6:23-25](#); [Heb 11:31](#); [Jas 2:25](#)). Until then, God would send the family to Egypt where Israel could become a great nation. Seeing all this in advance was terrifying ([Gen 15:12](#)), but it was comforting to know that nothing could interfere with God's plan.

Genesis 15:17-18

smoking firepot . . . flaming torch: Fire represented the Lord's cleansing, consuming zeal and unapproachable holiness (cp. [Isa 6:3-7](#)). The holy God made (literally *cut*) a unilateral covenant with Abram; its promises were absolutely sure because they did not depend on what Abram or his descendants might do.

Genesis 15:18-19

God specified the boundaries of the Promised Land. His clear message to Abram was that despite prospects of death and suffering (enslavement), he and his descendants would eventually receive the promises, for God had sworn an oath (see [Heb 6:13-14](#)). Nothing can separate God's people from his love or the fulfillment of his plans (see [Rom 8:18-39](#); [2 Pet 1:3-4](#)).

Genesis 16:1-3

Abram and Sarai faced the tension of her being barren and beyond childbearing years. By custom,

a barren woman could give her servant to her husband as a slave-wife; the child born to that union was considered the wife's child and could be adopted as the heir. Sarai's suggestion, unobjectionable by custom, set a problematic human plan in motion. God's promises would be fulfilled by faith.

Genesis 16:1–16

While waiting for their promised son to be born, Abram and Sarai attempted an alternate plan that was not in keeping with faith.

Genesis 16:4–6

Perhaps Hagar expected to become the favored wife instead of Sarai (cp. [Prov 30:21–23](#)).

Genesis 16:7

The angel of the Lord was the Lord himself ([16:13](#); [21:17](#); [22:11–12](#); [31:11–13](#); [48:16](#); [Exod 3:2](#); [32:34](#); [Judg 6:11](#), [16](#), [22](#); [13:22–23](#); [Zech 3:1–2](#)) but was also distinct from the Lord ([Gen 24:7](#); [2 Sam 24:16](#); [Zech 1:12](#)). The angel of the Lord was probably a *theophany* (a manifestation of God) or a *Christophany* (an appearance of the pre-incarnate Messiah; see [Gen 18:1–2](#); [19:1](#); [Num 22:22](#); [Judg 2:1–4](#); [5:23](#); [Zech 12:8](#)), speaking with the authority of the Lord himself.

Genesis 16:8–12

The angel's rhetorical questions encouraged Hagar to pour out her heart to God. When she did, God commanded her to return and submit ([16:9](#)), promising that her son would have innumerable descendants. The angel of the Lord never referred to Hagar as Abram's wife, only as Sarai's servant. She would have Abram's child, but Ishmael was not central to God's covenant with Abram.

Genesis 16:10–12

Hagar's son would become the father of a great but wild and hostile nation living in the Arabian Desert as perennial enemies of Israel (cp. [25:18](#)). God blessed Ishmael as Abram's descendant, but not as

the line chosen to carry on the covenant. That blessing was reserved for Abram's chosen heir.

Genesis 16:11

Names in Genesis often capture the message of a passage and aid the remembrance of the events and their significance in the history of the faith. The name Ishmael, which means "God hears," commemorates that the Lord . . . heard Hagar's cry of distress (see also study note on [16:14–15](#)). This name would have greatly comforted Hagar; God listened to her prayers and acknowledged her complaint.

Genesis 16:13

Hagar responded to God's messages by faith, in her words and in her obedience. • the God who sees me: God knew Hagar's plight and watched over her.

Genesis 16:14–15

The names Beer-lahai-roi, which means "well of the Living One who sees me," and Ishmael (see [16:11](#)) were a message and a rebuke for Abram and Sarai. God sees affliction and hears the cries of those in need. Sarai and Abram should have prayed rather than taking the fulfillment of the promise into their own hands by following social custom (cp. [25:21](#)). Giving children to the barren woman is God's work ([Ps 113:9](#); cp. [1 Sam 1:1–28](#); [Luke 1:1–25](#)); impossible difficulties cannot be resolved by human intervention. The Lord hears the afflicted, sees them in their need, and will miraculously provide for them.

Genesis 17:1

El-Shaddai: This name for God emphasizes his power (see also [28:3](#); [35:11](#); [43:14](#); [48:3](#); [49:25](#)). • Serve me faithfully and live a blameless life: Being a blessing to the nations required obedience from Abram; his conduct would be guided by Almighty God.

Genesis 17:1–27

God now gave the family signs that the promises would be fulfilled. He changed Abram's name to Abraham ([17:1–8](#)), instituted the rite of circumcision as the sign of the covenant ([17:9–14, 23–27](#)), and changed Sarai's name to Sarah ([17:15–22](#)).

Genesis 17:4–5

God guaranteed his promise by changing Abram's name. Abram referred to his noble lineage, as Terah was the “exalted father” ([11:27](#)). His new name, Abraham (Hebrew 'ab hamon) was a wordplay on the promise of his own progeny (see also [John 8:31–59](#); [Rom 4:16–17](#); [Gal 3:7, 15–19, 29](#)). Whenever the new name was used, he and his household would remember that a multitude of nations would issue from him.

Genesis 17:6

kings will be among them! This is the first indication that Israel would become a monarchy (see also [35:11](#); [36:31](#); [Num 24:7](#); [Deut 17:14–18](#); [28:36](#)).

Genesis 17:7–8

The land of Canaan was to be an everlasting possession for the descendants of Abraham; the Lord would be their God forever (see [Jer 31:31–40](#); [Zech 8:8](#); [Luke 1:68–79](#); [Rev 21:1–4](#)).

Genesis 17:9–14

God gave circumcision as a confirming sign that reminded all households of loyalty to the covenant.

Genesis 17:14

will be cut off: This punishment seems to have several applications. A person could be exiled from society or put to death by the community; most often it warned that a person might die prematurely as God cut him off from the land of the living (see [Exod 31:14](#); [Lev 7:20–27](#); [17:3–4](#); [20:17–18](#); [23:28–29](#); [Num 15:30–31](#); see also [Ps](#)

[31:22](#); [Ezek 21:4](#); [Rom 9:3](#); [11:22](#)). Failure to be circumcised was a serious violation (see [Exod 4:24–26](#); cp. [Gal 5:2–4](#)).

Genesis 17:15–16

Sarah: The new name, fitting for one who would be the mother of kings, was a milestone in Sarah's calling and brought attention to the promise.

Genesis 17:17–18

Abraham laughed (Hebrew yitskhaq) because the promise seemed unbelievable; he had begun to believe that his line would come through Ishmael. But Abraham and Sarah would have a son of their own.

Genesis 17:19

The name Isaac (Hebrew yitskhaq, “he laughs”) would constantly recall Abraham's disbelieving laughter when he heard the promise. It was also a reminder of God's favor and his pleasure in the birth (cp. [21:6](#)).

Genesis 17:20–21

Ishmael would not be abandoned; his family would prosper (see [25:13–16](#)), but the covenant promises were for Isaac.

Genesis 17:23–27

Having received God's word about Isaac, Abraham immediately complied with God's instructions. He implemented the rite of circumcision as an act of faith; it signified their participation in the covenant (cp. [Rom 4:11–12](#); [Gal 5:2–6, 11](#); [6:15](#); [Phil 3:2–3](#); [Col 2:11–12](#); [1 Pet 3:21](#)).

Genesis 18:1–15

The Lord's visit to Abraham set the time for Isaac's birth. The three visitors were probably the Lord and two angels (see study note on 16:7). Abraham's peaceful and generous reception of the visitors

contrasts sharply with the chaos and corruption of Sodom (ch 19). Eating together was important in making or confirming covenants; when God was ready to fulfill the covenant promise, he came in person to share a meal with Abraham. Fellowship with God has always been signified by a communal meal (see [Exod 24:9–11](#); [Matt 26:17–30](#) // [Luke 22:7–38](#); [Acts 2:42](#); [1 Cor 11:20–34](#)).

Genesis 18:2–8

Abraham received his visitors as very important guests, perhaps realizing that they were messengers from God.

Genesis 18:3

My lord: The Hebrew text uses *'adonay*, which always refers to God. In Hebrew tradition, people said this word when they saw the letters of God's holy name ("Yahweh") in the text. The text here might use *'adonay* instead of the more common *'adoni* to show this was the angel of the Lord, meaning the Lord himself (see study note on 16:7). We do not know if Abraham knew who his visitors were at first. But by the end of the story, he knew he had been talking with God.

Genesis 18:9

The visitors asked about Sarah by name, even though no one had told them who she was.

Genesis 18:10

I will surely return: The Hebrew phrase is emphatic. The statement announced a certain promise and dramatic change.

Genesis 18:13–15

Sarah thought her disbelieving laughter was hidden, but God knows human hearts (see [Ps 69:5](#); [Prov 20:27](#); [Mark 4:22](#); [Luke 8:43–48](#); [Heb 4:13](#)), whether they stagger at the promises or step out in faith (see [Heb 11:11–12](#)).

Genesis 18:14

Is anything too hard for the Lord? The question is rhetorical. God is able to do marvelous things. Nothing is incredible to those in covenant fellowship with the Lord, because nothing is too difficult for him.

Genesis 18:16–33

God took Abraham into his confidence as his prophet ([18:16–21](#); see [20:7](#)); Abraham, in turn, interceded for Sodom ([18:23–32](#); see [Heb 7:23–26](#)). God is able to do whatever he chooses to do; this passage affirms that it will be just and right.

Genesis 18:17–19

Abraham was responsible for teaching his descendants righteousness and justice so that they might enjoy God's blessings. It was important for Abraham to know how God's righteousness was at work in judgment.

Genesis 18:20

a great outcry: See [Ezek 16:49–50](#).

Genesis 18:20–21

The omniscient God was cautious in his judgment: He knew the sins of Sodom and Gomorrah, but this close scrutiny communicated God's justice in human terms—he would not destroy the people of the plain unless he was absolutely sure they were wicked.

Genesis 18:22–33

Abraham probably thought there were more righteous people in Sodom and Gomorrah than there were (see study note on 19:14). In his concern for them, he approached the Lord with a legal appeal based on God's justice. His prayer seems too bold at times, as though he were bargaining with God, but he approached God with genuine humility and reverence. He did not try to talk God into doing something against his will, but prayed for the well-being of others (contrast Lot's

prayer, [19:18-23](#)). God is a righteous judge; righteousness exalts a nation ([Prov 14:34](#)), and righteous people help to preserve society (cp. [Matt 5:13](#)).

Genesis 19:1

The two angels also first appeared to Abraham as men ([18:2](#)). • Lot was no longer living in tents next to Sodom ([13:12](#))—he had become a citizen and leader in Sodom, sitting there at the entrance of the city. Community leaders (elders) usually congregated in the gates, where legal and business transactions were publicly finalized (cp. [23:18](#); [Job 29:7, 12-17](#)). As a righteous man ([2 Pet 2:7-8](#)), Lot tried to modify the townspeople's wickedness by giving advice on good living (cp. [Gen 19:9](#)). Although he denounced gross evil, Lot preferred Sodom's sumptuous lifestyle to life in the hills (cp. [13:10-11](#)), where there was clean living but no "good life." As long as the Lord left Lot and his family alone in Sodom, he lived comfortably there and kept his personal belief in God; but finally, he could not hold to both. Sodom would have destroyed Lot if the Lord had not destroyed Sodom. • This account showed Israel that God is the righteous judge of the whole earth ([18:25](#)) who will judge evildoers with justice and equity. In wicked societies, moral and ethical failures lead to social injustice.

Genesis 19:1-14

The two angels who were with the Lord at Mamre (cp. [18:2, 22](#)) visited Sodom reluctantly, knowing what kind of people lived there. Despite Lot's hospitality, they preferred lodging in the square to entering Lot's house.

Genesis 19:1-38

The Canaanites were an evil, corrupting people. God judged their morally bankrupt civilization and warned others against becoming like them. It was difficult to get Lot and his family out of Sodom; it was more difficult to get Sodom out of Lot and his family. This chapter helped later Israelites to understand the moral and spiritual threat of the peoples living in and around the Promised Land, such as the Canaanites and Lot's descendants, the Moabites and the Ammonites (see [Num 22-25](#);

[Deut 23:3-6](#); [Josh 24:9](#); [Judg 10:7-9](#); [11:4-5](#); [1 Sam 10:27](#); [1 Kgs 11:1-3](#); [2 Kgs 24:2](#)).

Genesis 19:4-5

The townsmen's vileness was matched by Lot's hypocrisy ([19:6-9](#)).

Genesis 19:6-9

Lot opposed homosexuality and rape and rebuked their wicked plans, but he was hypocritically willing to sacrifice his daughters to fend off the townsmen's vice. Lot had originally pitched his tent next to Sodom; now Sodom controlled his life.

Genesis 19:9

The men of the city were enraged by Lot's attempts to curtail their wickedness. Lot had apparently not condemned them before, since they were amazed that he now judged them.

Genesis 19:14

Lot's warning words were not taken seriously because of his hypocrisy. It seemed that there would not be even ten righteous people in the city.

Genesis 19:15-23

- Lot escaped God's judgment because of God's grace, but Lot was still hesitant to leave Sodom. Israel would forever remember Lot as someone who hesitated and needed angels to pull him to safety. The Lord was merciful and spared Lot because of Abraham ([18:23](#); [19:29](#)).
- Today, people who follow God often feel pressure to copy the wrong ways that many people live. God asks his followers to live differently from people who do not follow him. This means Christians should choose actions and behaviors that show they belong to God ([1 John 2:15-17](#)). God will judge the corrupt systems of the world. This judgment will be even more severe than the destruction of Sodom and Gomorrah ([Matthew 11:23-24](#)).

Genesis 19:18-22

Lot asked the angels for permission to live in the small town of Zoar (which means "little place") even after they saved him.

Genesis 19:23-25

Cp. [Luke 17:29](#). The eruption of Vesuvius and the destruction of Pompeii in AD 79, as well as recent natural disasters, show how quickly a thorough catastrophe like this could happen.

Genesis 19:26

looked back: The verb indicates prolonged, intense gazing toward the world she loved, not a curious glance ([15:5](#); [Exod 33:8](#); [Num 21:9](#); [1 Sam 2:32](#); cp. [Exod 3:6](#)). Lot's wife was too attached to Sodom to follow God's call of grace, so she was included in the judgment as she lingered on the valley slopes. Christ's return to judge the world will be as sudden and devastating as the destruction of Sodom ([Luke 17:32-37](#)). Those who crave the life of this wicked world will lose this world and the next.

Genesis 19:29

God listened to Abraham's plea (compare [18:23-32](#)). But Lot lost everything during the destruction of Sodom. His choice to live in the fertile land of Sodom eventually led him into a dangerous situation ([13:10-13](#)). After this, he could no longer remain in the land he had chosen.

Genesis 19:30-35

The character of Lot's daughters was formed by Sodom's culture more than by their father's heritage, so they had no qualms about having children by their drunk father (cp. [9:21-22](#)). They saw no other way to carry on their line.

Genesis 19:30-38

The poverty of the cave contrasts with the wealth Lot shared with Abram and the good life he lived in Sodom. Abraham would father a righteous nation ([17:1](#)), but Lot and his daughters gave birth to a new Sodom.

Genesis 19:36-38

The daughters' plan worked, and they each became pregnant by their own father. From these two incest-born sons came two perennial enemies of Israel, the nations of Moab and Ammon. Their grotesque wickedness was due in part to their origin. • Both daughters chose ambiguous names that hinted at their actions without raising the suspicions of those who did not know the stories.

Genesis 20:1

Gerar was near the coast in Philistine land, about twelve miles south of Gaza and fifty miles southwest of Hebron.

Genesis 20:1-18

This second "sister story" in Genesis (cp. [12:10-20](#)) occurred shortly before Sarah became pregnant with Isaac (ch [21](#)). On both occasions, God

protected Abraham and Sarah's marriage in purity for the sake of the covenant promises. Participation in God's plan requires separation from worldly corruption. • This story took place in the Promised Land; it showed Israel how God intervened in people's lives to fulfill his plan, how God continued to protect them against threats from other tribes, and how God used his chosen people to mediate his relationship with the nations. • God's preventing the destruction of Abraham's marriage by adultery reminded the Israelites to keep their marriages morally and racially pure ([Ezra 9:1–4](#); [Neh 13:23–27](#); [Mal 2:10–17](#)); they should not allow any opportunity for temptation ([Exod 20:14, 17](#); [Lev 20:10](#); [21:13–15](#)). Adultery would eventually destroy the covenant and the covenant people.

Genesis 20:2

Abraham told the same lie to Abimelech that he had told to Pharaoh ([12:13](#)); Isaac would later do the same ([26:1–11](#)), probably having learned this tactic from his father. • Abimelech (literally *my father the king*) was probably a title like "Pharaoh" ([37:36](#); [Exod 1:15](#)), not a proper name (see study note on Gen 26:1).

Genesis 20:3

that night God came . . . in a dream: God urgently intervened to stop Abimelech from violating Sarah's purity shortly before God's promise was fulfilled ([18:10](#); [21:1–3](#)).

Genesis 20:3–7

God gave Abimelech a stern warning against committing adultery; it was a capital offense (cp. [Exod 20:14](#)), viewed throughout the ancient Near East as a "great sin" ([Gen 20:9](#)).

Genesis 20:4–5

Abimelech was innocent ([20:6](#)); his conscience was clear. Nonetheless, he was about to commit adultery, and ignorance does not excuse guilt ([Lev 4:13–14](#)). • will you destroy an innocent nation? Abimelech's appeal to God echoes Abraham's earlier words (cp. [18:23–32](#)) and rebukes Abraham's lack of faith on this occasion.

Genesis 20:6

Because Abimelech acted with a clear conscience, God kept him from sinning. God will graciously help those who try to do what is right. When people act with reverence toward God, God gives them more revelation and draws them into more specific faith (see [Acts 10](#)).

Genesis 20:7

Abraham's prayer saved the king's life and restored his family ([20:17–18](#)). Abimelech learned that Abraham's God was sovereign (meaning God has complete power and authority over everything). Abraham, as God's prophet, received God's messages and would pray for others (see [Numbers 12:13](#); [Deuteronomy 9:20](#)). This was true even if he did not always act like a prophet.

Genesis 20:8–10

Abraham had earned rebukes from Abimelech and from God (cp. [12:17–19](#)). Abimelech was angry that Abraham's deception had made him guilty of this great sin (see study note on 20:3–7). He knew that taking a married woman into his harem was wrong.

Genesis 20:11–13

Abraham's duplicity was not a momentary loss of faith. Despite the rebuke he received in Egypt, he practiced this strategy wherever he went (cp. [12:12–13](#)). Living by faith requires perseverance.

Genesis 20:14–16

Abimelech showed he was an honorable person by making things right (see study note on 20:4–5). He made things right by letting Abraham live in the area. He also gave him slaves, livestock (compare [21:27](#)), and 1,000 pieces of silver to make up for any wrong done to Sarah.

Genesis 20:17–18

The infertility suggests that some time had passed. God controls births; he opens and closes wombs ([25:21](#); [29:31](#); [30:2](#), [17](#), [22–23](#); [1 Sam 1:19–20](#); [Pss 113:9](#); [127:3](#); [Luke 1:13](#)).

Genesis 21:1–2

See [Genesis 18:10](#).

Genesis 21:3–4

Abraham responded in faith by naming his son Isaac and circumcising him according to the terms of the covenant (see [17:9–14](#)).

Genesis 21:5

Isaac was born twenty-five years after the promise was first given (cp. [12:4](#)).

Genesis 21:6

Sarah's wordplay on the name *Isaac* (Hebrew *yitskhaq*, "he laughs") shows that the laughter of unbelief when the promise was given ([18:12](#)) had changed to the laughter of joy at its fulfillment. Isaac's name could refer to the pleasure of God and of his parents at his birth. Sarah knew that everyone who heard about this would laugh with her and rejoice at the news.

Genesis 21:6–7

Sarah was filled with joy and praise for this amazing event—only God could enable her to have a child.

Genesis 21:8–9

The feast for Isaac's weaning probably occurred when he was three and Ishmael was about seventeen years old ([16:16](#)). Sarah saw Ishmael making fun of her son, Isaac: The verb *metsakheq* ("making fun of") is related to the word for "laughter"; this theme ([21:6](#)) is given a sour twist by Ishmael's mockery.

Genesis 21:8–21

God used the incident of Ishmael's mocking Isaac to separate Ishmael and Hagar from the family and the child of promise. They would constantly threaten the promised descendant if they remained with the family.

Genesis 21:10

Earlier, Sarah mistreated Hagar and pressured her to flee ([16:6](#)); when Hagar's son mistreated Isaac, Sarah demanded that that slave woman and her son leave.

Genesis 21:11–13

Abraham was upset by Sarah's demand to oust Hagar and Ishmael. God told him to comply, assuring Abraham that Ishmael would also have a future as Abraham's offspring.

Genesis 21:14–21

God again rescued Hagar in the wilderness and guaranteed her future (cp. [16:7–14](#)). This passage is similar to ch [16](#), but the differences are great. Here, Hagar and Ishmael are rescued, but there is no commemorative naming. God's earlier promise to Hagar is reiterated, but this time Hagar is not told to return to Sarah. The repeated motifs on the two occasions confirm God's sovereign plan for Hagar and Ishmael. As Joseph later told Pharaoh, a twofold event demonstrated God's confirmation ([41:32](#)). God did not abandon Hagar and Ishmael but met them in their despair (cp. [16:7](#)), provided sustenance for them, and promised again that Ishmael would found a great nation ([21:13](#); cp. [16:11–12](#)). Paul uses this event in his letter to the Galatians to illustrate how God's people must relinquish all that threatens the fulfillment of God's promise ([Gal 4:21–31](#)).

Genesis 21:16

a hundred yards (literally *a bowshot*): This description connects with Ishmael's vocation ([21:20](#)).

Genesis 21:22-23

Abimelech pressed for the treaty so that Abraham would not cheat or deceive him. Abimelech knew that God was blessing Abraham even though Abraham was not entirely trustworthy ([20:9-10](#)). This sad contradiction made the treaty necessary. By contrast, God's faithful people are exhorted to speak the truth ([Eph 4:15, 25](#)), and Jesus warned against manipulating truth by the clever use of oaths ([Matt 5:37](#); [Jas 5:12](#)).

Genesis 21:22-34

This passage, at its climax, explains the name of Beersheba, Abraham's home ([21:31-34](#)). Beersheba reflected the covenant Abraham made with the residents of the land, which enabled him to dwell there in peace and prosperity. God's promise was coming to fruition ([12:7](#); [13:14-17](#); [15:7, 18-21](#); [17:8](#)).

Genesis 21:25

The motif of the well appears again (cp. [16:14](#); [21:19](#)). God provided water (a symbol of blessing) in the barren wilderness and later even brought water out of a rock for Israel ([Exod 15:22-27](#); [17:1-7](#); [Num 20:1-13](#)).

Genesis 21:27-31

Abraham's gifts to Abimelech (cp. [20:14](#)) secured his legal right to dwell peaceably in the land and to claim ownership of the well. Beersheba marked one more step toward the fulfillment of God's promise.

Genesis 21:32

The Philistines in Genesis are different from the Philistines of Judges through Kings. The earlier Philistines had Semitic names (e.g., Abimelech) and Canaanite culture. The later Philistines were apparently of Greek origin, with Greek customs and culture. They seem to have arrived in Canaan by sea from the Aegean area around 1200 BC, during the time of the judges. Probably the name of the later

Philistines was used here simply to describe the region's earlier inhabitants.

Genesis 21:33-34

A tamarisk tree requires a lot of water; this act indicated Abraham's security in his land rights and his faith that God would provide water in this desert area. He settled as a foreigner in the land, but dwelling under his tree was a sign of peaceful security (cp. [Zech 3:10](#)). • there he worshiped the Lord: See study note on 12:8.

Genesis 22:1

Some time later: Abraham had sent Ishmael away and settled in the land. Now God tested Abraham's faith by telling him to give up Isaac. This pushed the limits of logic and of Abraham's knowledge of God. Would he still obey when God seemed to be working against him and against the covenant? Would he cling to the boy or surrender him to God (see [Exod 13:11-13](#))? Did he believe that God would still keep his word and bless the world through Abraham's offspring?

Genesis 22:1-2

The greatest test in Abraham's life came after he had received the promised child following a long wait. He had grown to love Isaac and had enjoyed his presence for a number of years.

Genesis 22:2

Obedience to God's earlier call ([12:1-3](#)) was rewarded with great blessing; now Abraham had the opportunity to show even greater obedience. • Take your son . . . Isaac, whom you love so much: By this detailed description of Isaac, God reminded Abraham that the young man was his beloved son, and intensified his awareness of the cost of the sacrifice. • The name Moriah is explained by the Chronicler ([2 Chr 3:1](#)) as the place of the later Temple Mount in Jerusalem. • Go: By wording the command in this way, God helped Abraham to obey by recalling his former call (cp. [12:1-3](#)).

Genesis 22:3

Abraham's immediate, unquestioning obedience is almost as astounding as the test.

Genesis 22:5

We will worship there, and then we will come (or *We will worship there so that we may come back*): Abraham's amazing statement makes us wonder what he was thinking. Abraham knew that God had planned the future of the covenant around Isaac and that God wanted him to sacrifice Isaac. He could not reconcile these things in his mind; he could only do what God commanded him to do, and leave the future to God (cp. [Heb 11:17–19](#)).

Genesis 22:7–8

In response to Isaac's question, Abraham again showed his faith in the Lord, saying God will provide, although he was not sure how. This theme is central to the entire narrative.

Genesis 22:9–19

God's intervention was dramatic and instructive, confirming that he never intended for Isaac to be sacrificed. God later made it clear that child sacrifice was an abomination to him (see [Lev 18:21](#); [20:1–5](#); [Deut 18:10](#); [2 Kgs 16:2–3](#); [Isa 57:5](#); [Jer 32:35](#)). God wanted Abraham to sacrifice his own will and surrender it to God, and when he did, God intervened. This passage sets a pattern for all sacrificial worshipers. Like Abraham, true worshipers of God know that everything belongs to God—it all came from God and must therefore be acknowledged as God's possession. A true worshiper holds nothing back but obediently gives God what he asks, trusting that God will provide for all needs, and then discovering through experience that God always does so.

Genesis 22:11

The angel of the Lord stopped Abraham just as he was ready to plunge the knife into his son.

Genesis 22:12

Now God knew that Abraham would hold nothing back from him, that he did truly fear God. To fear the Lord means to reverence him as sovereign, trust him implicitly, and obey him without protest. The sacrifice that pleases God is a heart broken of self-will, surrendered to God ([Pss 40:6–8](#); [51:17](#)) and offering its best to God. • You have not withheld: Cp. [Rom 8:32](#), which uses the same verb ("spare") as the Greek Old Testament uses here. If God gave us his dearest possession, he will surely provide all things for us.

Genesis 22:13

God provided a ram caught by its horns in a thicket for the sacrifice. God graciously allowed Abraham to substitute an animal sacrifice in place of Isaac. Later, all Israel would offer animals to the Lord, knowing that God's grace had provided this substitution ([Exod 29:10](#); [Lev 4:15](#); [16:20–22](#)). In the New Testament, God substituted his only son for all humanity; the perfect sacrifice was made once and for all ([Isa 53:6](#), [10](#); [John 1:29](#); [Heb 7:27](#); [10:1–14](#); [1 Pet 3:18](#)).

Genesis 22:14

As with many patriarchal narratives, the heart of the matter is retained through commemorative naming. Yahweh-Yireh . . . means "the Lord will provide" (see [22:8](#)). That Abraham used the holy name in this act shows that the patriarchs knew the name Yahweh (cp. [Exod 6:2–3](#)) but not its full meaning (see study note on [Exod 6:2–3](#)). • To this day: Later Israelites understood this passage as a lesson about their own worship in Jerusalem. Abraham's sacrifice took place on the mountain of the Lord, later the location of the Temple in Jerusalem (see study note on [22:2](#)). Three times a year, the people of Israel brought their best to God as a sacrifice, trusting that he would continue to provide for their needs.

Genesis 22:15–19

After the event, God again confirmed his covenant with Abraham (cp. [15:5](#), [18–21](#); [17:3–8](#)). His descendants would be numerous like the stars in the sky (cp. [26:4](#)), like the sand on the seashore (cp.

[32:12](#)), and like the dust of the earth (cp. [13:16](#); [28:14](#)).

Genesis 22:16

by my own name: There is no higher name by which God can swear ([Heb 6:13-17](#)).

Genesis 22:17

Joshua and Old Testament Israel partially fulfilled the promise that Abraham's descendants would conquer the cities (literally *take possession of the gates*) of God's enemies; this will be fulfilled fully by the church (cp. [Matt 16:18](#) and study note there).

Genesis 22:18-25.11

Abraham passed the test of faith; from this point, his task was to pass the covenant blessings to Isaac. He purchased a burial plot (ch [23](#)), acquired a wife for Isaac (ch [24](#)), and distributed his property ([25:1-11](#)).

Genesis 22:20

Milcah, Nahor's wife, was also his niece (see [11:29](#)).

Genesis 22:20-24

A report came from the east that Abraham's brother Nahor (see [11:27-29](#)) was flourishing. The actors in the following narrative are introduced here.

Genesis 22:21

Uz might have been Job's forefather ([Job 1:1](#)).

Genesis 22:22-23

Bethuel was the youngest of Nahor's eight sons by Milcah; he was the father of Rebekah, Isaac's future wife (see [24:15](#), [67](#)). Rebekah would follow Sarah as matriarch of the clan ([23:1-2](#)).

Genesis 23:1-2

Sarah was 127 years old: Isaac was 37 at this time (cp. [17:17](#)). • Hebron: See study note on 13:18.

Genesis 23:1-20

When Sarah . . . died, Abraham acquired a parcel of land for a burial place. This transaction was the first sign that a permanent transition had taken place, as people were normally buried in their ancestral homeland (cp. [49:29-50:13](#)). In burying Sarah, Abraham detached from his just-mentioned ancestral home (where his relatives still lived, [22:20-24](#)); his future would be in Canaan, where his descendants would realize the promise.

Genesis 23:3-4

Abraham bargained with local Hittite elders for a piece of land for a burial site. These Hittites had apparently migrated south to Canaan from the great Hittite empire in eastern Asia Minor (modern Turkey; cp. [10:15](#)). • Abraham was a stranger and a foreigner among these people; his hope was in God's promise that he would eventually possess the land.

Genesis 23:5-6

my lord, you are an honored prince: Either Abraham was highly regarded by these people, or they were politely appealing to his generosity. • Choose the finest. . . . No one here will refuse: They were willing to accommodate his request, especially if they could legally obligate him to themselves ([23:11](#)).

Genesis 23:7-16

Abraham wanted to buy Ephron's cave at Machpelah, but Ephron wanted him to buy the entire field.

Genesis 23:9

This would be a permanent burial place for Abraham's family. The site was near Mamre ([23:19](#)), where Abraham lived (see [13:18](#); [14:13](#); [18:1](#)). Abraham and Sarah, Isaac and Rebekah, and Jacob and Leah would all be buried in this cave ([23:19](#); [25:9](#); [35:27–29](#); [49:29–31](#); [50:13](#)), their permanent place in the Promised Land.

Genesis 23:11

Ephron did not intend to give the cave to Abraham; Abraham was expected to “give” the full price in return. Ephron wanted to sell as much as he could to avoid responsibility for caring for the cave and to receive as high a price as possible.

Genesis 23:12–13

Abraham didn't want the whole field, but he was willing to take it to get the cave.

Genesis 23:15

400 pieces of silver was a very high price. Ephron's politeness was typical of the bargaining process.

Genesis 23:16–20

Abraham paid the amount and finalized the transaction, avoiding indebtedness by accepting no gifts from the people (cp. [14:21–24](#)). The Hittite elders witnessed the transaction, ensuring that no one could challenge Abraham's full ownership of the land. The transaction took place at the city gate, where public legal and business dealings were conducted (cp. [19:1](#)). The land became Abraham's permanent possession, a down payment on God's promise to give him the land. Abraham knew that God's promise was not fulfilled ([12:7](#)) by this acquisition, so he planned for the future. By buying land for his dead, he declared that God's promises do not end with this life. This is the hope of all who die in faith.

Genesis 24:1–9

Confident in the Lord's promise, Abraham had his chief servant (probably Eliezer, [15:2](#)) swear to find a wife among Abraham's relatives in his homeland, some 450 miles away. Abraham was faithful to the covenant by preparing for Isaac's future.

Genesis 24:1–67

Isaac's marriage to Rebekah ensured that God's plan would continue into the next generation. God showed covenant faithfulness by working through his faithful people ([24:12](#), [27](#), [49](#)).

Genesis 24:2

Putting his hand under Abraham's thigh (cp. [47:29](#)), the servant took a very solemn oath, assuming the burden of completing this mission.

Genesis 24:3

Isaac knew how wicked and threatening the local Canaanite people were, so he maintained separation from them (cp. [26:34–35](#); [27:46](#); [28:8–9](#)).

Genesis 24:6–8

Under no circumstances was the servant to take Isaac from the Promised Land to seek a wife. Abraham ensured Isaac's safety and secured God's promises in the land of blessing.

Genesis 24:10

Aram-naharaim (“Aram of the two rivers”) was also called *Paddan-aram* (“the field of Aram,” cp. [25:20](#)). It was a two-week journey in each direction, so the servant had ten . . . camels for provisions and gifts ([24:22](#), [53](#)).

Genesis 24:10–27

The servant obeyed his master's instructions and trusted God to lead him to the right woman.

Genesis 24:10–60

The servant faithfully carried out the mission, and he glorified God in displaying faithful covenant love for Abraham's family by bringing all the details together. God sovereignly worked behind the scenes to accomplish his will through the circumstances of those acting responsibly in faith.

Genesis 24:14

Abraham's future daughter-in-law manifested hospitality and industry like Abraham's (see [18:1–8](#)). Ten thirsty camels could drink 250 gallons of water, so a woman who would work that hard for a stranger was certainly not lazy, but generous and hospitable.

Genesis 24:15–22

The servant received a precise, immediate answer to his prayer for guidance.

Genesis 24:22

The servant showed his gratitude by giving the girl expensive jewelry.

Genesis 24:23–24

God led the servant to Abraham's family.

Genesis 24:25

Rebekah again showed kindness by offering lodging for the servant and food for his camels.

Genesis 24:26

The servant bowed to the ground and worshiped the Lord for his loyal love and faithfulness in guiding him to the exact family he sought.

Genesis 24:27

The Lord has shown unfailing love and faithfulness to my master: These words express this chapter's message (cp. [24:48](#)). Believers can trust the Lord's leading because he is sovereign in all things. He never leaves his people to their own resources in carrying out his covenant work.

Genesis 24:29–31

Laban . . . ran: He was not going to miss the chance to marry his sister off and receive more gifts. Laban's response to the servant's wealth foreshadows his avaricious character (see [24:54–56](#) and study note; [29:21–27](#); [30:27–36](#); [31:1–13](#)).

Genesis 24:33–48

The servant was not diverted from his mission; he insisted on telling his story before he would eat. He recounted his mission and acknowledged God's providence in directing him to Rebekah before attending to his personal needs. The servant wanted everyone to know that this was God's work, not a chance or humanly arranged meeting.

Genesis 24:48

The way that God directed this event from behind the scenes is different than in most of Genesis, but it is true to how the life of faith normally works. Faith, expressed in personal prayer and obedience, looks for evidence of God's working. Believers usually have to make wise choices and remain faithful to the covenant, trusting that God will guide them through the circumstances of life to accomplish his will.

Genesis 24:50–51

Following his testimony about God's guidance, the servant secured the family's blessing and permission to take Rebekah to his master's son Isaac.

Genesis 24:53

The servant gave expensive gifts to Rebekah, her mother, and her brother to conclude the arrangements.

Genesis 24:54–56

It was hard for Rebekah's family to let her go so suddenly, and Laban may have hoped to gain more wealth. However, the servant had sworn an oath and would not rest until it was completed. There was no reason for him to stay.

Genesis 24:57–58

Rebekah's decision to leave immediately to be with her new husband settled the impasse. Rebekah submitted to the Lord's obvious leading. Young women were normally eager to marry (not to marry was a catastrophe), and later accounts of Laban suggest why Rebekah preferred to leave (cp. [31:14–15](#)). Rebekah displayed faithful love to the servant, Abraham's family, and Isaac by going to be Isaac's wife.

Genesis 24:60

At Rebekah's departure, her family invoked the blessing that she would be a mother of many millions and that her descendants would conquer . . . their enemies. Rebekah's marriage to Isaac was part of God's plan to bless all humankind ([12:1–3](#)).

Genesis 24:62

Isaac lived in the Negev, in the southern part of Canaan.

Genesis 24:67

Isaac was 40 years old when he married Rebekah ([25:20](#)), so Abraham was 140 ([21:5](#)).

Genesis 25:1

Exactly when Abraham married . . . Keturah is unknown. It was probably, but not necessarily, after Sarah's death.

Genesis 25:1–11

Though Abraham had sons by another wife, he safeguarded Isaac's inheritance and blessing.

Genesis 25:2–4

The birth of these nations from Abraham partially fulfilled God's promise to him ([12:2](#); [17:4](#)).

Genesis 25:3

Sheba and Dedan: Cp. [10:7](#). Abraham's descendants probably settled in these regions and became identified by their names, along with people of other lineage.

Genesis 25:5–6

Abraham loved all his sons, so before he died, he gave them gifts and sent them away as he had sent Ishmael ([21:8–14](#)). In this way, he preserved Isaac's position as his heir.

Genesis 25:7–8

Abraham's death is recorded before the births of Jacob and Esau, but he lived until they were fifteen years old ([25:19–26](#); cp. [21:5](#); [25:26](#)). This literary arrangement closes Abraham's story before focusing on Isaac's family.

Genesis 25:11

God's blessing transferred to Isaac; Abraham's other sons had been sent away. Isaac lived near Beer-lahai-roi—a special place where God had answered prayer ([16:14](#)) and where Isaac waited on the Lord ([24:62](#)).

Genesis 25:12–18

This record lists Ishmael's descendants before tracing Isaac's ([25:19–35:29](#)), which is in keeping with the literary arrangement of Genesis (see Genesis Book Introduction, "Summary").

Genesis 25:16

Ishmael's twelve sons fulfilled God's promise of blessing ([17:20](#)).

Genesis 25:18

Havilah was a region in north-central Arabia. • Shur was a region between Beersheba and Egypt. • in open hostility toward all their relatives: The wording is close to that of [16:12](#).

Genesis 25:19–20

Isaac . . . married Rebekah: Isaac's marriage tied him and his family even more closely to Abraham's ancestors. Had he married a Canaanite, the covenant faith would have been imperiled by this corrupt, syncretistic people.

Genesis 25:19–26

Jacob's struggle for supremacy began before the twins were born (see [Hos 12:3](#)).

Genesis 25:19–35.29

This account of the family of Isaac, the chosen son of Abraham, mostly recounts Jacob's struggle for the blessing ([25:27–34](#); chs [27–33](#)).

Genesis 25:21

For twenty years, Rebekah was barren (cp. [25:20, 26](#)), like Sarah (see [16:1](#)). This condition tested their faith (see study note on [16:1–3](#)). How could they be childless when God promised that nations would issue from them? • Isaac pleaded with the Lord and the Lord answered Isaac's prayer. Isaac apparently learned from his father's mistake and responded in faith.

Genesis 25:22

When the pregnancy was difficult, Rebekah went to ask the Lord about it, probably by visiting a prophet—perhaps Abraham ([20:7](#); see study note on [25:7–8](#)).

Genesis 25:23

rivals: Jacob and Esau fought in the womb, and their descendants (Israel and Edom) fought continuously throughout their history. In their many conflicts, Israel achieved supremacy over Edom. • your older son will serve your younger son: God's choice of the younger son over the elder ran against natural order (cp. [48:12–14](#); see [Mal 1:1–3](#); [Rom 9:11–16](#)).

Genesis 25:24–26

When the twins were born, the unusual circumstances inspired each boy's name and hinted at what would happen to them in the future.

Genesis 25:25

Two wordplays anticipate Esau's later life. Esau sounds like Hebrew *se'ar*, which means "hair"; Esau's later homeland, Edom, was known as *Seir* ("hairy") because it was wooded (as though covered with hair). • red (Hebrew *'admoni*) sounds like Esau's other name, Edom ([25:27–34](#)); Edom had red soil. • Esau's >hair was like the fur coat of an animal, foreshadowing his unspiritual character ([25:34](#); [Heb 12:16](#); cp. [Lev 26:22](#); [Deut 7:22](#); [1 Cor 15:32](#)). The description of the child uses words that highlight the Edomites' nature.

Genesis 25:26

The name Jacob (Hebrew *ya'aqob*, from Hebrew *'aqeb*, "heel, footprint") was originally positive, meaning "protect" (like a rear guard), but it took on the negative meaning of "heel grabber" or "deceiver" in the context of Jacob's deceptive, grasping, usurping character (see [27:36](#)).

Genesis 25:27

Esau was a skillful hunter and an outdoorsman—a wild man who loved wild country. Jacob had a quiet (or *even*) temperament and preferred to stay at home (literally *dwelling in tents*)—i.e., he was civilized.

Genesis 25:27–34

Jacob and Esau each developed in accord with his initial characteristics ([25:24–26](#)). Esau, the reddish, hairy man, cared about physical things rather than spiritual things (see [Heb 12:16](#)); he was finally overcome by physical appetites and sold his birthright. Jacob, the heel grabber, knew the birthright's value and drove a ruthless bargain to gain it presumptuously from his brother.

Genesis 25:28

The parents each practiced favoritism. • because: Isaac's love for Esau was conditioned upon his son's performance. Rebekah's love for Jacob was constant and unconditional.

Genesis 25:29

Ironically, Jacob proved the more cunning hunter. The word cooking (Hebrew wayyazed, “boiling”) sounds like the word for “hunter” (Hebrew tsayid). While boiling stew, Jacob was laying a trap for the hairy red animal. He may have waited a long time for this opportunity. This word for “boil” was also used for presumptuous action (like water boiling over the rim of the pot). Jacob overstepped his boundaries when he seized the promise for himself. By contrast, Abraham knew the promise was his and was secure in giving the land away (see study note on 13:8–13). • Esau was exhausted and hungry, but his life was not in danger ([25:32](#); see study note on 25:33–34).

Genesis 25:30

Esau was preoccupied with his appetite. Being driven by one's appetites leaves no place for spiritual values. The text emphasizes this by using a Hebrew word (translated give) that was normally

used for feeding animals. • Edom, which means “red”: See study note on 25:25.

Genesis 25:31–33

Jacob was the better hunter on this occasion, but great danger lay in exercising such strong ambition. God's people should desire the things of God, but they must not seek them in the flesh (see [Zech 4:6](#); [Gal 5:16–17](#); [Eph 6:10–12](#)). The Lord dealt severely with Jacob to purge him of carnal methods. He later received the promise not as crafty Jacob the usurper, but as Israel (meaning, “God fights”), with God fighting on his behalf ([Gen 32:28](#)).

Genesis 25:33–34

Esau eagerly took Jacob's bait and fell into the trap. He ate and left too quickly to have been near death ([25:32](#)). The final comment on the passage explains that Esau showed contempt for his birthright, considering it worthless ([Heb 12:16](#)). It is foolish to sacrifice spiritual blessings to satisfy physical appetites (cp. [Gen 3:6](#)).

Genesis 26:1

This Abimelech is probably not the man in ch [20](#), for these events could have been 90 years apart. Possibly Abimelech was a dynastic name or title (a later King Achish, [1 Sam 21:10](#), was also called Abimelech, [Ps 34:title](#)).

Genesis 26:1–35

In this digression from Jacob's story, Isaac's prosperity (ch [26](#)) shows that the blessing had passed to him (cp. [25:11](#)) despite his failures of faith.

Genesis 26:2–5

The Lord assured Isaac that the covenant promises (cp. [12:2–3](#); [15:5–8](#); [17:3–8](#); [22:15–18](#); [28:13–14](#)) would pass to him because Abraham faithfully listened to God and obeyed all his requirements, commands, decrees, and instructions. These terms were later used in Deuteronomy to describe God's

full legal covenant with Israel. An Israelite reader would immediately think of the complete Torah when hearing these words and be prompted to obey God's law as Abraham did, though Abraham had only a few commands from the Lord. Through these words, the text emphasizes that Abraham would have obeyed the later commands if he had had them, because he was an obedient servant of the Lord.

Genesis 26:6–11

While staying in Gerar, Isaac, like his father, deceived people into believing that his wife was his sister. Some suppose that this story duplicates the stories of Abraham's deception ([12:10–20](#); [20:1–18](#)), but the differences are greater than the similarities, and the son's repetition of his father's lie is natural. Through numerous parallels with Abraham, ch [26](#) shows how God's plan continued with Isaac. Even when Isaac jeopardized the covenant as his father had, God prevented disaster and preserved the marriage. Abraham's descendants would be blessed because of Abraham, but they had to exercise their own faith to enjoy the blessings. Genuine faith in God's promises engenders a fearless walk with him; cowering in fear endangers the blessing and mocks the faith.

Genesis 26:8

Abimelech . . . saw Isaac caressing Rebekah: The word for "caressing" (Hebrew *metsakheq*) is the same as the word used for Ishmael's "making fun of" Isaac ([21:9](#)); the word is related to the name "Isaac" (Hebrew *yitskhaq*). It is as though Isaac's lapse of faith made fun of Abimelech and made a mockery of Rebekah and the great promise embodied in Isaac's name.

Genesis 26:10–11

Isaac, like his father, was rebuked by Abimelech (see study note on [20:1–18](#)). This legal wording would remind Israel of how important it was to preserve marital purity. Abimelech recognized the danger to his own people. Though his decree preserved his own society, it was also a word from God that preserved the sanctity of Isaac's and

Israel's marriages. If Isaac's marriage had ended here, there would have been no Israelite society.

Genesis 26:12–13

Isaac lived in the land as a temporary settler, enjoying abundant prosperity because of God's blessing; his crops flourished and he became very rich.

Genesis 26:14–16

The Philistines envied Isaac's prosperity and filled his wells with dirt. The king then ordered Isaac to leave that region because he was too powerful for them (cp. [21:22–23](#)).

Genesis 26:17–22

Isaac moved . . . to the Gerar Valley (away from the city of Gerar itself, [26:6](#), but probably still within ten miles) and reopened his father's wells. Isaac was also opposed there, but chose not to fight back; he relinquished one well after another until God's blessing outdid the opposition. Whenever Isaac reopened a well, and regardless of how often enemies caused them to cave in, he found water. God was blessing Isaac and that blessing could not be hindered. Finally, the Philistines left Isaac alone.

Genesis 26:23–25

At Beersheba, . . . the Lord appeared to Isaac to confirm his covenant (cp. [21:31–33](#)). Isaac responded in faith as his father had done by building an altar to the Lord and proclaiming the Lord's identity and nature (see study note on [12:8](#); [21:33](#)).

Genesis 26:26–33

This treaty is similar to the one an earlier king had made with Abraham (cp. [21:22–31](#)). This king acknowledged that God was blessing Isaac and realized that a treaty with Isaac would benefit him. No opposition can hinder God's blessing—it will flourish, and other nations will see it and seek peace with God's people to share in the blessing.

Genesis 26:33

Since the earlier treaty was renewed with Isaac, the name of the well was also renewed by the oath.

Genesis 26:34–35

Esau's marriages illustrate how unfit he was to lead the covenant people into God's blessings, and how foolish was Isaac's later attempt to bless Esau ([27:1–40](#)). Esau later married a third wife in a vain attempt to do the right thing ([28:6–9](#)).

Genesis 27:1–4

The first scene sets up the chapter's crisis. Isaac knew of God's oracle ([25:22–23](#)), yet he thwarted or ignored it by trying to bless Esau. • Isaac was old and turning blind: He was losing his senses, both physically and spiritually.

Genesis 27:1–40

Jacob got his father Isaac's blessing through deception. In this story, an entire family tries to carry out their responsibilities by physical means rather than by faith. Faith would have provided Rebekah and Jacob a more honorable solution to the crisis.

Genesis 27:3–4

Like Esau, Isaac allowed his palate to govern his heart (cp. [25:28–34](#)).

Genesis 27:5

Esau agreed to Isaac's plan, thus breaking the oath he had sworn to Jacob ([25:33](#)).

Genesis 27:5–17

The blessing seemed to be in jeopardy. In scene two, Rebekah and Jacob sought to achieve God's blessing by deception, without faith or love. Rebekah planned to deceive the old man into

thinking that he was blessing Esau when he was actually blessing Jacob.

Genesis 27:11–12

Jacob had no qualms about this deception; he only feared that it might not work and that he would be cursed for trying.

Genesis 27:18–20

Jacob lied about his identity, and then came close to blasphemy by lying about God.

Genesis 27:18–29

In scene three, Jacob deceives his father and receives the blessing.

Genesis 27:20–27

Isaac voiced his suspicion three times but was finally deceived by his senses, which were not functioning well (see study note on 27:1–4).

Genesis 27:30–40

In scene four, everything is discovered, and the family becomes even more divided.

Genesis 27:33

When he realized what had happened, Isaac began to tremble uncontrollably; he had been tampering with God's plan, and God had overruled him.

Genesis 27:34–35

Esau was very bitter, and angry enough to kill ([27:41](#)).

Genesis 27:36

Esau began to realize Jacob's true nature, saying he has cheated me (or *tripped me up*, or *deceived me*)

twice, by taking the birthright (the right of inheritance, Hebrew *bekorah*; [25:27-34](#)) and by deceiving their father to receive the blessing (the spoken pronouncement of the inheritance, Hebrew *berakah*). • Esau's assessment of Jacob was correct, but he failed to see his own ungodliness in these transactions (see study note on 27:5; [Heb 12:16](#)).

Genesis 27:37

There was no going back. Isaac had declared an oracle from God, who had made Jacob to be Esau's master (see [Rom 9:11-13](#)).

Genesis 27:39-40

All that remained for Esau was a promise of hardship and struggle (cp. [3:17-19](#); [16:11-12](#)).

Genesis 27:41-45

Rebekah and Jacob got the blessing but reaped hatred from Esau and separation from one another; there is no indication that Rebekah and Jacob ever saw each other again. They gained nothing that God was not already going to give them, and their methods were costly. Jacob fled from home to escape Esau's vengeance.

Genesis 27:42-33.17

Jacob met the Lord on a road that Abraham had traveled 125 years earlier. The story in [27:42-33:17](#) follows a pattern (called a "chiasm") focusing on Jacob's exile:

- A: Jacob runs away from Esau ([27:42-28:9](#))
 - B: Angels of God meet Jacob at Bethel ([28:10-22](#))
 - C: Jacob lives in exile in Paddan-aram ([29:1-31:55](#))
 - B': Angels of God meet Jacob at Mahanaim ([32:1-2](#))
- A': Jacob reconciles with Esau ([32:3-33:17](#)).

Genesis 27:46

Rebekah convinced Isaac to send Jacob away by carefully planning her words and actions. Like Isaac, Jacob married a woman from his relatives who lived in the east.

Genesis 28:1-2

Isaac remained in the land, but Jacob had to leave it. God would deal with Jacob under the hand of Laban, his uncle (see study note on 29:1-31:55). • Believers in any age must remain spiritually pure by marrying other believers ([2 Cor 6:14-18](#)). The Canaanite people incorporated dozens of groups and clans into their society and religion by wars, treaties, and marriages (see [Gen 34:20-23](#)). Abraham's family was to resist such mixing (cp. [24:3](#); ch [34](#)); they were to marry within their clan to maintain the purity of the line and of the faith that identified them as the chosen seed. The surest way to lose their distinctiveness was to intermarry with people of other tribal backgrounds and beliefs (see [Ezra 9-10](#); [Neh 13:23-29](#)).

Genesis 28:3-5

Before Jacob departed, Isaac gave him a pure, legitimate blessing. He did not hold back, because he now knew what God wanted him to do. Isaac clearly passed on the blessing God Almighty (Hebrew *El-Shaddai*; see [17:1](#)) had given to Abraham and to him regarding prosperity and the land (cp. [15:5](#), [18-20](#)).

Genesis 28:6–9

Esau, the unchosen son still trying to please his father, married a woman from the unchosen line of Ishmael, which he thought would be more acceptable. He did not understand the uniqueness of the covenant family.

Genesis 28:10–22

Despite Jacob's previous means of securing the blessing, God assured him of protection and provision. The God of Abraham and Isaac was also the God of Jacob. The revelation dramatically changed Jacob's outlook and brought faith into clearer focus.

Genesis 28:11

The good place where Jacob set up camp was apparently a protected area at the foot of a hill. The stone to rest his head against was probably large, more for protection than for a pillow.

Genesis 28:12–13

stairway (traditionally *ladder*): This word occurs nowhere else in Scripture. The imagery probably reminded readers of a staircase or ramp up the front of a ziggurat that signified communication between heaven and earth (see study note on 11:4). God initiated a divine communication between heaven and earth to guide and protect Jacob, the steward of his covenant (28:13–15; see [Ps 91:11–15](#)). • Jesus said that he himself is the stairway between heaven and earth ([John 1:51](#)).

Genesis 28:12–15

The point of the vision was that God and his angels were with Jacob on his journey. God reiterated to Jacob the covenant promises made to Abraham and Isaac, promising him land, descendants numerous as the dust (cp. [13:16](#); [22:17](#)), and universal blessing through him (cp. [12:2–3](#); [15:5](#), [18](#); [17:3–8](#); [22:15–18](#); [35:11–12](#)). God also promised to be with Jacob and watch over him until he returned.

Genesis 28:14

Jacob inherited Abraham's entire covenant (see [22:17](#)), which confirmed Isaac's blessing ([28:3–4](#)) and stipulated a temporary exile ([28:15](#); see [15:12–16](#)).

Genesis 28:15

I am with you: The promise of God's presence meant that God would protect and provide for Jacob in a special way. God's promise to be with his people is repeated throughout Scripture (see also [26:24](#)), prompting a response of worship and confidence in those who have faith ([28:16–22](#)).

Genesis 28:16–22

The second half of the passage gives Jacob's response to the revelation. He felt reverential fear and awe in the Lord's presence, and his acts of devotion became archetypes of Israel's worship. When God graciously visits his people and promises to be with them and make them a blessing to the world, his people respond in faith with reverential fear, worship, offerings, and vows. They preserve their faith in memory for future worshipers.

Genesis 28:18

Anointing with oil became a way of setting something apart for divine use in Israel's worship ([Exod 29:1–7](#); [40:9](#); [Lev 2:1](#); [1 Sam 10:1](#)).

Genesis 28:19

Bethel later became a holy site for Israel (see [Judg 20:18–27](#); [1 Sam 7:16](#); [10:3](#); [1 Kgs 12:26–13:10](#); [2 Kgs 2:2–3](#)).

Genesis 28:20–22

In view of what God would do for him, Jacob vowed to do certain things for God. He believed the Lord's words and responded in gratitude. Jacob's vow influenced Israel's way of making commitments to God in worship.

Genesis 28:22

I will present to God a tenth: By paying a tithe (*a tenth*) as an act of worship, a person acknowledges that everything is a gift from God and belongs to God (see [14:19–20](#); [Num 18:21–32](#); [Deut 14:22–29](#); [2 Chr 31:5–6](#); [Mal 3:7–12](#); [Matt 23:23](#)).

Genesis 29:1

Jacob hurried on: The Hebrew text says that he “picked up his feet” as if he felt the wind at his back; he continued his journey with fresh enthusiasm. His changed outlook was the direct result of the vision he received at Bethel, a marvelous revelation that God was going to protect and bless him. He now sought the fulfillment of God’s promises to him, not just an escape from Esau. Jacob’s attitude had become positive and magnanimous to the point of being naive and vulnerable.

Genesis 29:1–31:55

These chapters tell how God kept his promise by abundantly blessing Jacob with family and possessions. God also disciplined Jacob, leaving him to struggle with Laban for many years. Laban was Jacob’s match in deception, and thus a means of correction. • The story of Jacob and Laban parallels Israel’s later sojourn in Egypt. Jacob struggled while serving his uncle but finally emerged with a large family (the founders of the twelve tribes) and great wealth. In Egypt, the Israelites suffered under their oppressors, but they also flourished, becoming a great nation of twelve large tribes and escaping with great riches.

Genesis 29:2–12

Jacob’s meeting Rachel at the well was providentially timed by the sovereign God who was leading Jacob to fulfillment of the promises (cp. [24:12–20](#)). The well was a reminder of God’s blessing (cp. [16:13–14](#); [21:19](#); [26:19–25](#), [33](#)).

Genesis 29:10

In contrast to the lazy, unhelpful shepherds ([29:7–8](#)), Jacob is portrayed as generous, industrious, and energetic. • Jacob . . . watered his uncle’s flock: Laban’s flocks would flourish under Jacob’s care.

Genesis 29:11

Jacob kissed Rachel: Kissing relatives was a proper greeting ([29:13](#); cp. [Song 8:1](#)).

Genesis 29:14

You really are my own flesh and blood! Laban welcomed Jacob into his house and treated him much like a son.

Genesis 29:14–30

Jacob’s joyful prospect of marriage to the lovely Rachel became an occasion for Laban’s shrewdness and Jacob’s discipline. Jacob and his mother had deceived his father and brother to gain the blessing; now his mother’s brother deceived him. Jacob received a dose of his own duplicity through twenty years of labor, affliction, and deception in Laban’s service ([31:38](#)). In God’s justice, people harvest what they plant ([Gal 6:7](#)). Laban’s deception was perfectly designed to make Jacob aware of his own craftiness. God often brings people into the lives of believers to discipline them. But Jacob was tenacious, and God blessed him abundantly with a large family and many possessions ([30:25–43](#)) during this time of service.

Genesis 29:18

Seven years of service was a high bride-price in the ancient world, but Rachel was beautiful (like Sarah and Rebekah), and Jacob was in love with her.

Genesis 29:23–26

Like Isaac, Jacob was plied with food and wine (cp. [27:25](#)), deprived of sight in the darkness (cp. [27:1](#)), baffled by clothing (cp. [27:15](#)), and misled by touch (cp. [27:23](#)). The marriage had been consummated ([29:23](#); see [2:24](#)), so Jacob was bound to Leah. • It’s

not our custom here to marry off a younger daughter ahead of the firstborn: Laban's words are a reminder of what Jacob did when he, the younger son, pretended to be his older brother to gain the blessing (ch [27](#)). Now Leah, the older sister, pretended to be the younger sister to get a husband. God gave the deceiver a dose of his own deception as a discipline in his life.

Genesis 29:28–30

After the bridal week ended ([29:27](#)), Jacob also received Rachel as his wife, though he then would have to work an additional seven years (cp. [31:41](#)). Laban seemed to have gained the upper hand.

Genesis 29:30

Jacob loved Rachel much more than Leah: Favoritism was an ongoing cause of dysfunction in Jacob's family (cp. [25:28](#); [37:3](#)). Jacob's favoritism had lasting effects: his family was never together, and their descendants, the tribes of Israel, were rarely unified.

Genesis 29:31–35

Leah's first four sons were born in rapid succession, but Rachel could not conceive. She was barren, like Sarah and Rebekah (cp. [16:1](#); [25:21](#); see also [1 Sam 1:1–28](#); [Luke 1:5–25](#)). • Each name is a memorable wordplay on Leah's experience and hopes.

Genesis 29:31–30.24

The rivalry between these sisters explains much of the later rivalry among their sons, and then among the tribes, just as the rivalry between Jacob and Laban foreshadowed conflict between Israel and the Arameans of Damascus ([2 Sam 8:5–6](#); [10:8–19](#); [1 Kgs 20:1–34](#); [2 Kgs 5:1–8:29](#); [13:1–25](#); [Isa 7:1–9](#)). • God champions the cause of the poor and oppressed; he exalted Leah, the despised first wife, as the first to become a mother. Judah's kingly tribe and Levi's priestly line came through her despite Jacob's favoritism for Rachel and her children. Despite the tension and jealousy resulting from Laban's treachery and Jacob's favoritism, God still

built Jacob's family and brought about the births of the tribal ancestors.

Genesis 29:32

Reuben (Hebrew re'uben) sounds like the Hebrew for "He has seen my misery" (ra'ah be'onyi). His birth gave Leah consolation from God and hope for Jacob's love. Jacob seems not to have seen her misery, but God did (cp. [16:14](#); [24:62](#); [25:11](#)). The name was a reminder of God's intervention.

Genesis 29:33

Leah named her second son Simeon. The name suggests that she had cried out to the Lord and was heard (cp. [16:11](#)).

Genesis 29:34

Leah named her third son Levi, hoping that her husband would become "attached" to her since she had given him three sons. This hope was not fulfilled.

Genesis 29:35

Leah reconciled herself to the reality that nothing would turn Jacob's affections toward her. She named her fourth son Judah with the sentiment, "I will praise the Lord." She seems to have given up on Jacob, taking her consolation from the Lord.

Genesis 30:1–2

In that culture, it was like death for a woman not to have children (cp. [1 Sam 1](#)); only God could open Rachel's womb.

Genesis 30:1–8

Rachel's naming of sons through Bilhah does not reflect faith as Leah's namings had. Rachel felt wronged over the marriage and her barrenness. The names of Bilhah's sons reflect Rachel's bitter struggle with her sister and her feeling of some victory.

Genesis 30:3-4

Rachel's decision to have children through her servant, and Jacob's compliance, recall Sarai's use of Hagar ([16:1-4](#)).

Genesis 30:5-6

Dan means "he judged" or "he vindicated." Rachel felt vindicated (Hebrew *dananni*) by Dan's birth.

Genesis 30:7-8

The name Naphtali is related to the clause I have struggled hard (Hebrew *naptule 'elohim niptalti*, "I have struggled the struggles of God").

Genesis 30:9

When Leah saw that she had stopped bearing children, she countered Rachel's effort by giving her servant . . . to Jacob as a wife even though she already had four sons.

Genesis 30:10-13

Gad (meaning "fortune") was the name of a god associated with fortune. *Asher* (meaning "happy") was the name of a god associated with luck. These names show Leah's pagan background, but there is no indication she believed in these gods.

Genesis 30:14-17

People believed *mandrakes* could increase sexual desire and help women become pregnant (see [Song 7:13](#)). Rachel hoped they would help her become pregnant, so she made a deal with Leah. Rachel would let Leah spend one night with Jacob in exchange for mandrakes. Yet, Leah became pregnant, not Rachel.

Genesis 30:18

The name Issachar captures the sense of Jacob's being hired ([30:16](#)) and of the Lord's rewarding Leah (Hebrew *sekari*, "my hire").

Genesis 30:19-20

Zebulun means "honor" or "gift," as in a dowry or tribute. Leah thought that God gave her Zebulun so that her husband would honor her. This hope never fully left her.

Genesis 30:21

Dinah was Jacob's only daughter. See ch [34](#).

Genesis 30:22-24

Rachel finally gave birth to her own son, Joseph. His birth was brought about by God's intervention, not by superstitious practices ([30:14-16](#)) or the social custom of giving servants as wives. • Removed (Hebrew *'asap*, "take away") sounds similar to Joseph (Hebrew *yosep*, "may he add"). Rachel rejoiced over Joseph's birth, yet she prayed that the Lord would add yet another son to her family.

Genesis 30:25-34

After his fourteen years of service, Jacob asked Laban for permission to go home. The two bedouin leaders negotiated politely but remained cautiously on guard. Laban wanted to get more out of Jacob. Jacob wanted to gain his wages by selective breeding.

Genesis 30:27

I have become wealthy: God had prospered Laban through Jacob's presence (see [22:18](#)). Laban may have looked for omens, or simply have perceived what was happening. Since dark-colored sheep ([30:32](#)) were rare, a large number of them was considered an omen of God's blessing.

Genesis 30:30–33

Jacob agreed that God had blessed Laban through him, so he made a plan to gain something for himself. He proposed for his wages the rare black and multicolored goats and the speckled and spotted sheep that were born.

Genesis 30:32

As Abraham had done with Lot ([13:9](#)), Jacob gave Laban what he valued most. White sheep were more common and more valuable than dark or multicolored sheep; as a man of faith, Jacob was willing to take the rejects (cp. [1 Cor 1:26](#)).

Genesis 30:34–36

Laban verbally agreed with Jacob's plan, but he tried to prevent Jacob from accruing wealth by removing animals from the flock that would fulfill the agreement. • Laban's deception with his goats reminds us of Jacob's deception of Esau (cp. [27:9](#); see study note on 29:14–30).

Genesis 30:37

exposing the white inner wood: This clever wordplay explains the entire section. When Jacob *exposed the white* (Hebrew *laban*) streaks of wood underneath, he played the "white" game (the *Laban* game) and won. By outsmarting Laban ("Whitey"), Jacob's flocks increased and he became successful.

Genesis 30:37–43

God blessed Jacob despite Laban's duplicity. Not to be outwitted, Jacob used selective breeding to acquire a flock, following the traditional belief that peeled sticks influenced the kind of animal that would be born. The peeled branches seemingly made his animals produce streaked and spotted young; Jacob later acknowledged that God had prospered him ([31:7–12](#)). Jacob gained stronger animals for himself and weaker ones for Laban ([30:41–42](#)).

Genesis 30:42

Laban now received due recompense for his treatment of Jacob. Laban's attempt to defraud Jacob resulted in Jacob's coming out ahead, because God was at work in his life.

Genesis 30:43

Jacob became very wealthy, in fulfillment of God's promises to him ([27:28](#); [28:13–15](#)).

Genesis 31:1–2

The animosity of Laban's sons against Jacob grew because his flocks were multiplying faster than Laban's. They were jealous of God's blessing on Jacob and afraid that he would completely overrun them.

Genesis 31:1–21

Jacob's return journey precipitated a confrontation with Laban that set a permanent boundary between Israel (Jacob) and Aram (Laban). God kept his word to Jacob by prospering him in Paddan-aram and protecting him on his journey home.

Genesis 31:3

- *the land of your fathers* was Canaan, to which God had called Abraham ([12:1–7](#); [17:8](#)).
- *Go back ... I will be with you*: See study notes on 26:2–5; 28:12–15. God protected Jacob (also called “Israel,” [32:28](#)) as he led his family back to the land God promised them. Later, God brought Israel back to Canaan after many years of slavery in Egypt. This return had many similarities to this passage:
 - God defeated foreign gods and beliefs.
 - He used dreams for rescue and protection.
 - He gave victory over threats.
 - He set boundaries between nations and tribes (see [Deuteronomy 32:8](#)).

Genesis 31:4–13

Jacob explained to his wives how God had blessed him despite Laban’s opposition. He was not sure they would want to leave Laban and go to Canaan. He wanted to take a willing family, so he had to make an effective appeal. He rehearsed God’s leading and provision over the years and then told them that he had to keep the vow he had made at Bethel ([28:20–22](#)).

Genesis 31:14–16

The women responded immediately that they would go with Jacob because God had blessed him. They were very willing to leave Laban, who had squandered their wealth (the property that would have provided for them). They knew that what God had given to Jacob would also be theirs.

Genesis 31:17–21

Jacob left Laban secretly out of fear of reprisal ([31:31](#)).

Genesis 31:19–20

Rachel stole her father’s household idols: Rachel probably wanted to regain some of the assets Laban had squandered; possibly she also worshiped idols (cp. [35:2–4](#)). To have the idols may have signified claiming the family inheritance, as customs in subsequent periods indicate. Laban apparently felt vulnerable without them. Whatever her reasons, Rachel’s theft almost brought disaster on the fleeing family when Laban caught up with them. • A wordplay shows that Rachel and Jacob were very much alike—Rachel stole (Hebrew *wattignob*) Laban’s household gods, and Jacob outwitted (Hebrew *wayyignob*, “stole the heart of, deceived”) Laban.

Genesis 31:21

The journey took the family from Haran southwest to the land of Gilead, just east of the Jordan River in the north of today’s kingdom of Jordan.

Genesis 31:22–23

The theft of the idols ([31:19](#)) was probably the main reason that Laban and his men chased Jacob. It was one thing for Jacob to take his family and flocks—Laban probably still believed they were all his—but another matter entirely to take his household gods. Laban may have feared that Jacob would return someday to claim all of Laban’s estate. When he failed to find the gods, he asked for a treaty to keep Jacob away ([31:43–53](#)). • It took Laban seven days to catch up with Jacob.

Genesis 31:24

leave Jacob alone! (literally *Do not speak to Jacob either good or evil*): God commanded Laban not to take justice into his own hands. When we try to enact our own sense of good and evil apart from God’s command, we always do evil (see study note on 2:9).

Genesis 31:25–30

The dispute between the two men used the language of legal controversies and lawsuits (see also [31:36](#)). In his first argument, Laban presented himself as a wounded party that Jacob had robbed.

Genesis 31:32

Jacob, so convinced that he didn't have the gods, used an oath that unwittingly put Rachel under a death sentence.

Genesis 31:33–35

Laban searched for the idols but found nothing. Laban never dreamed that a woman having her monthly period would desecrate the idols by sitting on them (cp. [Lev 15:19–24](#)).

Genesis 31:36–42

Jacob retaliated by accusing Laban of false charges and humiliation. Laban now became the defendant, for his charges were demeaning and apparently groundless.

Genesis 31:40

Jacob, who preferred domestic life ([25:27](#)), had for twenty years endured the rigors of the outdoors that Esau had loved.

Genesis 31:42

The God that Isaac feared (see textual note) was with Jacob ([31:3](#)), had seen his hard work and faithfulness despite Laban's abuse, and had rewarded Jacob. Laban's dream only proved to Jacob that he was in the right.

Genesis 31:43–44

Laban pushed for a treaty to settle the dispute—he felt vulnerable, so he wanted to secure the borders. Jacob did not need a treaty, since God had provided for him and protected him.

Genesis 31:45–48

The stone and the heap of stones were a monument to the border treaty between the two men, as a witness to future generations. Each man named the monument witness pile in his native language. It remained the perpetual border between Israel and the kingdom of Aram (Syria), two nations often at war.

Genesis 31:49

The witness pile was also called watchtower. God would watch over Jacob and Laban and keep them apart, for they could not trust each other.

Genesis 31:50–53

Laban added some face-saving stipulations to the treaty, using many words to cover up his own untrustworthiness and portray Jacob as the unethical party. He even took credit for the monument Jacob had erected (this monument I have set, [31:51](#)). The women and children would be much safer and better cared for with Jacob than they ever were with Laban.

Genesis 32:1

God assured Jacob of his protection at a time when Jacob most needed such consolation. His journey was both a physical return to his homeland and a spiritual return to the land of God's promised blessing. God protects his people and fulfills his plan.

Genesis 32:2

This is God's camp! Jacob must have seen the angels that revealed God's presence as a sign of protection, as with the earlier vision when he was departing the land ([28:10–22](#)). • Mahanaim ("two camps"): Jacob's company and the company of angels were together in one place.

Genesis 32:3-5

Apparently inspired by the vision of angels ([32:1](#), Hebrew *mal'akim*), Jacob sent messengers (*mal'akim*) into Edom to meet Esau.

Genesis 32:7-8

Jacob divided his company into two groups or camps (Hebrew *makhanoth*, related to “Mahanaim” in [32:2](#)) because he was afraid, remembering Esau’s character and his threat to kill Jacob (see [25:25](#); [27:41](#)).

Genesis 32:9-12

Jacob’s prayer is a wonderful example of how to address God. He based his appeal on God’s will, reminding God of his relationship with him, his command for him to return to the land, and his promise ([32:9](#)). He had a correct attitude of genuine humility and total dependence on God ([32:10](#)). Finally, he asked that God rescue him from his brother, and he repeated God’s promises (see [22:17](#)).

Genesis 32:13-21

Taking a large portion of the wealth God had blessed him with (some 550 animals), Jacob prepared a gift to appease Esau’s anger and gain his favor.

Genesis 32:22-24

The Jabbok River flows westward to the Jordan Valley, dividing the region of Bashan on the north from Gilead on the south. Wordplays on Jacob’s name and character preserve the memory of this encounter. Jacob (Hebrew *ya‘aqob*), while at Jabbok (Hebrew *yabboq*), wrestled (Hebrew *wayye’abeq*). Through his fight with an adversary to receive the blessing, Jacob’s name would be changed, and his deceptive striving would partially give way to faith as his way of life.

Genesis 32:22-32

Before Jacob returned to the land God had promised him, God met him, crippled him, and blessed him, changing his name to Israel. This episode was a significant turning point for him.

Genesis 32:24

a man came: The narrative unfolds as the event did for Jacob. No details are given about the assailant, who later refused to identify himself ([32:29](#)). • until the dawn: The darkness fit Jacob’s situation and increased the fear and uncertainty that seized him. In the darkness he had no idea who it was—it might have been one of Esau’s men, or Laban’s.

Genesis 32:25

he touched Jacob’s hip and wrenched it out of its socket: Jacob, the deceitful fighter, could fight no more. When his assailant fought him as man to man, Jacob could hold his own. But like so many of his own rivals, he had now more than met his match.

Genesis 32:26

At daybreak, the significance of this fight began to dawn on Jacob. He realized who his assailant was, and since it was futile to fight, he held on to obtain God’s blessing.

Genesis 32:27

What is your name? The Lord’s question was really about Jacob’s character, not his identity (cp. [3:9](#); [4:9](#)). By giving his name, Jacob confessed his nature, his way of doing things as “Heel-grabber, Deceiver, Usurper.” Before God would bless him, he had to acknowledge who he was, and then God would change his identity.

Genesis 32:28

Jacob: See study note on 25:26. • Israel (“God fights”): God first had to fight *with* him, but now God would fight *for* him. Jacob’s name was thus full of promise for Jacob and his descendants. • you

have fought with God and with men: Through his entire life, Jacob had been seizing God's blessing by his own abilities and by any means possible. Jacob knew the importance of the blessing, but he was too self-sufficient and proud to let the blessing be given to him. He had been fighting God long before this encounter. • and have won: He had prevailed in his struggles with Esau and with Laban; now he prevailed in obtaining God's blessing.

Genesis 32:29

Jacob knew who was with him ([32:30](#)); the request was his attempt to regain some control. God would not reveal his name, which cannot be had on demand.

Genesis 32:30

Peniel (which means "face of God"): The name shows that Jacob recognized the man as a manifestation of God (a *theophany*). • yet my life has been spared (or *and I have been rescued*): The saying probably meant that Jacob realized that his prayer to be rescued from Esau ([32:11](#)) had been answered, for if he could meet God like this and walk away, he had nothing to fear from Esau. The saying may also reflect an ancient understanding that no one could see God and live (see [Exod 33:20](#)).

Genesis 32:31

God injured Jacob's hip, thus curtailing his proud self-sufficiency. Since the Lord had restricted his natural strength, Jacob would have to rely on the Lord with greater faith. He had thought that returning to his land would be a matter of outwitting his brother once again ([32:3-21](#)), but here at the land's threshold he met its true proprietor. He would get the land, but only if God fought for him. Self-sufficiency—trying to achieve the blessing by our own strength or by the ways of the world—will not suffice. If we persist, God may have to cripple our self-sufficiency to make us trust him more.

Genesis 32:32

The story includes a dietary restriction for Israel that became a custom but was not put into law. This custom helped preserve the memory of the story. Observant Jews still refuse to eat the tendons of an animal's hindquarters.

Genesis 33:1-2

Jacob's identity had been changed ([32:27-28](#)), but he had not yet learned to live up to the new name; he still showed the favoritism that divides families. He lined up his family and his possessions in the order of their importance to him, with the slave wives and their children in front (to face danger first), Leah's group behind them, and Rachel and Joseph in the back, where it was safest.

Genesis 33:1-17

Jacob's long-anticipated meeting with his brother Esau turned out far better than he had feared. Esau's changed heart is an example of how "God fights" (See [32:28](#)). Earlier, he had cared little about the birthright ([25:32-34](#)); now he cared little for old grudges. Jacob recognized that God had intervened.

Genesis 33:3-13

Even though Jacob had nothing to fear, he was afraid and tried to appease his brother. He assumed the role of a servant before royalty by bowing ([33:3](#)), using an honorific title ([33:8, 13](#)), making introductions ([33:6-7](#)), and presenting gifts ([33:8](#)).

Genesis 33:4

Esau's friendly greeting was an answer to prayer ([32:11](#)). God had rescued Jacob from Esau's revenge.

Genesis 33:5

your servant: In talking with his brother, Jacob continued to refer to himself as Esau's servant (also [33:14](#)) and to Esau as his lord ([33:8, 13-15](#)); Esau called Jacob "my brother" ([33:9](#)). Jacob was

cautiously warding off any possible retaliation by reversing the words of the oracle ([25:23](#)).

Genesis 33:7

Among Jacob's sons, only Joseph is named; he was Jacob's favorite son and the recipient of the blessing.

Genesis 33:10

Jacob knew that Esau's friendly greeting was God's work, secured at Peniel when he saw God face to face.

Genesis 33:11

this gift I have brought you (literally *my blessing*): Jacob perceived Esau as a threat and tried to appease him with a gift (cp. [2 Kgs 17:3-4](#); [18:7](#), [14](#); [2 Chr 28:21](#)), perhaps in a guilty attempt to undo the past. Jacob would not take no for an answer.

Genesis 33:12-15

Despite Esau's apparent magnanimity, Jacob was wary and cleverly avoided traveling with his brother. • I will meet you at Seir: Jacob's lie manifests his old character, living by deception rather than by faith.

Genesis 33:16-17

Instead of following Esau south to Seir as promised, Jacob again deceived his brother, then headed in the opposite direction to Succoth, east of the Jordan River and north of the Jabbok.

Genesis 33:18-20

These verses form an epilogue to Jacob's adventures outside the land. He returned in peace with a large family and many possessions. • Jacob, like Abraham, built an altar at Shechem (see [12:6-8](#)) and purchased land from the family of Hamor.

Genesis 33:20

El-Elohe-Israel: The name of the altar ("God, the God of Israel") commemorated Jacob's relationship with God. Jacob publicly proclaimed that God was his God, and that God had led him back to the land he would inherit.

Genesis 34:1-2

As far as we know, Dinah was Jacob's only daughter ([30:21](#)). • Shechem . . . seized her and raped her: Shechem violated and debased Dinah, so she had no chance for a proper marriage.

Genesis 34:1-31

Once Jacob and his family settled in the land, the Canaanite presence became a threat. This account is a stern warning to the Israelites about the possibility of their being defiled by the Canaanites. The nation of Israel was later commanded not to intermarry or make treaties with them, for they were a corrupt and corrupting people. This chapter implicitly warns against becoming familiar with the way they lived ([34:1-2](#)). It also taught Israel that in dealing with the Canaanites, they were to keep their integrity and not use the holy things of the covenant for deception and slaughter ([34:13](#)); Israel's reputation was at stake in the land ([34:30](#)). For their ruthless violence, Simeon and Levi were passed over in the birthright blessing ([49:5-7](#)).

Genesis 34:3-4

While Shechem's intense feelings for Dinah made him willing to undergo significant hardship ([34:11-12](#), [17-18](#), [24](#)), the way he showed his "love" for her was selfish, impetuous, and in violation of customary decency (cp. [Judg 14:2](#); see [1 Cor 13:4-7](#); [1 Jn 4:10](#)). His character illustrated why Israel needed to remain separate from the Canaanites.

Genesis 34:5-7

Jacob's response to this crime is surprising. When he heard that Dinah had been defiled, he said nothing about it until his sons came home. Because Jacob did not act, his sons did, though without the

wisdom and integrity necessary for justice. Dinah's full brothers were shocked and furious that Shechem had done such a disgraceful thing to Jacob's family (literally *in Israel*; this is the first use of the name *Israel* to describe the family). This sexual crime was an outrage against the community of God's people and deserved punishment, but the leader of the clan did nothing.

Genesis 34:8–10

Hamor proposed an alliance of intermarriage with the prospect of mutual economic benefit, but God had already promised Jacob everything, including the land ([34:10](#); see [14:21–24](#)). Hamor wanted to gain control of Israel's wealth ([34:23](#)); no good could come of trusting the defiling Canaanites. For some of these reasons, intermarriage with Canaanites was not allowed under the law (see [Exod 23:27–33](#); [Deut 7:1–5](#))—unless, of course, they came to faith (see [Josh 2:1–15](#); [6:23–25](#); [Matt 1:5](#)).

Genesis 34:13–17

Dinah's brothers responded to the proposal without waiting for Jacob to respond, and they acted deceitfully. They may not have thought that Shechem and his people would ever agree to the rite of circumcision, but they knew what they would do if the Canaanites accepted ([34:25](#)).

Genesis 34:18–24

The Canaanites accepted the stipulation and every male in the town was circumcised. This was not just to allow Shechem to marry Dinah, but to give them the opportunity to acquire everything that Jacob possessed ([34:23](#)).

Genesis 34:25–29

When Simeon and Levi used circumcision to deceive and slaughter the Canaanites, they showed disdain for the sign of the covenant. Their slaughter of all the males and their plunder of the city was not justice, but brutal and excessive revenge. In their moral outrage and desire to right the wrong, they should have demanded compensation (see [Exod 22:16–17](#); [Deut 22:28–29](#)). Instead, their

passionate act of rage cost them their birthright blessing ([Gen 49:5–7](#)).

Genesis 34:30

Jacob responded again out of fear of what would happen to him, but God caused the people of this land to fear him instead ([35:5](#)).

Genesis 35:1–7

Jacob returned to Bethel, about fifteen miles south of Shechem, to complete the vows he had made there ([28:20–22](#)).

Genesis 35:1–29

This chapter highlights God's promises, Jacob's vow, and the transition to Jacob's sons' carrying on the covenant. Deborah, Rachel, and Isaac all died, marking the end of an era and of the account of Isaac's family ([25:19–35:29](#)). • Idols were removed ([35:1–4](#)) and pure worship was established ([35:6–7](#)). During this transition, the faith had to be revitalized so that the covenant could be carried forward by Jacob's sons.

Genesis 35:2–4

Jacob had vowed wholehearted devotion to the Lord ([28:20–22](#)); establishing this required that his family remove all pagan idols and cease their devotion to other gods. God permits no rivals; only the Lord was to be their God (cp. [Josh 5:1–9](#)).

Genesis 35:3

He has been with me wherever I have gone: God had fulfilled his promises ([28:15](#); [31:3](#)), so Jacob must fulfill his vow.

Genesis 35:5

a terror from God: People had heard about the massacre of Shechem ([34:25–30](#)).

Genesis 35:6–7

Jacob built an altar at Bethel as God had instructed ([35:1](#); cp. [12:8](#)).

Genesis 35:9–15

At Bethel, God confirmed the promise he had made there earlier; he reiterated Jacob's change of name from Jacob to Israel as proof that the blessing had been given.

Genesis 35:11–12

God's reference to himself as God Almighty assured Jacob that his promise could and would be fulfilled. At Bethel, God had promised that Jacob would have descendants in the land (cp. [28:13–14](#)); here he added that his descendants would include kings (see [17:6](#)).

Genesis 35:14–15

In fulfilling his vow ([28:20–22](#)), Jacob's actions were almost identical to his actions in the earlier experience at Bethel (cp. [28:16–19](#)).

Genesis 35:16–20

Benjamin's birth completed the family, but it was a sorrowful event because Rachel died in childbirth (see study note on 31:32).

Genesis 35:18

Rachel found the name son of my sorrow appropriate to the situation, but Jacob did not want such a sad name for his son, so he changed it to son of my right hand. Jacob thus turned the day of sorrow into a day of hope that gave his son the prospect of success.

Genesis 35:19

Jacob did not carry Rachel's body to the family tomb at Machpelah ([23:1–20](#); [25:9](#); [49:30](#); [50:13](#)) but buried her in the territory that would be Benjamin's (see [Josh 18:21–28](#); [1 Sam 10:2](#)).

Genesis 35:20

it can be seen there to this day: This seems to be a later editorial comment by someone who was living in the land after the conquest and giving directions to the tomb (see Genesis Book Introduction, "Composition").

Genesis 35:22

Reuben had intercourse with Bilhah, thus defiling his father's marriage bed. Perhaps Reuben, as the oldest son, was trying to replace his father as head of the clan by a pagan procedure (cp. [2 Sam 16:15–22](#)), but by this action he lost his birthright (see [Gen 49:3–4](#)). • Jacob soon heard about it, but he again delayed his response (see [49:3–4](#); cp. [34:5](#)).

Genesis 35:23–26

The twelve sons became leaders of the twelve tribes of Israel. Their names are the firstfruits of the nation.

Genesis 35:27–29

Esau and Jacob (listed here in ordinary birth order) came together—probably for the first time since they had reconciled ([33:16–17](#))—to bury Isaac in Hebron (see [13:18](#); [23:1–2](#), [17–19](#)).

Genesis 36:1–8

The account of Esau stresses two points. First, Esau's sons were born . . . in the land of Canaan ([36:5](#)) before he moved to Seir ([36:8](#)). Jacob's children, by contrast, were almost all born outside the land but then moved into it. God was giving the land to Jacob and his descendants and so made room for them by providing for Esau in a different place. Second, Esau's other name was Edom. Israel often struggled with the Edomites (see [1 Sam 21:7](#); [22:9–22](#); [Obad 1](#)).

Genesis 36:1–43

The book turns to the accounts of Isaac's sons, concluding the unchosen line of Esau (ch [36](#)) before proceeding with the chosen line of Jacob (ch [37](#)).

Genesis 36:2

Oholibamah was a great-granddaughter of Seir the Horite, whose descendants lived in Edom when Esau went to live there ([36:20](#), [25](#)).

Genesis 36:2–3

Esau's three wives—Adah, Oholibamah, and Basemath—are listed. Two of these wives' names are different from those listed earlier ([26:34](#); [28:9](#)). Perhaps the others died, or Esau favored these three among a total of six, or these were just different names for the same three. There is not enough information to decide.

Genesis 36:7–8

Esau, like Lot, left for the eastern land (cp. [13:5–6](#)).

Genesis 36:9–14

The descendants of Esau's five sons are named.

Genesis 36:9–43

This passage begins a second account of Esau's descendants ([36:1](#)); it traces the family to subsequent generations and alliances.

Genesis 36:15–19

Thirteen of Esau's descendants had positions as leaders of various clans. A picture begins to emerge of Esau as a grand overlord of tribes (cp. [36:40–43](#)).

Genesis 36:20–30

Seir the Horite was an early inhabitant of the land; his descendants populated the region until Esau moved in and displaced them ([Deut 2:12](#)).

Genesis 36:31

before any king ruled over the Israelites: This editorial note was probably inserted into the text during Israel's monarchy (see study note on [35:20](#)).

Genesis 36:31–39

It is not clear how these kings of Edom were related to Esau. The clans in Edom followed the same pattern of organization as the later tribes of Israel. They eventually chose a king from one of their tribes and carried on a line of succession from him.

Genesis 36:40–43

These chiefs descended from Esau, who was a great and powerful overlord. As father of the Edomites, he ruled over clans and regions, with eleven chiefs descended from him. By separating from Jacob, Esau was beginning to shake Jacob's yoke from his neck ([27:39–40](#)).

Genesis 37:1

In ch [36](#), Esau was well on his way to power and prosperity; by contrast, Jacob, still waiting for the promise, settled in the land as a foreigner, like his father. He was still a temporary resident with a single family. Worldly greatness often comes more swiftly than spiritual greatness. Waiting for the promised spiritual blessing while others prosper is a test of patience, faith, and perseverance.

Genesis 37:2

The account of Jacob and his family tells of Joseph and his brothers. Jacob is still prominent, but the focus is on Joseph, who is introduced as an obedient seventeen-year-old son. • Joseph reported . . . the bad things his brothers were doing: Bringing a bad report has never been popular, but

it was the right thing to do and shows that Joseph was faithful from the beginning. As the story progresses, we see more of his brothers' wickedness displayed until, like Cain, they tried to eliminate the brother who pleased God.

Genesis 37:2–50:26

The story of Joseph and his brothers comprises a separate unit in Genesis, distinct in tone and emphasis from the preceding material. It traces one continuous series of episodes with Joseph at their center. • Cycles of repeated motifs structure the entire Joseph account. The themes are closely related to those found in wisdom books such as Proverbs, Ecclesiastes, and Daniel. Wisdom literature assures the faithful that God brings good out of evil and joy out of pain—if not in this life, then certainly in the life to come. Though the wicked may prosper for a time, the righteous should hold fast to their integrity because a higher, more enduring principle of life is realized through obedience to God. Everyone who aspires to leadership in God's plan should observe how wisdom led to Joseph's success. Christ Jesus embodied the life of wisdom portrayed here as no one else could, for he is the wisdom of God. • Judah is also an important character in the story. He began as irresponsible and mean-spirited as his brothers; but he truly repented, put his life on the line to ransom a child for his father, and received a very important inheritance.

Genesis 37:3

Jacob: Hebrew *Israel*; also in [37:13](#). • Jacob loved Joseph more because Joseph had been born to him in his old age and because he was the first son of his favorite wife, Rachel. • Jacob gave Joseph a beautiful robe to demonstrate that he intended to grant him the largest portion of the inheritance.

Genesis 37:4

Jacob's favoritism toward Joseph inflamed his other sons' hatred of their brother. Just as Isaac's and Rebekah's favoritism had separated their family, Jacob's favoritism would separate him from his son Joseph.

Genesis 37:5–11

God confirmed his choice of this faithful son as the eventual leader of the whole family through two symbolic dreams. This is the first of three dream sequences in chs [37–50](#) (see [40:1–41:36](#); cp. [15:13](#); [20:3](#); [28:12–15](#); [31:24](#)). Dreams carried weight as a form of divine communication, especially if the dream revelation was given twice.

Genesis 37:7

The bundles of grain hint at how Joseph's authority over his family would be achieved (see [42:1–3](#)).

Genesis 37:8

The brothers' angry response to the revelation, in contrast to Joseph's honesty and faithfulness, clearly demonstrates why they were not chosen for leadership: Leaders in God's plan cannot be consumed with jealousy and hatred. In their anger, they missed an important part of the revelation—they too would be rulers (stars, [37:9](#)) who would productively bind their sheaves ([37:7](#)).

Genesis 37:9

The sun, moon, and eleven stars: Astrological symbols often represent rulers. The dream predicted Joseph's elevation to a position of authority over the whole clan of Israel.

Genesis 37:10

your mother and I: Joseph's birth mother, Rachel, was dead ([35:19](#)). Leah was now the matriarch of the clan.

Genesis 37:11

His brothers hated Joseph because they were jealous of him. Rather than recognize the hand of God, the brothers tried to prevent the dream from being fulfilled ([37:18–36](#)). These actions show that they were not fit to lead the household of faith. God's sovereign choice of a leader, especially if the one chosen is young or appears unqualified, often brings out the true colors of those who have to

submit to that leader's authority. The brothers represent people throughout history who have been driven by envy and malice because they were not committed to doing the Lord's will. • Jacob wondered what the dreams meant because he knew that God would choose the next leader, that God could choose the younger son to rule over the older sons, and that God could reveal all this in dreams.

Genesis 37:12-13

It was foolish for Jacob to send Joseph on such a mission, knowing how the brothers felt about him. Joseph obeyed his father by going to find his brothers despite their hatred for him.

Genesis 37:14-17

The brothers ranged far and wide. Shechem was about fifty miles from Hebron, and Dothan another fifteen miles beyond Shechem.

Genesis 37:18-20

When Joseph's brothers saw him coming, they devised a plot to kill . . . the dreamer and end his dreams. Earlier, they had unjustly killed the men of Shechem to avenge their sister (ch [34](#)); in the region of Shechem, they now plotted to unjustly kill their own brother out of envy.

Genesis 37:21-24

Reuben was perhaps trying to get back into his father's good graces ([35:22](#)) by exercising the leadership of the firstborn (cp. [42:22](#)). Reuben succeeded in saving Joseph's life, but he failed to earn his father's favor ([37:29-30](#)).

Genesis 37:23

The recurring motif of changed clothes signifies changes in status, position, and authority (see [37:3](#), [23](#); [38:14](#), [19](#); [39:15-18](#); [41:14](#), [42](#)).

Genesis 37:25-28

The Ishmaelite traders were descendants of the slave child who was cast out for mocking Isaac. Now they would enslave Joseph. When he was sold for twenty pieces of silver and carried to Egypt, he was at least preserved alive.

Genesis 37:26

Judah began to exercise leadership that he would continue to develop as events unfolded (see [43:8-10](#)).

Genesis 37:28

the Ishmaelites, who were Midianite traders (literally *the Midianite traders*): Ishmaelites were descendants of Abraham through Hagar ([16:5](#)), while Midianites were descendants of Abraham through Keturah ([25:1-2](#)). The term *Ishmaelite* may have described bedouin tribes generally. The Midianites might also have been traveling with a separate caravan of *Ishmaelite traders* ([37:27](#)). • Kidnapping (see [40:15](#)) would become a capital offense (see [Exod 21:16](#)) in Jewish law.

Genesis 37:29-30

When Reuben returned, he tore his clothes in grief. His attempt to restore his relationship with his father by saving Joseph had gone awry.

Genesis 37:31-35

The old family propensity for deception seized the brothers' imagination. Jacob had killed a young goat to deceive Isaac ([27:5-17](#)); now Jacob's sons deceived him with a goat (see study note on 30:34-36).

Genesis 37:32

your son: In their cold hatred, the brothers did not refer to Joseph by name or acknowledge him as their brother (see [21:10](#)).

Genesis 37:33

recognized: Compare with [27:23](#).

Genesis 37:34–35

Jacob tore his clothes and dressed himself in burlap: These were signs of great distress and mourning (see [44:13](#); [Job 1:20](#); [16:15](#)). Jacob was devastated and refused to be comforted. The treachery thus affected everyone in his family.

Genesis 37:36

sold Joseph to Potiphar: Joseph found himself in a place of service that seemed congruent with his rise to authority, yet he still faced more testing.

Genesis 38:1–30

The story of Judah and Tamar is a carefully placed interlude; it reports what was happening in the family of Judah, who would later rise to prominence, and it shows the beginnings of assimilation with the people of the land to help explain why God sent the family to Egypt (chs [39–47](#)). The Egyptians were strict separatists ([43:32](#)); the Israelites would retain their unique identity better in Egypt than in Canaan.

Genesis 38:7

That Er was a wicked man is not surprising, since his mother was a Canaanite and his father a wayward Israelite.

Genesis 38:7–10

In this story, the Lord is mentioned as the sovereign judge who took the lives of Judah's evil sons.

Genesis 38:8

as our law requires. . . . You must produce an heir for your brother: The custom that informs this episode is the law for levirate marriage (Latin *levir*, "husband's brother"). By this custom, which was

later incorporated into God's law for Israel ([Deut 25:5–10](#)), if a man died childless, his brother or nearest relative would marry his widow to produce a child who would carry on the family name of the deceased and inherit his property. Apparently, the near kinsman had a right to refuse, but he would be disgraced in the family for refusing to perpetuate his brother's name.

Genesis 38:9–10

Onan married Tamar, but was not willing to provide an heir for his brother. He would have sex with Tamar but not fulfill his responsibility to his dead brother ([38:8](#)).

Genesis 38:11

Judah is now presented as the model for his sons' behavior—he, too, was unfaithful to his levirate responsibility to Tamar as next kinsman (see study note on 38:8). Judah and his sons were far too Canaanite in their ways (see study note on 38:27–30; contrast Boaz, [Ruth 3–4](#)).

Genesis 38:12–13

Without a marriage, the family's future was in jeopardy. • Judah's wife died: This made Judah available to fulfill the responsibility of providing an heir.

Genesis 38:14–19

Tamar realized that she would have to take matters into her own hands if the family were to have a future. Tamar acted in keeping with the levirate custom (see study note on 38:8) out of loyalty to her deceased husband. She had a legal right to an heir by Judah's son or by Judah, so she lured her father-in-law into having sex with her. Jacob's family was deceived again, this time by a Canaanite daughter-in-law.

Genesis 38:17

It would be normal for Tamar to ask for a pledge if the man did not have the money to pay. A woman

in such a position would not trust anyone to send the money.

Genesis 38:18

identification seal: A stone or metal cylinder was engraved with distinctive designs and was usually worn around the neck on a cord; when rolled onto clay or wax, it left a distinct impression.

Genesis 38:20–23

Judah had gone in to Tamar as a regular prostitute (Hebrew *zonah*, [38:15](#)), whereas Hirah was mistakenly looking for a shrine prostitute (Hebrew *qedeshah*), of which there were none.

Genesis 38:24–26

Judah played the hypocrite when he condemned Tamar to death for adultery. When she produced the seal and cord and walking stick that identified him as the father, he withdrew the condemnation.

Genesis 38:26

She is more righteous than I am: Judah acknowledged that he had shirked his responsibility to provide an heir. It was sinful for Judah to go to a prostitute, but Tamar had a legal right to be the mother of Judah's child and had acted on that right. In the book of Ruth, the elders analogously blessed the marriage of Boaz and Ruth, praying that God would make Ruth like Tamar ([Ruth 4:12](#); cp. [Matt 1:3, 5](#)).

Genesis 38:27–30

Judah's line continued because of Tamar. The twins replaced Judah's two slain sons ([38:7, 10](#)); their birth was similar to the birth of Jacob and Esau ([25:21–26](#)) in that the "red" one was born first, but the other son pushed past him in later life. Jacob's gaining the right to rule over his older brother ([27:29](#)) seemed to be relived in Judah's line. The line was carried on through Perez and not through the elder son Shelah, whom he had gone to such lengths to protect ([38:11](#); see [1 Chr 4:21](#)), nor

through the elder twin Zerah (see [Ruth 4:13–22](#); [Matt 1:3](#)).

Genesis 38:29–30

Perez pushed past his brother, just as Joseph would soon do in relation to his brothers (chs [39–47](#)).

Genesis 39:1–23

Joseph's integrity in Potiphar's service contrasts with Judah's moral failure (ch [38](#)). God was with Joseph ([39:2–3, 21, 23](#)) and enabled him to prosper and be a blessing (see study notes on 12:1–9; 28:16–22) despite his slavery and imprisonment.

Genesis 39:1–47:31

Joseph began as a slave, alienated from his brothers and separated from his father; he ended as Pharaoh's viceroy. Through the trips to Egypt, the covenant family went from the brink of apostasy, divided by jealousy and deception, to being reconciled and united by Judah's intercession and Joseph's forgiveness.

Genesis 39:2

God is mentioned for the first time (apart from [38:7–10](#)) since Jacob built his altar in Bethel ([35:1–15](#)); his covenant name, "the Lord," is used for the first time since Jacob left Laban ([31:49](#)).

Genesis 39:5

God began to bless Egypt through Joseph (see [22:18](#)).

Genesis 39:6–10

One of the major motifs of wisdom literature (see study note on 37:2–50:26) is to warn young people that immorality will lead them to disaster (cp. [Prov 5–7](#)). Joseph was able to resist temptation because he had godly wisdom—he was guided by the fear of the Lord ([Prov 1:7](#); [9:10](#)).

Genesis 39:14

Though Potiphar's wife was addressing slaves, she appealed to them as fellow Egyptians (us) to enlist them as witnesses against the despised Hebrew (see [43:32](#)) who had won Potiphar's trust.

Genesis 39:19–20

This was the second time that Joseph, while faithfully doing the right thing, was thrown into bondage with his clothing used deceptively as evidence (cp. [37:23–24](#), [31–33](#)).

Genesis 39:21–23

Joseph thrived in prison because God was with him. Each time Joseph prospered, he was put in charge of something.

Genesis 40:1–4

Joseph was so faithful and trustworthy that the captain of the guard trusted him with the care of two of Pharaoh's chief . . . officials.

Genesis 40:1–23

Joseph did not lose faith in God's promises, as evidenced by his readiness to interpret the dreams of two prisoners. He was still convinced that God's revelation in his own two dreams ([37:5–11](#)) was true, and he had not abandoned hope that they would be fulfilled. When the fellow prisoners' dreams were fulfilled exactly as Joseph said, this confirmed that his previous dreams were from God.

Genesis 40:5–8

Pharaoh's cup-bearer and baker looked worried because they knew that their futures were somehow bound up in these ominous and disturbing dreams that they could not understand.

- Joseph still had faith that interpreting dreams is God's business and that he would understand them with God's help. He knew he had not misinterpreted his own dreams.

Genesis 40:9–19

Joseph listened to the dreams and offered their interpretations. These dreams were not trivial; they were ominous warnings from God about what everyone was going to face. These two dreams prepared for Pharaoh's two dreams, which revealed the periods of life and death that the nation would soon experience.

Genesis 40:14–15

Because he knew that the chief cup-bearer was going back into Pharaoh's personal service, Joseph saw an opportunity to seek his own release from prison.

Genesis 40:20–22

The interpretations Joseph gave the prisoners proved true. The death of the chief baker speaks of the harsh realities of life in ancient Egypt, with a king whose word was his land's highest law.

Genesis 40:23

The cup-bearer . . . forgot all about Joseph, but God did not forget him. Joseph's faith was about to be rewarded (ch [41](#)).

Genesis 41:1–4

Pharaoh's first dream was about cows. Cows liked to stand half-submerged among the reeds in the Nile River to take refuge from the heat and flies. They would come out of the water to find pasture. The second group of cows disturbed Pharaoh because they were scrawny yet able to swallow the fat cows.

Genesis 41:1–46

God had used two dreams to identify Joseph as a leader among his brothers ([37:5–11](#)). He used two dreams to test Joseph's faith in prison ([40:5–14](#)). Now he would use two dreams to elevate Joseph from prison to preeminence. Joseph had repeatedly

proven faithful in small matters; now he would be put in charge of great things.

Genesis 41:5-7

Pharaoh's second dream carried a similar message. Seven plump ... heads of grain on a single stalk were swallowed up by seven shriveled and withered heads that sprouted after them.

Genesis 41:8

The magicians and wise men belonged to a guild of supposed experts in spiritual matters, including dreams and visions (cp. [Exod 8:18-19](#); [Dan 2:10-11](#)), but they could not interpret these dreams. God used an Israelite slave to confound the wisdom of the world (cp. [Dan 2](#)). However powerful a nation becomes, it is still under God's sovereign control ([Dan 2:20-23](#)).

Genesis 41:9-13

The chief cup-bearer finally remembered Joseph and testified that his interpretations were true.

Genesis 41:14-15

Pharaoh immediately summoned Joseph from prison to interpret his dreams. • He shaved, as was the Egyptian custom.

Genesis 41:16

Joseph knew that only God could tell what Pharaoh's dreams meant (cp. [40:8](#)), and he was confident that God would do so, because he had given the dreams for a purpose ([41:25](#), [28](#)).

Genesis 41:17-24

Pharaoh recounted his dreams and testified that no human wisdom could interpret them.

Genesis 41:25-32

Both dreams predicted that seven years of abundant crops would be followed by seven years of severe famine.

Genesis 41:32

The two similar dreams confirmed that the message was decreed by God and would soon ... happen, just as the dreams of the two prisoners were quickly fulfilled ([40:5-23](#)). Joseph's own two dreams ([37:5-11](#)) were about to come true as well ([41:37-46](#); [42:6-9](#)).

Genesis 41:33-36

God's revelation demanded a response—it was not given just to satisfy curiosity about the future. Joseph's advice about planning and preparing showed that he was the kind of intelligent and wise man that Pharaoh needed ([41:37-40](#)). • Joseph instituted central planning and control with a supervisor, local managers, a 20 percent tax on grain, and a rationing system. Later wisdom literature (see study note on [37:2-50:26](#)) teaches the principle of planning ahead rather than living just for the moment (see [Prov 6:6-8](#); [27:12](#)).

Genesis 41:37-40

Pharaoh recognized that Joseph was the man for the job; he had the spirit of God and was intelligent and wise. God showed his sovereign rule in Egypt; Israelites who later read the account could be confident that God would save them as he had promised.

Genesis 41:41-46

Joseph was made the acting ruler or manager of Egypt.

Genesis 41:42

Pharaoh's signet ring had a seal used for signing documents. The seal was impressed in soft clay, which hardened and left a permanent impression of the ruler's signature, which carried his authority.

Numerous seals of this type have been found in archaeological digs. • The linen clothing and gold chain signified Joseph's new status as ruler.

Genesis 41:43-44

Pharaoh made Joseph second-in-command; all the people had to submit to him. Cp. [Ps 105:16-22](#).

Genesis 41:45

As token of Joseph's new status, Pharaoh gave him an Egyptian name and a wife from a high-ranking family. • On was a center for sun worship that came to be known as Heliopolis ("sun city").

Genesis 41:46

He was thirty years old: It had been approximately thirteen years since his brothers had sold Joseph into slavery ([37:2](#)). • he inspected the entire land of Egypt: As a wise manager, his first priority was to learn the scope of his responsibilities.

Genesis 41:47-57

Pharaoh's dreams were fulfilled in keeping with Joseph's interpretation.

Genesis 41:50-52

In spite of his position and authority, Joseph never abandoned his heritage; he gave Hebrew names to his two sons. • Manasseh: Joseph's prosperity and success made him "forget" the misery of separation from his family. • Ephraim: In so naming him, Joseph proclaimed his gratitude to God for making him "fruitful" in Egypt.

Genesis 41:53-57

Joseph's wisdom paid off, for the seven years of plenty were followed by seven years of severe famine, but throughout Egypt there was plenty of food. Joseph had grain to sell to the Egyptians and to people from other countries as well.

Genesis 42:1-44.34

Joseph did several unusual things to his brothers when they came looking for grain. The last time Joseph had been with them, they were filled with jealousy, hatred, and anger; they attempted to destroy their brother, and they deceived their father. Joseph put them through various tests, similar to the trying situations they had put him through, to see if they had changed.

Genesis 42:1-47.31

God used the famine to bring Israel to Egypt under Joseph's rule, thus fulfilling two prophecies ([15:13](#); [37:7-11](#)).

Genesis 42:4

Jacob may have believed that Benjamin would not be safe with his brothers.

Genesis 42:6-7

Joseph's first dream ([37:5-11](#)) was partially fulfilled when his brothers bowed down to him without recognizing him (see also [43:26](#); [44:14](#)). It was totally fulfilled in [50:18](#). Joseph recognized his brothers immediately, but he could not reveal himself because he did not yet trust them to be the honest men they claimed to be ([42:10](#)).

Genesis 42:8

they didn't recognize him: Joseph was a grown man, not a boy. He was not wearing a beard, was dressed in Egyptian clothes, and was in an unexpected position, speaking to them through an interpreter ([42:23](#)).

Genesis 42:9

You are spies! The brothers had considered Joseph a spy for their father and had treated him roughly ([37:2](#), [14](#), [18-28](#)). Joseph was putting them in a similar situation to see how they would respond.

Genesis 42:11

Joseph knew that they had not always been the honest men they claimed to be.

Genesis 42:15–17

Joseph put the brothers in jail for three days to see if they had a conscience functioning about what they had done ([42:21–23](#)). The brothers had similarly thrown Joseph into a cistern-prison while they decided what to do with him ([37:24](#)).

Genesis 42:18–20

Rather than keep all but one, Joseph would release all but one to take grain home to their starving families.

Genesis 42:21–23

Clearly we are being punished: The brothers sensed that having to bring Benjamin back to Egypt against their father's wishes was God's punishment for their having sold Joseph to the traders. The sense of divine retribution began to awaken feelings of remorse that Joseph's cries for mercy and their father's tears ([37:34–35](#)) had failed to arouse.

Genesis 42:22

you wouldn't listen: Reuben had lost the reins of leadership (see study notes on [42:37](#); [49:3–4](#)).

Genesis 42:24

Joseph turned away from them and began to weep (cp. [43:30](#); [45:2, 14](#); [50:1, 17](#)); perhaps he was hearing part of the story that he had never known (Reuben's attempt to save him, [37:21–22, 29](#)), or his brothers' remorse moved him to forgiveness.

Genesis 42:25

return each brother's payment: He was now testing them to awaken their conscience and make them

face their past guilt; once again, they were going home with silver instead of a brother ([37:28–35](#)).

Genesis 42:25–28

Joseph cared for his brothers' needs; he had forgiven them (see study note on [42:24](#)) and was fulfilling his role to provide for them. God used Joseph's care to convict the brothers even more fully of their sin.

Genesis 42:28

What has God done to us? They knew that God was behind everything that had been happening, so they faced a day of reckoning for their sins.

Genesis 42:29–34

The brothers' account focused on the accusation that they were spies and on the need to take Benjamin back to Egypt with them. They omitted their growing realization of divine retribution for their crime against Joseph.

Genesis 42:36

Filled with grief over two sons lost already, Jacob feared that he would also lose Benjamin if he went to Egypt. • You are robbing me of my children! He did not realize the full truth of his words, but they must have stung his sons' guilty consciences.

Genesis 42:37

Reuben tried to take the lead; perhaps he thought he could get back into his father's good favor (see [35:22](#)), first by rescuing Joseph from certain death ([37:21–22, 29–30](#)) and now by keeping Benjamin safe.

Genesis 42:38

Jacob was resolute in his favoritism toward Rachel's remaining son. Benjamin would not go to Egypt even if it meant that Leah's son Simeon never

returned. Jacob's grief apparently weighed heavily on the brothers' conscience ([44:18-34](#)).

Genesis 43:1-7

As the famine continued, Jacob's family needed more grain, but they could not return to Egypt without Benjamin ([42:16, 20](#)). Jacob realized that he was in a bind; he needed more food but was loath to lose Benjamin.

Genesis 43:8-10

Judah broke the deadlock by taking responsibility for Benjamin's well-being, thus succeeding where Reuben failed. His action was fitting, since it had been his idea to sell Joseph to the Ishmaelites ([37:26-27](#)) instead of killing him. Now he would secure Benjamin's safety with his own life (see [44:18-34](#)).

Genesis 43:11-13

Jacob provided everything he could to ensure a favorable reception from the Egyptian governor (the man; cp. [32:13-21](#)).

Genesis 43:13-14

Jacob finally entrusted his family's future to God Almighty, the divine title that stresses God's power (see also [17:1](#); [28:3](#); [35:11](#); [48:3](#); [1 Kgs 19:10, 14](#); [Rev 21:22](#)).

Genesis 43:16

When Joseph saw Benjamin with them: Joseph now knew that Benjamin was well (see study note on [42:1-44:34](#)). The feast was both a celebration and a test.

Genesis 43:18

the brothers were frightened: Compare [32:6-12](#). Their guilt stopped them from seeing that something good might happen.

Genesis 43:19-22

The brothers, completely vulnerable and feeling the weight of God's judgment on their consciences, approached the manager in desperation.

Genesis 43:24

Joseph no longer treated his brothers harshly, but provided kind hospitality.

Genesis 43:26

For the second time, the brothers bowed . . . before Joseph in fulfillment of his first dream ([37:7](#); see [42:6-7](#); cp. [33:3](#)).

Genesis 43:29

May God be gracious to you, my son: Joseph's blessing to his full brother fulfilled Jacob's prayer ([43:14](#)).

Genesis 43:30

he was overcome with emotion for his brother: Cp. [42:24](#). Joseph's tears were of painful memories and years of lost fellowship, as well as of joy and thanksgiving at seeing his brother again. • He went into his private room: He did not yet plan to reveal his identity.

Genesis 43:33

to their amazement: This ruler knew more about the brothers than seemed possible (cp. [44:15](#)).

Genesis 43:34

The brothers were confronted with generous and gracious dealings from God through Joseph, who tested their tolerance by reenacting the favoritism toward Rachel's son that had galvanized their earlier hostility.

Genesis 44:1–34

The brothers appeared to have changed; they had shown remorse over what they had done to Joseph, and they showed integrity in returning the money and in bringing Benjamin. Given a chance to get rid of Rachel's other son, Benjamin, would they do it?

Genesis 44:2

Joseph was giving his brothers the chance to abandon Benjamin if they wanted to. Joseph was testing them to see if they were loyal to the family and faithful to their father.

Genesis 44:5

This description would make the brothers understand that the ruler knew things that others could not. • *Hydromancy* (pouring water into oil) and *oenomancy* (pouring wine into other liquids) were methods of divination used in the ancient Near East that would have required such a cup. Joseph was continuing his ruse (see [42:7](#); cp. [30:27](#); see also [Lev 19:26](#); [Num 23:23](#); [Deut 18:10–11](#))—he knew that only God grants revelation (see [Gen 37:5–9](#); [40:8](#); [41:16](#)).

Genesis 44:9–10

The punishment that the brothers proposed was harsher than necessary; it was normal in antiquity to stake your life on what you said. The palace manager was agreeable but enforced a punishment that matched Joseph's intentions ([44:17](#)).

Genesis 44:11–12

The palace manager knew where the cup was, but he created more anxiety by beginning with the oldest.

Genesis 44:13

they tore their clothing in despair: They knew what it would do to Jacob to lose Benjamin ([42:38](#)).

Genesis 44:14

This time, the brothers did not bow politely (see [42:6–7](#); [43:26](#)); they fell to the ground in desperation, fulfilling Joseph's first dream for the third time (see [37:10](#)).

Genesis 44:16

Judah again spoke for the group. • God is punishing us for our sins: God was completing the work of repentance in their hearts. Judah again proposed that they all be punished. Benjamin was seemingly guilty of this theft, but all of the others were guilty of sin against Joseph. They preferred not returning to Jacob at all versus seeing his grief at the loss of Benjamin ([44:34](#)).

Genesis 44:18–34

Judah made good on his promise to pay for Benjamin's safety ([43:8–10](#)). His lengthy plea to be imprisoned in place of the lad ([44:33](#)) is one of the most moving acts of intercession in Scripture. It demonstrated Judah's concern for their father and his willingness to give up everything for the sake of his brother. With this kind of integrity (see [John 15:13](#)), Judah showed himself to be a true leader, qualified to receive the blessing of the firstborn. Through him the kings of Israel would come (see [Gen 49:10](#)). • The brothers had fully repented, as expressed by Judah's intercession. Because of their change, Joseph could make himself known to them ([45:1–15](#)) and arrange for the family to join him in Egypt where there was food ([45:16](#); [47:12](#)).

Genesis 44:32–34

Judah was willing to give up his family, his future, and his freedom for others.

Genesis 45:1–15

In one of the most dramatic scenes of the book, Joseph revealed his identity to his brothers, bringing the process of reconciling with them to a climax (see also [50:14–21](#)).

Genesis 45:2

This is the third of five times in the story that Joseph wept over his brothers (see also [42:24](#); [43:30](#); [45:14](#); [50:17](#); cp. [50:1](#)).

Genesis 45:3

The brothers were stunned at the news, unable to speak from amazement and fear ([45:5](#); cp. [50:15](#)).

Genesis 45:5–8

God . . . sent me is the central message of the account of Jacob's family ([37:2](#)). As the Lord had told Abraham, he was leading the Israelites into Egypt ([15:13](#)). God had sent Joseph to Egypt to prepare for his family's rescue during the famine. In what has become a classic statement of God's sovereignty, Joseph explained that God had been working through all of the circumstances and human acts to bring about his plan. The certainty of God's will is the basis for forgiveness and reconciliation with those who do wrong, cause hurt, or bring harm. If people do not believe that God is sovereign, then they will blame others and retaliate. Those who are spiritual will trust that God is at work even through human wickedness (see also [Rom 8:28–30](#)).

Genesis 45:9–13

Joseph instructed his brothers to inform Jacob. The whole family was to move to Egypt and live in Goshen, a fertile region in the Nile delta (see [47:1–12](#)). If they did not come to Egypt, they would not survive the five years of famine ahead.

Genesis 45:10

The region of Goshen was in the northeast corner of Egypt, only a few days' walk from Canaan. Jacob's family stayed there because there was food and water for themselves and their flocks; later, they were kept there by Egyptians who put them to slave labor.

Genesis 45:14–15

Joseph was reunited with his brothers—first with Benjamin and then with the rest. Their previous hatred and jealousy of Joseph ([37:4–11](#)) had come to an end. The brothers experienced forgiveness from God and from Joseph. Far from commanding his brothers to bow down to him (see [42:6–7](#)), Joseph welcomed them. Joseph held no grudge because he accepted what had happened as God's work and saw the good that had resulted (see [50:14–21](#)). This is how wisdom rules: The wise leader will forgive and restore (see study note on [37:2–50:26](#)).

Genesis 45:16–25

Joseph sent his brothers with instructions to bring Jacob and the entire family to Egypt. Out of gratitude for Joseph's having saved all of Egypt ([45:18](#); see [47:20](#)), Pharaoh promised the best of all the land of Egypt, and Joseph gave them the finest products of Egypt.

Genesis 45:16–47:12

This section is transitional, as the family moved from Canaan to Goshen, where they would live for the next four centuries.

Genesis 45:24

Don't quarrel about all this along the way! When they were away from Joseph, they might begin to accuse one another about the past or argue about how to explain what had happened to Jacob. It was now time to put the past behind them and enjoy the reunion.

Genesis 45:26–28

As might be expected, Jacob was stunned when he heard that his son Joseph was still alive and ruling all the land of Egypt. As he heard the details of their story and saw all that Joseph had sent him, he was convinced that it was true. He immediately prepared to move to Egypt and reunite with his son Joseph, whom he had not seen for twenty-two years.

Genesis 45:27

their father's spirits revived: This royal invitation to Jacob, an old man near the end of hope, and to the ten brothers burdened with guilty fears, was a turning point in their lives. It was also a fulfillment of God's prediction ([15:13-16](#)) that they would go into seclusion in a foreign country and there become a great nation without losing their identity. The joyful news about Joseph changed the lives of everyone in this family for the good.

Genesis 46:1

set out for Egypt: A little over 200 years earlier, Abraham had similarly gone down into Egypt during a famine in Canaan ([12:10](#)), and God had protected him there. • Jacob's first stop was at Beersheba, where Abraham had sacrificed to the Lord and worshiped him after settling his land and water rights with the Philistines ([21:31-33](#)). This was where Isaac had lived, and where Jacob had lived before he fled from Esau's anger ([28:10](#)). • all his possessions: See [46:5-7](#).

Genesis 46:1-4

God reassured Jacob about his move to Egypt.

Genesis 46:2-4

In a night vision, the Lord repeated his promise to go with Jacob and make his family into a great nation in Egypt. The same God who led the family into Egypt promised to bring them out of Egypt to live once again in the land of Canaan.

Genesis 46:4

You will die: He would have a peaceful death, surrounded by his family and many blessings from God ([49:33](#)).

Genesis 46:8-27

This genealogy of the sons of Jacob shows that all the tribes of Israel went together to the land of Egypt; they would all leave together as well (see the book of Exodus).

Genesis 46:20

On: See study note on 41:45.

Genesis 46:26

The total number . . . was sixty-six: This is the number of those who traveled with Jacob to Egypt, excluding his sons' wives, the servants, and others attached to the household. It also omits Joseph, Ephraim, Manasseh, and Jacob.

Genesis 46:27

The total seventy includes Joseph, Ephraim, Manasseh, and Jacob. Seventy is also a symbolic number for perfection or completion (see "Symbolic Numbers" Theme Note). From these seventy (i.e., all Israel) would grow the nation of Israel that would bless the seventy nations (i.e., all the nations) of the world (see study note on Gen 10:2-32; cp. [12:3](#)).

Genesis 46:28-34

Jacob finally saw his son Joseph again; their reunion was overwhelmingly joyful.

Genesis 46:29

Joseph . . . embraced his father and wept: Joseph was seventeen when he had last seen his father ([37:2](#)); now he was thirty-nine.

Genesis 46:30

Jacob was satisfied just to see his beloved son alive—the firstborn of his chosen wife Rachel and the designated family leader (see study note on 48:5-7; see also [1 Chr 5:1-2](#)). More than just a family reunion, this was confirmation that God's plan was intact.

Genesis 46:34

In contrast to the syncretistic Canaanites, who would have absorbed the Israelites had they stayed in Canaan, Egyptians detested Semitic shepherds out of a sense of ethnic superiority and observed a strict segregation (see [43:32](#)). When Jacob's family settled in Egypt, this separation would allow the people to grow into a great nation without losing their identity.

Genesis 47:1

Goshen (see study note on 45:10) is not referred to in ancient Egyptian texts; the name it bore in later Egyptian writings was "the region of Rameses" ([47:11](#); see [Exod 1:11](#)). It was fertile and near to Joseph at court, which suggests that it was on the eastern side of the Nile delta.

Genesis 47:1–6

Pharaoh responded as Joseph hoped by giving Jacob's family the best part of the land; he even gave some of the brothers oversight of his own livestock ([47:6](#)).

Genesis 47:7–10

When Jacob entered Pharaoh's court and when he left, he blessed Pharaoh, an indication of Jacob's position as God's representative (see [Heb 7:7](#)). God had promised that he would bless those who blessed Abraham's family ([Gen 12:2–3](#)), so he now blessed Pharaoh and Egypt.

Genesis 47:13–26

The Lord blessed Pharaoh because Pharaoh was blessing Abraham's descendants ([12:3](#)). Through Joseph's wise administration in Egypt, the Lord saved the people from starvation and prospered Pharaoh. In selling food to the Egyptians during the years of famine, Joseph accepted money, livestock, and finally land as payment, until almost all of Egypt belonged to Pharaoh. Meanwhile, God provided Israel with some of the best land in Egypt where they could live, work, and multiply.

Genesis 47:21

he made them all slaves: In Hebrew script, the difference is very slight between *slaves* (Hebrew 'abadim) and *towns* (Hebrew 'arim). Moving the people into the towns doesn't fit the context very well, so most translations select *slaves* as the reading that makes the most sense (cp. [47:20](#)).

Genesis 47:27

God blessed his people according to his promise to Abraham that his descendants would be innumerable ([15:5](#); [22:17](#)). They had to wait for the fulfillment of the second promise, that they would own the land of Canaan ([17:8](#)).

Genesis 47:29–31

bury me with my ancestors: Cp. [49:29–33](#). Jacob wanted to be buried with Abraham and Isaac in the cave of Machpelah (see study note on 49:29–33; see [23:1–20](#); [25:7–10](#); [35:27–29](#)). • Put your hand under my thigh: This custom (cp. [24:1–9](#) and study note on 24:2) was a serious oath to carry on the covenant, which had as its main promise innumerable descendants in the Promised Land.

Genesis 47:31

When the oath was taken, Jacob bowed humbly in worship and thanked the Lord for ensuring that he would be buried with his ancestors in the land of promise (cp. [1 Kgs 1:47](#)).

Genesis 48:1–22

In blessing Ephraim and Manasseh, Jacob reached out by faith for the promise to be continued, having learned that God's ways are not always the ways of men. Out of Jacob's long life, the writer to the Hebrews selected the blessing of Joseph's sons as his great act of faith ([Heb 11:21](#)). As Jacob acted in light of God's will, the primary blessing was again given to the younger instead of the older son, but without scheming and its bitter results.

Genesis 48:3-4

Jacob rehearsed how God Almighty had appeared to him and had promised him Abraham's blessing—innumerable descendants dwelling in the land ... as an everlasting possession (cp. [28:10-22](#)).

Genesis 48:5-7

Jacob, prompted by his memory of Rachel (see [35:16-20](#)), blessed Joseph by elevating his two sons as coheirs with his other sons—the tribes of Ephraim and Manasseh would have shares along with the other tribes that came from Jacob (see [Josh 16-17](#)). Jacob also gave Ephraim, Joseph's younger son, the birthright (see [1 Chr 5:1-2](#)). As a result of this blessing, Ephraim and Manasseh became large and powerful tribes (see [Josh 17:14-18](#)).

Genesis 48:10

As Isaac his father had done, Jacob now gave the blessing when his eyesight was failing (cp. [27:1](#)).

Genesis 48:14

The right hand was for the head of the firstborn, and Jacob was deliberately giving that position to the younger son. That pattern was followed for four consecutive generations: Isaac over Ishmael, Jacob over Esau, Joseph over Reuben, and Ephraim over Manasseh. Many years later, Ephraim became the leading tribe in the northern kingdom, superior to the tribe of Manasseh. The entire northern kingdom of Israel was occasionally called Ephraim (see study notes on 2 Chr 28:12; Isa 11:13; Ezek 37:15-28; Hos 6:4; Zech 9:10).

Genesis 48:15-16

In his blessing on Joseph, Jacob used a threefold invocation to describe the God in whom he trusted: (1) the God who was in covenant with his fathers Abraham and Isaac ([28:13](#); [31:5](#), [42](#); [32:9](#); [46:3](#)); (2) the God who had been his shepherd (cp. [49:24](#); [Exod 6:6](#); [Ps 23:1](#); [Isa 59:20](#)); and (3) the Angel who rescued him from all harm. He prayed the same blessings for Joseph's sons.

Genesis 48:17-19

Joseph was upset: He expected God to act according to convention, but faith recognizes that God's ways are not man's ways, and God's thoughts are not man's thoughts. It took Jacob a lifetime to learn this lesson, but he did learn it, and here he acted on it.

Genesis 48:22

Joseph was later buried at Shechem ([Josh 24:32](#)) as a sign that he possessed this bequeathed extra portion (Hebrew shekem) of land. Jacob had apparently conquered this area though the occasion is not mentioned elsewhere.

Genesis 49:1-2

Jacob's words were deliberately chosen prophetic oracles. The days to come refer to the conquest and settlement of the Promised Land, and beyond that to the messianic age. They would all share in the blessing; all the tribes would enter the land with Joshua, but they would not all participate equally.

Genesis 49:1-28

Jacob, by faith and as God's spokesman, looked forward to Israel's settlement in the land, and beyond that to the glorious future. Here at the end of the patriarchal age, he foretold what would happen to each tribe as he evaluated his sons one by one, just as Noah had done at the end of the primeval era (cp. [9:25-27](#)). The character and acts of each ancestor affected the lives of his descendants ([Exod 20:5-6](#); [34:6-7](#); [Num 14:18](#); [Jer 32:18](#)).

Genesis 49:3-4

As firstborn, Reuben was entitled to be head of the family, but because he had the ungoverned impulses of boiling or turbulent waters ([35:22](#)), Jacob prophesied that Reuben would fail in leadership (see [37:21-22](#), [29](#); [42:22](#), [37-38](#); cp. [Judg 5:15-16](#); [1 Chr 5:1-2](#)).

Genesis 49:5-7

Simeon and Levi were violent and lawless; instead of serving justice, they indulged their uncontrolled anger and disregarded life ([34:24-29](#)). • I will scatter them: Simeon's land was largely absorbed into Judah's ([Josh 19:1, 9](#)); Levi was given a more honorable future because the Levites became the priestly tribe (see [Exod 32:25-29](#)), but they had no region of their own ([Josh 21](#)).

Genesis 49:8-12

The blessing on Judah commands the most attention. In this oracle, Jacob predicted the fierce, lion-like dominance of Judah over his enemies and over his brothers, who would praise him (cp. [29:35](#); see, e.g., [Ruth 4:11-12](#); [1 Sam 18:6-7](#); [Pss 2, 45, 72](#); [Isa 11:1-13](#)).

Genesis 49:10

This verse anticipates the kingship in Judah (cp. [17:6, 16](#); [35:11](#)). Although the birthright blessing went to Joseph, Judah would provide Israel's rulers (see [1 Chr 5:1-2](#)). A long line of kings from Judah would retain the scepter, the symbol of rule; the last king would be the one to whom it belongs, the promised Messiah (see [2 Sam 7:4-16](#); [Pss 2, 45, 60](#); [Isa 11](#); [Ezek 21:26-27](#); [Zech 9:9](#); [Rev 5:5](#)). • from his descendants: Literally *from between his feet*, a poetic euphemism for reproductive organs. • until the coming of the one to whom it belongs (Or *until tribute is brought to him and the peoples obey*; traditionally rendered *until Shiloh comes*): These differences arise from ambiguities in the Hebrew text. Rule of Israel belongs to Judah's descendant through David's line ([2 Sam 7:8-16](#)), and he will eventually rule all nations, as signified by the bringing of *tribute* (see [Pss 68:29](#); [72:8-11](#); [Isa 2:2-4](#); [Eph 4:8-10](#)).

Genesis 49:11-12

These descriptions envision the abundance of the Messiah's kingdom (see [Isa 61:6-7](#); [65:21-25](#); [Zech 3:10](#)). When the Messiah comes, there will be paradise-like splendor and abundance on the earth. • He ties his foal to a grapevine: Grapevines will be so abundant that they will be used for hitching posts, and wine will be as abundant as

fresh water (see [Amos 9:13-14](#); [Zech 3:10](#)). • The coming one will have eyes . . . darker than wine and teeth . . . whiter than milk: He will be vigorous and healthy, as will be the era of his rule. Jesus' miracle of changing water into wine ([John 2:1-12](#)), his first sign, was an announcement that the Messiah had come; it was a foretaste of even better things to come.

Genesis 49:13

The oracle said Zebulun would dwell by the sea and be a safe harbor, but in the actual settlement they spread inland (see [Josh 19:10-16](#)). The oracle did not give specific borders for the tribes.

Genesis 49:14-15

Like a sturdy donkey, the tribe of Issachar would be forced to work for others. Issachar was often subjugated by invading armies.

Genesis 49:16-17

Dan was called to provide justice (*Dan* means "judge"), but the tribe would choose treachery, like a snake beside the road (see [Judg 18](#)).

Genesis 49:18

At this point, Jacob interjected an expression of hope. He may have been indirectly reminding his sons of their need for dependence on the Lord or expressing his hope in the Messiah's reign, when he and his descendants would be rescued from all trouble, grief, and human treachery.

Genesis 49:19

Three of the six Hebrew words in this verse are wordplays on the name Gad ("attack"). Gad will be attacked by marauding bands (attackers), but he will attack. The tribes that settled east of the Jordan River frequently experienced border raids (see [Josh 13](#); [2 Kgs 10:32-33](#); [1 Chr 5:18-19](#)).

Genesis 49:20

Asher would be fertile and productive, providing rich foods. The tribe settled along the rich northern coast of Canaan.

Genesis 49:21

Naphtali, like a doe, would be a free mountain people (cp. [Judg 5:18](#)). The tribe settled in the hilly region northwest of the Sea of Galilee.

Genesis 49:22-26

This oracle treats Joseph more expansively than any of the others, for here the main blessing lay (see [1 Chr 5:1-2](#)). Jacob lavished promises of victory and prosperity on Joseph's two tribes. Ephraimites recorded as victorious in battle include Joshua ([Josh 6, 8, 10, 12](#)) and Deborah ([Judg 4](#)). Victorious descendants of Manasseh include Gideon ([Judg 6-8](#)) and Jephthah ([Judg 11:1-12:7](#)).

Genesis 49:24-26

Five names for God introduce five blessings; God is the giver of all good things.

Genesis 49:25

The blessings of the heavens above meant rain for crops. • The blessings of the watery depths were streams and wells of water. • The blessings of the breasts and womb were abundant offspring.

Genesis 49:26

Joseph . . . is a prince among his brothers: a reflection of both his character and his position.

Genesis 49:27

The oracle about Benjamin describes a violent tribe (see [Judg 20](#); [1 Sam 9:1-2](#); [19:10](#); [22:17](#)).

Genesis 49:28

These prophecies are broad in scope, foretelling the future of the different tribes in general terms. Individuals, by faith and obedience, could find great blessing from God regardless of what happened to their clan.

Genesis 49:29-33

Bury me with my father: This grave in the land of Canaan represented hope for the future (cp. [47:29-30](#)). Others buried at the cave of Machpelah near Hebron were Sarah ([23:19](#)), Abraham ([25:7-9](#)), Isaac ([35:27-29](#)), Rebekah, and Leah.

Genesis 49:33

Jacob died at the age of 147 ([47:28](#)), bringing his life of struggle and sorrow to an end. Jacob had always had an unquenchable desire for God's blessing. He had a deep piety that habitually relied on God despite all else. In the end, he died a man of genuine faith. He learned where real blessings come from, and through his faith would be able to hand these on to his sons ([Heb 11:21](#)).

Genesis 50:1-6

As with his father and grandfather, Jacob's death brought the end of an era.

Genesis 50:2

Jacob's body was embalmed for burial in typical Egyptian fashion.

Genesis 50:3

the Egyptians mourned for Jacob for seventy days, just two days short of the mourning period for a pharaoh. This showed the great respect that the Egyptians had for Joseph.

Genesis 50:4-6

Joseph needed Pharaoh's permission to leave his post temporarily to bury his father in Canaan.

Pharaoh readily granted this freedom to the former slave.

Genesis 50:7–9

This was Joseph's first return to his homeland in thirty-nine years. The trip was temporary. Centuries later, the family of Israel would permanently leave Egypt, taking Joseph's bones with them for burial in the land of promise (see [50:25](#)).

Genesis 50:10–13

This journey into Canaan was made in sorrow to bury a man; the next journey into the land would be to live there.

Genesis 50:15–18

The brothers pleaded for Joseph's forgiveness, referring to themselves as Joseph's slaves (cp. [37:7](#); [44:16](#), [33](#)). The brothers were afraid that Joseph's earlier reconciliation with them had been motivated only by his desire to see his father again. With neither Jacob nor Pharaoh to restrain him, they feared that he might now take revenge on them. But Joseph . . . wept because they still feared reprisal.

Genesis 50:19–21

Joseph reassured his brothers that God planned to fulfill the promised blessing (cp. [45:5](#), [7–9](#)), and he promised kindness and provision (cp. [45:11](#)).

Genesis 50:22–23

Joseph lived to see his great-great-grandchildren by Ephraim, and his great-grandchildren by Manasseh—a sign of God's blessing (see [Ps 128:6](#); [Prov 17:6](#); [Isa 53:10](#)).

Genesis 50:23

whom he claimed as his own (literally *who were born on Joseph's knees*): Placing them on his knees

at their birth was a symbolic act signifying that they came from him and belonged to him (cp. [Job 3:12](#)).

Genesis 50:24–25

God will surely come to help you (literally *visit you*): These words of Joseph, given twice, summarize the hope expressed throughout both the Old Testament and the New Testament. God's visitation in the person of the Messiah, the offspring of Abraham, would bring the curse to an end and establish the long-awaited blessing of God in a new creation. The company of the faithful would wait in expectation for that to happen. • Like his father before him, Joseph made his brothers promise that his bones would be taken out of Egypt when God would come to take them (to help you and lead you back) to Canaan (see [Exod 13:19](#); [Josh 24:32](#); [Heb 11:22](#)).

Genesis 50:26

Joseph's death signified the end of his generation (see study notes on 25:7–8; 35:1–29) and of the patriarchal age. From this point forward, God dealt with Israel as a nation. • Joseph's body was kept in Egypt as a pledge of hope for slaves awaiting the Promised Land (see [Exod 13:19](#); [Heb 11:39–40](#)). He was eventually buried in Shechem (see [Josh 24:32](#)), where Jacob had originally sent him ([Gen 37:13](#)).